



Hindustan Times

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Terror in the air: Pilot stabs Indian captain in cockpit

Dubai-Tel Aviv flight diverted to Saudi; Israeli PM hails Capt Machchhar's heroics

HTC and Agencies
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NEW DELHI/MUMBAI/DUBAI: The co-pilot of a flydubai flight from Dubai to Tel Aviv allegedly stabbed the captain on Wednesday morning, triggering a battle in the cockpit during which the Boeing 737 MAX 8 plunged 14,300 feet in roughly 30 seconds over northern Saudi Arabia. The jet broadcast a hijack alert and diverted to Tabuk, where it landed safely, and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu credited its wounded Indian captain with fighting back and opening the cockpit door so that passengers and crew could overpower the attacker.

The captain, Smit Machchhar, is from Ghatkopar East in Mumbai and was based in Dubai for work, people aware of the matter told HT. Both pilots were hospitalised, Tabuk Airport said. Machchhar underwent surgery and is stable, while the other pilot, whose name was not known at the time of going to press, was arrested by Saudi authorities.

In a post on X, Netanyahu saluted Machchhar's "extraordinary bravery". "Despite being stabbed and seriously injured, he fought back, resisted, opened the cockpit door, and enabled passengers and crew to overpower the attacker — preventing a catastrophic mid-air disaster," he wrote. "He saved the lives of 174 people, including Israeli citizens and other nationals."



Passengers disembark from the plane at Ben Gurion International Airport in Israel.



Captain Smit Machchhar

In an earlier video message, Netanyahu said the pilot who attacked his colleague wanted to crash the airliner, and that another crew that happened to be on board stabilised the aircraft after the attacker was subdued. It was not clear if this was indeed the case or

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SC rules out blanket cracker ban: 'It will hurt sentiments'

Utkarsh Anand and Abraham Thomas

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Wednesday permitted the use of "green" firecracker chains, refused to impose a total ban on



AIR WE BREATHE

firecrackers saying that this would hurt public sentiments, and gave the Centre and expert bodies time till

October 15 to complete their assessment of the impact of barium content in other green crackers on ambient air quality.

The court's decision once again raises questions on

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Green crackers have a poor record

What is a green cracker
● Formulations developed by CSIR-NEERI after a 2018 SC ruling

● They drop potassium nitrate, sulphur and barium
● They cut emissions by 30-40%, by NEERI's own estimate

Hard to spot
● Green certification rests on QR codes and packaging
● Both have been faked

Enforcement record
● In 2025, the Commission for Air Quality Management told the court there was no way to verify products in the market
● PESO had no testing facility in Delhi
● In 2018 and 2019, police could not tell green crackers from conventional ones

Last Diwali
● Avg PM2.5 peaked at 785.6 µg/m³, the worst since 2021
● The peak came despite warm weather and few farm fires

This year
● Diwali falls on November 8, at the height of the farm-fire season, when calmer air traps pollution

DELHI MAY SEE A 2025 POLLUTION REPEAT DUE TO NOD FOR GREEN FIRECRACKERS

The Supreme Court's order permitting specified next-generation green crackers could expose the Capital to worse levels of pollution if trends from last year are an indication: 2025 was the first in many years when any firecrackers were allowed and it went on to become the most polluted in five years despite favourable weather conditions.

For years, firecrackers had been banned in Delhi through the peak pollution months. In October 2025, the SC allowed NEERI-approved green crackers for three days around Diwali, within fixed hours. The relaxation was meant to be a controlled opening. Instead, crackers of every kind flooded the market and were burst.

Trade, defence, energy ties in focus as Modi, Trump talk

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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi dialled US President Donald Trump on Wednesday to assess cooperation in key areas such as trade, defence, energy, critical technologies and other areas. "We agreed to maintain close engagement to take our Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership forward," he said.

The two leaders also discussed regional and international issues, including ongoing efforts to advance global peace and security, Modi said.



Narendra Modi, Donald Trump



the US remain engaged in negotiations on a bilateral trade deal.

Modi described his conversation with Trump in a social media post as productive and said they reviewed bilateral cooperation in trade, defence, energy, critical technologies and other areas. "We agreed to maintain close engagement to take our Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership forward," he said.

The two leaders also discussed regional and international issues, including ongoing efforts to advance global peace and security, Modi said.

MONSOON RAIN OVER INDIA 4TH LOWEST SINCE 2001, LARGE PARTS DRY

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NEW DELHI: India's southwest monsoon ended on Wednesday with rainfall 12.6% below normal. The country recorded 759.4mm of rain during June-September, making it the fourth-lowest monsoon rainfall since 2001, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD). According to IMD data, the monsoon had a weak start, with rainfall remaining sharply below normal through much of June and early July. The weekly deficit touched 51.1% in the week ending July 15.

New Chandra-Venu link: Push for tech park to serve TVS

mint

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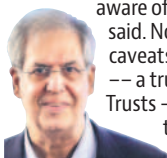
BENGALURU/MUMBAI: A company owned by the family of Tata Sons chairman N Chandrasekaran is pursuing a ₹330-crore industrial park in Karnataka to serve automaker TVS Motor Co., marking its second such project involving the two-wheeler maker, whose chairman-emeritus Venu Srinivasan backed Chandrasekaran for a third term at the helm of Tata Sons.

In November 2025, Hanno One Warehousing Pvt. Ltd, owned by Chandrasekaran's wife Lalitha, and son Pranav, approached Karnataka's Land Audit Committee for 35 acres in the state-run Immavu industrial area about 20km south of Mysuru. The meeting's minutes describe the project as an 'industrial park for auto component manufacturing and supply for TVS Motors and their tier-1 suppliers'. Hanno's latest financial statements show the Karnataka Industrial Areas Development Board (KIADB), which buys and develops industrial land, has allotted it land for about ₹27 crore, of which it paid ₹7.91 crore in FY26.

Neither Chandrasekaran nor

NOEL, NEVILLE MOVE TO SHIELD TRUSTS AS TATA ROW ESCALATES

Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata and his son Neville have filed a string of caveats with the Maharashtra charity commissioner, seeking to ensure they are heard before the regulator acts on complaints by vice-chairman Venu Srinivasan over the management of the trusts, two executives aware of the details said. Noel has filed 21 caveats, while Neville — a trustee of 5 Trusts — has filed 15, they said.



Srinivasan have informed the Tata Sons board about this business relationship. Tata Sons had earlier said the transactions did not need to be placed before its board.

Hanno does not count as a related party of TVS Motor under Indian law, because Chandrasekaran is not a TVS director. That keeps the deals out of TVS's related-party disclosures and leaves the duty to disclose with the two boards: Tata Sons and Tata Trusts.

The lack of disclosure has prompted corporate governance experts to question whether it is a conflict of interest and a breach of the Tata Code of Conduct.



The Indian men's compound archery team celebrates after winning gold at the 2026 Asian Games.

Quivers full of gold: Archers shoot India back into top 10

Rutvik Mehta

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MUMBAI: At an Asian Games where India have been starved of gold medals — the first 10 days yielded just six — the country's archers delivered three on Wednesday. India won the mixed team, women's team and men's team gold medals in archery.

Compound archery's mixed team event paired Chikitha Taniparthi with Sahil Jadhav: two diametrically opposite char-

acters. In Maharashtra's Satara, Sahil's coach knew exactly what would fire up his ward before the final. On Wednesday morning, he sent him a picture of the Indian flag at their training ground. In Japan's Aichi, when the Indian flag was raised in the afternoon, Chikitha barely broke into a half-smile. Her almost nonchalant reaction would become the talk of the

Indian archery coaching group. From this mixed tango of a visibly animated 25-year-old and a seemingly detached

21-year-old came an archery gold with added significance at the 2026 Asian Games: a berth at the newly introduced compound mixed team event at the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics.

Sahil and Chikitha clinched the mixed team compound gold, keeping their nerve to hold off a rally by South Koreans Park Jung-yoon and Choi Yong-hee and win the final in a tense shoot-off after the scores were tied at 157-157.

The compound mixed team event will debut at the 2028 Los Angeles Games, and with their

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MEERUT: WOMAN, FRIEND CONVICTED IN '25 'BLUE DRUM' MURDER CASE

MEERUT: A district court in Meerut on Wednesday convicted Muskan Rastogi and her partner Sahil Shukla for the murder of her husband and merchant navy officer Saurabh Rajput, whose body was found hidden inside a blue drum in March last year.

The murder drew widespread attention after the prosecution alleged that Rajput's body was cut into pieces and placed inside a large blue plastic drum before being sealed with cement.

The two were found guilty of murder, destruction of evidence and criminal conspiracy.

{ INDIA'S BIGGEST RUN CHASE }

Gill smashes fastest ODI double ton in rout of WI

NEW DELHI: Shubman Gill smashed the fastest double century in ODI history as India recorded the format's second-highest chase of all time on Wednesday to beat the West Indies by eight wickets.

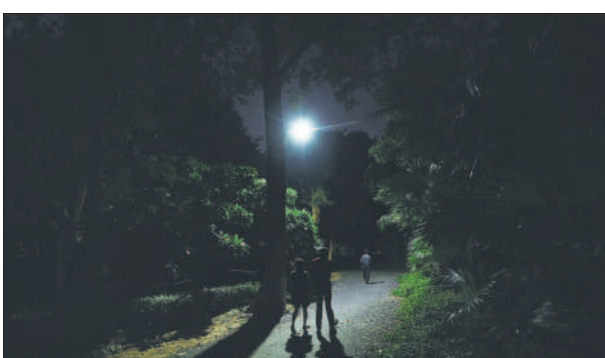
West Indies posted 405-7 after three centuries in the innings, but India rode on a 255-run opening stand between Gill (223*) and Rohit Sharma (101) to achieve the target with 39 balls to spare in Guwahati as they took an unassailable 2-0 lead in the

three-match series. South Africa hold the record for the highest successful run chase in men's ODI cricket, scoring 438-9 against Australia in Johannesburg in 2006.

India's previous best chase was 362 against Australia in Jaipur in 2019.

Gill, who hit 110 in the opening win, went past his previous ODI best of 208 and reached his second double ton in 117 balls for the fastest 200 in ODI history. He hit 26 fours and eight sixes in 133 balls.

1k sites, 42 guards, no cameras: MCD seeks govt help to plug gaps in its largest parks



A poorly lit stretch inside Roshanara Park. During a recent spot check of parks, HT found several gaps, including dark stretches, non-functional lights and shortage of guards.

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NEW DELHI: More than 15,000 parks, including over 1,000 bigger than an acre, but just 42 guards and not a single CCTV camera under the Municipal Corporation of Delhi — this is the security challenge facing the civic body's parks as it moves to strengthen safety following last week's gang rape of a 17-year-old at Aastha Kunj.

Officials said the two measures are being prioritised after the September 21 incident. MCD has approached the Delhi government to assess the feasibility of install-

ing CCTV cameras in around 1,000 of its larger parks. It is also preparing a proposal to deploy more guards. A senior MCD official said the initial CCTV plan would focus on entry and exit points, though the larger challenge would be monitoring the footage. "These parks will need around 2,000 guards..." the official added.

The push comes amid renewed scrutiny of security in city parks. During a recent spot check of 12 large parks, HT found several gaps, including dark stretches, non-functional lights, shortage of guards, broken boundary walls and inadequate CCTV coverage.

PUNJAB CONG CHIEF WARRING OFFERS TO RESIGN

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CHANDIGARH: Punjab Congress president Amarinder Singh Raja Warring has offered to resign from his post after weeks of factionalism in the state unit, party sources said on Wednesday.

SP RS POLL PICK'S GUJARAT LINKS CREATES A BUZZ

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LUCKNOW: The SP on Wednesday named Ram Gopal Yadav and Dhanraj Parimal Nathwani as its RS poll candidates, with the latter's candidature creating buzz because of his corporate profile and links to Gujarat political circles.

CHARGES FRAMED AGAINST SOREN IN LAND FRAUD CASE

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RANCHI: A special court in Ranchi on Wednesday framed charges against Jharkhand CM Hemant Soren, paving the way for the trial in a PMLA case related to an alleged 8.86-acre land fraud, people familiar with the matter said.

{ MY INDIA } 4 KILLED IN FRATRICIDE
Spat over kid at work sparked CISF killings



The argument that led to a Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) head constable shooting dead four of his colleagues apparently concerned the presence of his child at their workplace, a hydropower project near the border in Jammu and Kashmir's Kathua, people familiar with the matter said. In one version of the event, an officer said, the head constable, Avdesh Kumar, brought his child to work at the Sewa Hydel Power project in Kathua on Tuesday evening, which led to the argument with his company commander and three colleagues. Another version of events indicated that Kumar's wife, Pooja, also a CISF head constable and posted at the same project, brought the child to work. →P8

{ MY INDIA } PMLA PROBE
ED arrests Vatika Group promoters



The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has arrested the promoter and the chairman of Gurugram-based realty firm Vatika Group in connection with a money laundering probe linked to alleged fraud with homebuyers, the agency said. Anil Bhalla, chairman-cum-managing director, and Gautam Bhalla, promoter, were taken into custody under the PMLA Act on Monday and were produced before a special court in the city. ED said its probe stems from a Delhi Police FIR against the Vatika Group and the promoters, which alleged fraudulent inducement, non-delivery of residential plots and related offences. →P12

{ MY INDIA } COPS SEARCH FOR MISSING CARETAKER
Ex-IAS officer murdered at home in Bhopal; probe on



A 70-year-old retired IAS officer was found dead at his residence in Surajnagar area of Bhopal in Madhya Pradesh on Wednesday, with police suspecting that his newly hired caretaker, who is missing, was involved in his murder. According to officials, Rakesh Agarwal was allegedly attacked with a sharp-edged weapon and his throat was slit, with police suspecting the involvement of his caretaker Varun Kumar. "Kumar has been missing since the incident and his belongings were also not found in the house," Shailendra Chauhan, additional commissioner of police, Bhopal, said. "Kumar had been hired as a caretaker. His duties included administering medication on time and fetching supplies." HTc

{ MY INDIA } NANDIGRAM BYPOLL
WB moves SC against bail to Cong candidate



A day after the Calcutta High Court granted interim bail to Congress's Nandigram assembly bypoll candidate Milan Pradhan, the West Bengal government on Wednesday moved the Supreme Court seeking an immediate stay on the order, arguing that a murder accused with six non-bailable warrants (NBWs) against him should not have been given such relief. The top court agreed to list the matter for hearing on October 5. Meanwhile, Pradhan walked out of the jail in the afternoon and said he would immediately start campaigning for the October 6 by-election. →P5

{ MY INDIA } OIL REFINERY FIRE
1 killed, 12 injured in blast at MRPL facility



A 23-year-old contract worker was killed and 12 others were injured after a blast at Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals Limited's (MRPL) Coker Hydro Treating Unit in Dakshina Kannada district of Karnataka on Wednesday, officials said. The explosion occurred at about 12.20 pm when the unit's cold separator exploded, said Rudolph VJ Noronha, chief general manager, corporate branding and corporate communications, MRPL. The firm's emergency response and firefighting teams isolated the affected unit and brought the blaze under control, he added. The deceased was identified as Manish Karkada. "He was missing after the blast, and his charred body was found hours after the explosion," Noronha said. →P7

{ 17TH DRIEST SINCE 1901 }

Limp monsoon that left swathes of India bone dry

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Wednesday marked the end of the four-month-long south-west monsoon, which normally accounts for 75% of India's annual rainfall. How was the rainfall performance this season? Bad is the short answer, with total monsoon rainfall being the 17th lowest since 1901 (earliest available data). This detailed analysis explains exactly what this entails.

A month of surplus rain did not ease the El Nino pain

An early El Nino—a cyclical warming of the central eastern equatorial Pacific Ocean that crimps monsoon rain—meant that rainfall would be underwhelming. According to the India Meteorological Department's (IMD) real-time gridded data, India received 767mm rainfall this monsoon in terms of area weighted average. This is the 17th lowest monsoon rainfall for since 1901 and 10.5% below the 1971-2020 average for the same period, which IMD currently considers as the Long Period Average (LPA) for tracking monsoon rain. This also makes the 2026 monsoon the driest since 2009, when India got 722mm rain by weighted average. Only July recorded a surplus plus West Bengal, although the deficit was relatively small in September too. To be sure, IMD's published statistics may show slightly differ-

ent numbers because they use a somewhat different method for computing India averages.

39% of the country's area has drought-like conditions
There is no uniform definition of drought in India. This is because the term has practical implications for agriculture, and vegetation stress is not guided by rainfall alone. One rainfall-based definition sometimes used in Mausam (the quarterly research journal of IMD) defines a 26%-50% rainfall deficit over LPA as a "moderate" drought and more than 50% deficit as a "severe" drought.

The gridded data shows that 39% of the country is in drought, with 11.7% in the severe range. The area under drought is the 17th highest since 1901 and the area under severe drought is the 25th highest. (See Chart 1)

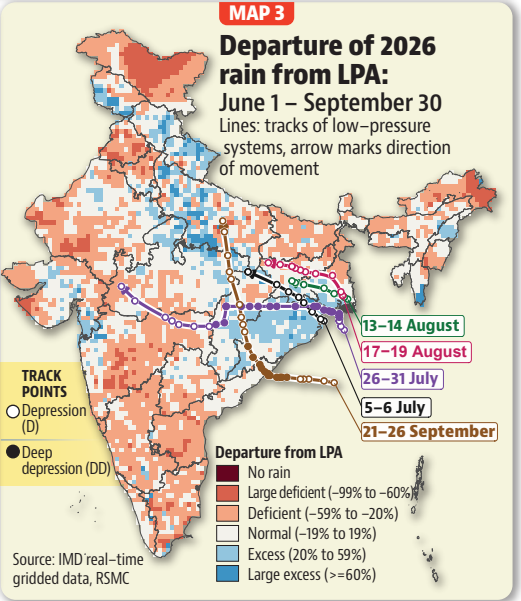
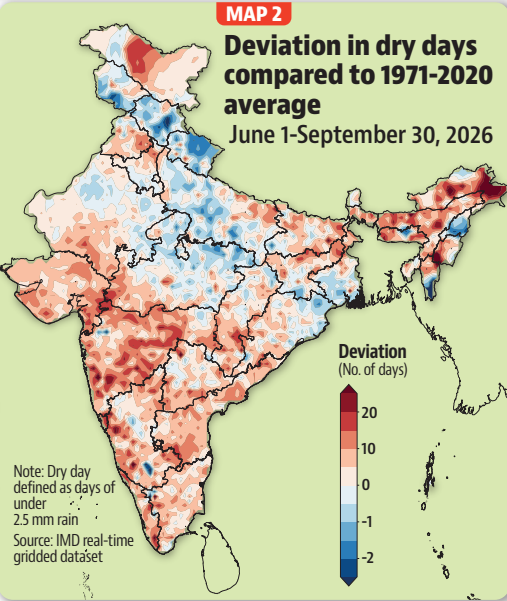
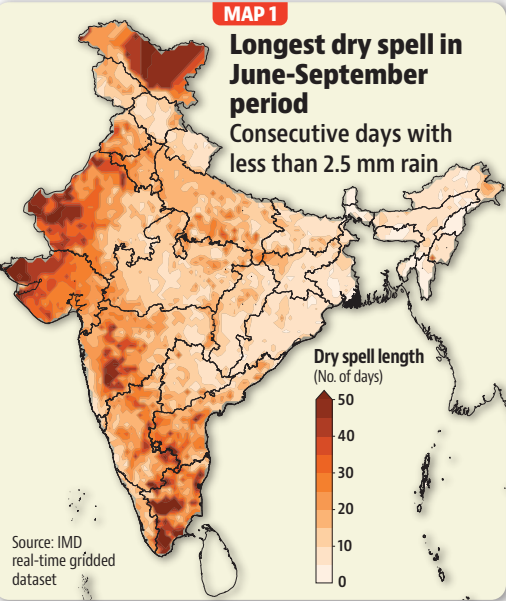
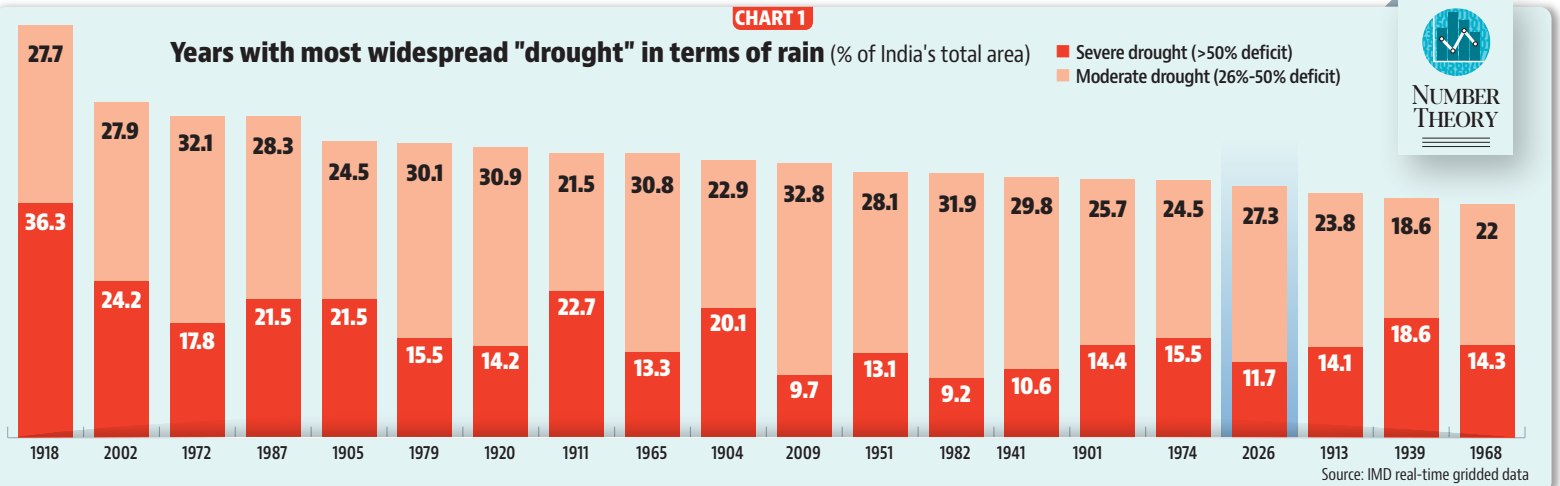
Long dry spells were the norm in western and peninsular India

This can be seen by tracking dry days or days of rain under 2.5mm. Parts of Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Maharashtra, Gujarat, and Rajasthan saw the longest dry spell—consecutive dry days—stretch longer than 50 days. At least half of the area of most states also saw more dry days this monsoon than in the 1971-2020 average. The only exceptions were Uttar Pradesh, West Bengal, and Madhya Pradesh among big states, and even here, 39%-48% of the area saw more dry days than normal. (See Maps 1 and 2)

Low-pressure systems kept parts of eastern and central India wet

While a drought-like dryness leads to water stress, it does not mean agriculture will be completely doomed. Some parts, such as the Indo-Gangetic plains, are well-irrigated. On the other hand, parts of these plains faced floods. IMD defines a surplus of 20%-59% as "excess" and of at least 60% as "large excess". Deficits of the same degree are called "deficient" and "large deficient", with deviation up to 19% of LPA called "normal". 52.7% of the country ended up in the normal and excess categories for June-September. But that was because of monsoon low-pressure systems that travelled from the Bay of Bengal to bring excess rain in the July-September period. Odisha and parts of Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, and Uttar Pradesh were the most affected by storms of this kind. Another peculiarity this monsoon was the flooding in Bihar, though most of the state was deficient even from July to September. This was because of floods in rivers and tributaries that flow to the state either from Nepal or its neighbouring states. This means crop damage and likely headwinds to farm incomes and tailwinds to inflation not just on account of low rain but also more rain than what was needed. (See Map 3)

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'Dangerous path': Govt warns Indians against joining Russian forces

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NEW DELHI: India on Wednesday emphasised the dangers faced by Indian nationals recruited into Russia's armed forces, including hiring by "non-public entities", and said it was engaged with the Russian side to ensure the early discharge of citizens. The fresh advisory for Indians travelling to Russia was issued by the external affairs ministry against the backdrop of the death of 51 Indians while serving with the Russian military on the front lines of the conflict in Ukraine, and New Delhi seeking the discharge of about two dozen Indians still with the Russian armed forces.

The advisory noted that there were still reports of Indian nationals being recruited into the Russian armed forces and said the government had "underlined the risks and dangers inherent in this course of action" on several occasions over the past two years and advised Indian citizens "to be cautious" in pursuing job opportunities abroad and not get lured by "job offers from unverified individuals".

"It has also come to our notice that foreign nationals are being recruited to serve in the Russian armed forces by non-public entities including voluntary groups", the advisory said. Indian nationals were advised to exercise due diligence before accepting job offers from agents not registered with the external affairs ministry. There have also been numerous instances of individuals

"willingly seeking out offers to join the Russian armed forces with an understanding that they would be able to avail concomitant monetary benefits, and later secure release by approaching the Indian government", the advisory noted. "The ministry made it clear that 'this is a dangerous path' that is strongly discouraged by the government.

Referring to numerous instances of individuals approaching Indian authorities to "willingly give up their Indian citizenship, avail a Russian passport and then get recruited in Russian armed forces", the advisory said some Indian nationals had already resorted to this course of action without consulting Indian authorities after being lured by temporary monetary benefits.

"It is advised that individuals should consider the gravity of such actions and understand the mortal dangers they are exposing themselves to. The government advises Indian nationals to refrain from taking such actions," the advisory said.

The Indian government remains engaged with the Russian side to ensure the safety, well-being and early discharge of all Indian nationals in the Russian armed forces, the advisory said.

Reports of Indian nationals being recruited into Russia's military began to emerge about two years after the Russian invasion of Ukraine. The Central Bureau of Investigation is currently probing cases of fraudulent recruitment of Indians in the Russian military and has made some arrests.

From OG to Gen Z, India's women quarter-milers Asia's track queens

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MUMBAI: When Vithya Ramraj charged to the dazzling anchor leg run that kept even a sizzling Salwa Eid Naser at bay in the women's 4x400m relay final in Nagoya, a sexagenarian sitting in front of a TV screen in Kerala on Tuesday night felt like she was running once again.

"I was so thrilled. When she was running in that last stretch, I thought I was running again, like the old times," Shiny Abraham Wilson told HT on Wednesday morning.

Shiny was one of the OGs, as Gen Z calls it now. From the famed golden quartet that scripted Indian athletics' only top finish at the 2026 Asian Games, two are Gen Zs: Vithya and Kiran Pahal. Prachi Choudhary is 29 and MR Poovamma, the oldest, is 36.

This generation could run towards Asian supremacy after Shiny's generation walked. And not just walked, but built the foundation of a solid legacy for Indian quarter-milers that stood tall for years, dipped a touch, and resurrected its hold at the continental stage.

PT Usha, Shiny, Vandana Rao and MD Valsamma were the trendsetters who won India's first Asian Games gold medal in the women's 4x400m relay in the 1986 Seoul edition. Four decades later, after five more top-of-the-pile finishes from the 2002 to 2018 Asian Games, the fabulous four of 2026 brought back the

gold after the Hangzhou silver three years ago.

"We were the leading country in this event, and these girls have done a fantastic job of putting India back up there," Shiny, now 61, said over the phone.

It's symbolic, and almost fitting, that Indian women delivered two creditable individual medals from one-lap races (Vithya 400m hurdles bronze and Prachi 400m bronze) at the Nagoya City Mizuho Park Athletic Stadium in the presence of PT Usha. India's legendary sprinter and current Indian Olympic Association (IOA) president could gleam with pride when Vithya broke her 42-year-old 400m hurdles national record.

"... There is no greater reward for an athlete than to see the next generation go beyond the boundaries we once set," Usha posted on X when Vithya broke the record.

On the women's relay gold, the Indian track legend had this to say: "Watching our incredible 4x400m women's relay team storm to a Gold medal finish brought back a flood of memories. I could feel every single stride, every heartbeat, and every ounce of grit out there on the track. Decades ago, we ran to show the world what Indian women could do. Today, these champions ran to rule the world. To see them standing on top of the podium, hearing our national anthem resonate through the stadium—there is no greater emotion for an athlete."



Track legend PT Usha with India's 2026 Asian Games gold-winning women's 4x400m team. X-P.T. USHA

And there was no greater woman trailblazer on the track than Usha, who fell 0.01 seconds short of a podium finish at the 1984 Los Angeles Olympics in the 400m hurdles clocking 55.42 seconds, a national record that stood until Vithya broke it on Monday. Two years later, Usha made the 1986 Seoul Asian Games her very own, bagging a hat-trick of individual titles in the 200m, 400m and 400m hurdles. Usha, Shiny, Vandana and Valsamma combined to end Japan's reign in the women's 4x400m relay since the event was introduced in the

Asian Games in 1974. The quartet not just broke a nation's monopoly, but also the Games record. Their timing of 3:34.58 pipped Japan (3:39.77), who had beaten India for gold in the previous 1982 Games in New Delhi, and China (3:41.59).

"I remember we had a huge lead for first place, and were about 30-40 metres ahead at the finish line," recalled Shiny, who also won the 400m silver in Seoul. "That medal, and the timing, underlined our status as the best in Asia at that time."

That status had its early writ-

ing at the 1985 Asian Championships in Jakarta, where India took the gold, beating Japan again.

"Hard work, a lot of hard work," said Shiny, rather simply, when asked what went behind making the Indian female quarter-milers so good back then.

"In the previous year itself (1985), we were breaking national records. Athletes like Usha and I were reaching world-class level then. And we could sense that we were creating a bit of a gap between us and the rest of the Asian nations."

That gap bridged over the next

three Asian Games editions, with China beating India for gold in 1990, 1994 and 1998. And it widened again over the next five.

India's women quarter-milers set the pace and won consecutive gold medals through the 2002 Busan and 2018 Jakarta and Palembang games. Poovamma was part of the 2014 and 2018 packs—also featuring the likes of Tintu Luka and Hima Das—that brought home the gold.

Bahrain was a rising threat in the event, and leapt to gold while pushing India to silver in Hangzhou. Prachi and Vithya were two from the current lot who returned with the feeling of coming second-best in Hangzhou. Three years on, that feeling kept them motivated, as did the fact that no Indian track and field athlete had won gold in Japan heading into the final day of events.

"Everybody has been saying that there was no gold medal in athletics, so we were motivated to win the gold for the country," Prachi was quoted as saying by PTI in Nagoya. "I was part of the relay team when we got silver the last time. At that time, we thought that we will win a gold medal in the Asian Games the next time."

When that time came, in the final few seconds that mattered, Salwa threatened to make the near-impossible possible again with her anchor leg burst. Kiran, Poovamma, Prachi and Vithya collectively ensured that one of India's strongest legacies in track and field in Asia was back to where it belonged.

"I am so, so happy that we have won the gold again," said Shiny.

MY BENGALURU

12-YEAR-OLD BOY RIDING PILLION ON BIKE KILLED IN B'LURU ACCIDENT

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BENGALURU: A 12-year-old boy died after the two-wheeler he was travelling on with his grandfather allegedly lost balance and fell on the road when a car suddenly came in their path here on Wednesday, police said.

The deceased was identified as Dikshith, they said.

The accident took place on Kurudusonnenahalli Main Road under the jurisdiction of the K R Puram Traffic Police Station, police said.

According to police, the accident happened when his grandfather was returning home after picking up his two grandchildren from school on a two-wheeler.

While they were travelling on Kurudusonnenahalli Main Road, the grandfather allegedly lost control of the two-wheeler after a car suddenly came across their path, causing the vehicle to fall onto the road, a senior police officer.

Dikshith suffered severe head injuries in the accident and as a result died on the spot, he said.

K R Puram Traffic Police personnel visited the spot and conducted an inspection.

Further investigation into the incident is underway to ascertain the exact sequence of accident, police said.

1 killed, 12 injured in explosion at oil refinery in Mangaluru

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MANGALURU: A high pressure separator at the Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals Limited (MRPL) refinery in Mangaluru ruptured on Wednesday, triggering an explosion and fire that killed a contract worker, left another with serious burns and injured 11 others, according to MRPL.

The explosion took place at about 12.20 pm at the refinery's Coker Hydro Treating Unit. The Cold Separator was operating at about 70 bar pressure when it ruptured, triggering the fire. MRPL's emergency response and firefighting teams isolated the affected unit and brought the blaze under control.

The deceased was identified as Manish Karkada, 23, a contract worker from Mulki. Dr Rudolph VJ Noronha, chief general manager, corporate branding and corporate communications, MRPL, said Karkera was reported missing after the explosion and his body was found several hours later.

"He was missing after the blast, and his charred body was found hours after the explosion," Noronha said.

Rajesh Baptist, another



The explosion took place at about 12.20 pm at the Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals Limited refinery's Coker Hydro Treating Unit in Mangaluru on Wednesday.

worker, suffered burns over about 35% of his body and was admitted to the Intensive Care Unit of a private hospital in Kankanady. "Doctors said he is out of danger," Noronha said.

Eleven people working in an adjacent office suffered minor injuries and were treated on an outpatient basis, he said.

"The battery limits of the affected unit have been isolated, and MRPL's emergency

response and firefighting teams are actively engaged in controlling and dousing the fire. The fire has been brought under control," Noronha said.

Fire tenders from the Fire and Emergency Services and the New Mangalore Port Authority were sent to the refinery.

Cooling and firefighting operations continued after the main blaze was brought under

control as part of efforts to make the affected unit safe.

The blast was heard across several areas around the refinery. Residents reported a deafening sound followed by thick black smoke. Some residents said windows and gates of nearby houses were damaged by the force of the blast.

The explosion was also heard in areas around Mangaluru International Airport. The

airport carried out visual checks of critical infrastructure, including peripheral roads and its Precision Approach Lighting Category I system, after the district administration advised the inspection. Airport operations continued normally.

Karnataka chief minister D K Shivakumar said he had instructed officials to ascertain the exact cause of the explosion and submit a report.

"I hope all the injured recover soon. The safety of people and workers is a major priority of our government," Shivakumar said.

Dakshina Kannada deputy commissioner Darshan HV, police commissioner Sudheer Kumar Reddy and zilla panchayat chief executive officer Narwade Vinayak Karbhari visited the refinery to assess the situation and oversee the response.

Officials said there was no immediate cause for major concern outside the affected unit. An investigation is underway to determine the precise reason for the separator rupture.

Videos showing flames and thick smoke rising from the refinery circulated widely after the explosion.

Chennai-based bizman held in fake meds case

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BENGALURU: A Chennai based pharmaceutical distributor and business associate of alleged counterfeit drug racket kingpin Prashanth Rajanbabu has been arrested by the Karnataka Special Investigation Team, becoming the seventh person taken into custody in the case.

The accused, Balasubramanian, was arrested in Chennai was brought to Bengaluru for questioning on Wednesday.

He was a partner in DM Pharma, the pharmaceutical distribution company set up by Rajanbabu, his wife and Balasubramanian in 2021.

His arrest followed the interrogation of Rajanbabu, who was taken into custody at Kempegowda International Airport on Monday after arriving in Bengaluru. Balasubramanian was remanded to seven days of SIT custody.

"We suspect that Balasubramanian received consignments of counterfeit medicines from Rajanbabu and another accused, Veeresh, and distributed them in Chennai and other locations. We are examining the movement of these consignments, the financial transactions linked to them and the companies used in the distribution chain," said a senior officer.

DM Pharma, based in Chennai, supplied medicines to hospitals and drug stores. Investigators suspect the company was used to move counterfeit medicines alongside genuine products, allowing the fake stock to pass through the regular pharmaceutical supply chain without attracting immediate attention, the officer added.

The SIT is also examining another company allegedly operated by Balasubramanian and its possible role in the distribution of the counterfeit medicines. Investigators have widened their inquiry to hospitals that purchased medicines from those linked to the case. Notices have been issued seeking details of

INVESTIGATORS HAVE WIDENED THEIR INQUIRY TO HOSPITALS THAT PURCHASED MEDICINES FROM THOSE LINKED TO THE CASE

their purchases, while the SIT is examining the roles of dealers, distributors and buyers in the supply chain.

The case began with the seizure of counterfeit medicines, machinery, packaging material and other stock from an alleged illegal manufacturing facility near Bidadi. The Karnataka food safety and drugs administration department subsequently cancelled the licences of 16 drug wholesalers and retailers over their alleged involvement in the distribution and sale of counterfeit medicines. The licences of eight establishments were also suspended.

Rajanbabu, who is from Shivamogga and lives in Papareddypalya in Bengaluru, was arrested a day before his associate. Officials said he had worked as a medical representative in New Delhi, Hyderabad and Chennai for over 10 years before establishing DM Pharma. Investigators said Rajanbabu had knowledge of medicines in high demand, their market prices and profit margins. They alleged that he later began manufacturing counterfeit medicines after identifying an opportunity to make large profits.

A farmhouse near Tavarekere in Bengaluru South district was allegedly rented in 2025 for manufacturing the fake medicines. Raw materials were brought from Uttarakhand and other states, officials said.

The counterfeit products allegedly carried the names of established pharmaceutical companies and were supplied to hospitals and drug stores through organisations including Krupa Pharma.

Magadi Lake in Chikkamagaluru



A grey heron stands with cormorants at Magadi Lake in Chikkamagaluru on Wednesday.

KPSC scam candidates gave blank cheques for favourable selection: ED

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BENGALURU: Candidates allegedly paid tens of lakhs of rupees for favourable selection in the Karnataka Public Service Commission's veterinary officers recruitment examination and were then made to sign over blank cheques and promissory notes to secure the unpaid balance, according to the Enforcement Directorate.

The agency, in an account of its investigation released on Wednesday, said the amount initially demanded from candidates was around ₹80 lakh but was later negotiated to between ₹30 lakh and ₹40 lakh each. Part of the money was collected in advance through cash and bank transfers, while blank signed cheques and promissory notes were obtained from some candidates for the remaining amounts. The ED said some of those documents were recovered during searches and seized as part of its investigation.

The agency is investigating alleged manipulation of the KPSC examination for 400 veterinary officers posts. Multiple FIRs were registered at Vidhana Soudha police station in Bengaluru under provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) relating to cheating, forgery and use of forged documents.

The investigation has centred on Basavaraj Kannale and Gyanendra Kumar Gangwar, who was the KPSC controller of examinations when the alleged paper leak took place.

According to ED, Kannale and his associates allegedly arranged for candidates to receive a leaked question paper containing correct answers in return for illegal gratification. The agency said Kannale obtained access to the paper through Gangwar, responsible for custody and supervision

of confidential exam material.

The ED arrested Kannale on September 17 under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act. He was subsequently produced before the special PMLA court, which granted the agency 14 days' custody. Gangwar was arrested a day later, on September 18. The ED alleged he had used his official position to facilitate the leakage of the examination paper to Kannale one day before the scheduled examination in return for illegal gratification. He was produced before the special PMLA court on September 21 and was also remanded to 14 days of ED custody.

The agency also traced a bank account of Om Lakshmi Souharda Sahakari Sangha Niyamitha in Bidar, which it said was used to receive some of the money connected with the alleged illegal gratification. A separate part of the ED investigation concerns what happened to the money after it was collected.

The agency said analysis of material seized during searches conducted between August 18 and August 24 showed proceeds allegedly generated through the recruitment racket were moved through several channels. These included bank transfers, purchases of gold jewellery and other cash transactions. The ED said transactions were intended to conceal the nature and source of the proceeds and make them appear to be legitimate property.

"Analysis of material seized during searches conducted from August 18 to 24 revealed the proceeds generated from aforesaid criminal activity were subsequently layered and utilised through various modes, including bank transfers, purchase of gold jewellery and cash transactions, with the object of concealing nature and source of proceeds and projecting the same as untainted property," it said.

19-YR-OLD B'LURU COLLEGE STUDENT STABBED TO DEATH DURING CLASH

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BENGALURU: A 19-year-old college student died after he was stabbed in the chest during a clash between two groups of students near Deepa Complex in Bengaluru on Wednesday afternoon, police said.

The incident took place between 2.30 pm and 3 pm in an area near a gym behind the private college where the student was studying, within the limits of Annapoorneshwari Nagar police station. Police said they have clues about those involved and are trying to trace them.

"The incident took place around 2.30 to 3 pm on Wednesday due to enmity," DCP N Yethish told HT. "Soon after the stabbing, the injured student was shifted to a nearby private hospital, but he died while undergoing treatment. The accused absconded after the incident. We have definite clues about the accused and would nab them soon," he added.

The student, a first year BCom student, had attended college as usual on Wednesday. Police said another student from the same college called him and asked him to come outside to speak. He later went to the area behind the college, where about seven to eight people had gathered.

A confrontation then broke out between the student's friends and another group over an unspecified issue. The argument escalated into a physical fight, during which one of the students allegedly took out a knife and stabbed him in the chest.

The injured student suffered heavy blood loss. His friends took him to a nearby private hospital on a motorcycle, but he died while receiving treatment.

Police are questioning students and other witnesses to establish how the confrontation began and who was involved.

5-commissionerate plan set to be placed before cabinet

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BENGALURU: The Karnataka government is expected to place its plan to split the Bengaluru City Police Commissionerate into five units before the Cabinet on Thursday, with approval potentially clearing the way for a reorganisation that would create 6,633 new police posts at a projected cost of ₹764.87 crore.

The proposal divides Bengaluru into Central, North, South, East and West commissionerates, each headed by an inspector general of police or deputy inspector general of police rank officer. All five would function under a chief commissioner of police or director general of police rank.

The plan, prepared by Bengaluru police commissioner Seemant Kumar Singh and submitted on August 1, also proposes increasing the number of deputy commissioners of police from 18 to 28.

The restructuring follows the expansion of Bengaluru's administrative boundaries and the creation of the Greater Bengaluru Authority, whose civic administration is divided into five corporations.

The police proposal seeks a corresponding territorial arrangement to improve coordination between policing and civic administration.

Chief minister DK Shivakumar announced the five com-



The proposal divides Bengaluru into Central, North, South, East and West commissionerates.

REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

missionerate structure during his Independence Day address on August 15. He said the reorganisation would strengthen law and order and facilitate the creation of police stations where they are needed.

"Under the proposed arrangement, the Central commissionerate would cover the core city. North would include areas such as Yeshwanthpur and Yelahanka, while East would cover the existing East division and Whitefield," said an officer in the know.

"South would encompass the South, Southeast and Electronic City areas, along with Anekal, Sarjapur, Suryanagar, Attibele, Bannerghatta and Jigani. West would cover West, Kengeri and Peenya, according to the proposed jurisdictions," the officer added.

Some specialised policing functions would continue to operate across the five territorial jurisdictions. The Central Crime

Branch and cybercrime units would remain under the city-wide crime structure, while traffic would retain a citywide command. Each territorial commissionerate would have its own traffic DCP.

The structure has drawn reservations from sections of the police establishment, particularly over the possibility of jurisdictional disputes and coordination problems between neighbouring commissionerates during law and order operations. There have also been questions over the proposed chief commissioner, who would supervise the five territorial commissioners.

The government had considered smaller divisions before settling on the five unit model. A three commissionerate arrangement covering North, South and Central Bengaluru was among the models discussed. Some retired police officers have favoured a two commissionerate structure.

Govt mulls points-based driving licence system

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BENGALURU: Karnataka is considering introducing a points-based driving licence system, under which repeated traffic violations would attract penalty points and a driving licence could be suspended once a prescribed threshold is reached, officials said on Wednesday.

The proposal was discussed at a joint review meeting of the home and transport departments chaired by state home minister Priyank Kharge and transport minister Byrathi Suresh. The meeting focused on measures to improve road safety, curb traffic violations and ease congestion in Bengaluru, Kharge's office said in a release.

Under the proposed system, points would be assigned for different traffic violations and accumulated against a driver's record. Reaching a specified limit could result in suspension of the driving licence, it said.

The meeting also examined the legal changes required to introduce the points-based system, it added. The departments discussed directly integrating the transport department's Sarathi driving licence system with the Bengaluru Traffic Police's e-Challan system.

The integration would enable



Under the proposal repeated traffic violations would attract penalty points and a driving licence could be suspended once a prescribed threshold is reached.

FILE PHOTO

traffic police to verify a driving licence's validity on the spot, access a driver's previous violation history and link newly recorded offences directly to the driver's digital record.

The move is expected to reduce paperwork and make enforcement of traffic rules more effective, it said.

The meeting also discussed increasing fines for traffic violations that affect traffic flow and public safety in Bengaluru.

These include parking on footpaths, driving against traffic on one-way roads, driving on footpaths, unauthorised parking, parking in no-parking zones, violating traffic signals and obstructing free flow of traffic.

The proposal also includes higher penalties for repeat offen-

system was also considered.

The state also discussed measures to curb manufacture and sale of half helmets that do not meet road-safety standards. Officials considered banning manufacture of such helmets and taking action against manufacturers and sellers.

Action against the sale and use of unauthorised horns, modified silencers and excessively bright LED lights, which can contribute to noise pollution and road-safety concerns, was also discussed.

The meeting discussed bringing low-speed battery-powered electric two-wheelers under necessary traffic regulations, including measures relating to helmets, registration, vehicle identification and driver accountability. Officials noted that certain traffic regulations currently do not apply to such vehicles and discussed appropriate controls to improve road safety and traffic discipline.

The meeting also considered a "one city, one fare" policy to bring greater uniformity to fares charged by different transport and mobility service providers.

A state-level policy to promote carpooling and ride-sharing, including app-based services and park-and-ride facilities, was also discussed as a means of reducing congestion.

Strict enforcement of pollution-under-control certificates was considered, including the possibility of withholding certificates from vehicles with unpaid traffic fines and conducting joint enforcement drives by the Transport Department and traffic police.

Officials also discussed greater public awareness of the vehicle scrappage policy and promotion of incentives such as tax concessions for scrapping old, highly polluting and mechanically unfit vehicles.

For metro commuters, the meeting considered a framework for shared auto services, including designated routes, fares and licensing, to improve first- and last-mile connectivity. Measures to ensure the quick removal of BMTC electric buses that break down on major roads were also discussed, including dedicated technical teams, an emergency response mechanism and better coordination between BMTC and traffic police.

Expansion of Bengaluru Metropolitan Transport Corporation (BMTCL) services in technology corridors along the Outer Ring Road, feeder services between metro stations and technology parks, additional buses during peak hours and promotion of employee transport services were also considered.

CCB charges Veeramani with abetment of victim's suicide

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CHENNAI: The central crime branch (CCB) of Tamil Nadu police has registered a new case against industrialist R Veeramani under the 'abetment to suicide' charge related to the death of a minor in 2004, police said on Wednesday.

The decades-old case against Veeramani (84), the founder of Gem Granites who is in police custody under Pocco, resurfaced after investigators accessed a text message sent by Shanthi, a co-accused, asking him if he remembered his involvement in the victim's death. The SMS prompted a fresh complaint from the girl's mother alleging that her daughter died by suicide following sexual abuse by Veeramani, police said.

Veeramani was arrested under the POCO Act in August and three of his associates — Ganeshan, a former employee, Shanthi, and her husband Mahendra Simhan — who allegedly played key roles in the abuse of minors, have also been arrested. Veeramani, Shanthi and Simhan are currently in police custody until October 8.

IPS officer recuses herself from SIT

Meanwhile, V V Geethanjali, one of the four IPS officers on the Special Investigation Team (SIT) formed to probe the case, has recused herself from the team, citing personal reasons.

The SIT was formed based on the orders of director general of police (DGP) Mahesh Kumar Aggarwal and is headed by the Greater Chennai Police Commissioner A Amalraj.

Besides Geethanjali, who is the deputy commissioner of



police, crime against women and children, PC Thenmozhi, additional commissioner of police, CCB, Chennai, Disha Mittal, joint commissioner of police, law and order (west), and J Mutharasi (superintendent of police) were part of the SIT. Geethanjali has sought the Commissioner's permission to recuse herself from the team as she was part of an earlier investigation into the Veeramani case under the supervision of the then-Chennai city police commissioner A Arun.

Recently, the Tamil Nadu government transferred Arun from the directorial post in the Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption. He is now on 'compulsory wait'.

Deputy commissioner of police B Geetha, who is currently serving Kilpauk police, will replace Geethanjali in the SIT, said officers aware of the matter, adding that a formal communication to that effect is expected from the police department soon.

BJP reiterates demand for CBI probe in case

The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) has reiterated its earlier stand that the case should be transferred to Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI). In a party statement, BJP Tamil Nadu spokesperson Narayanan Thirupathi said, "deputy commis-

THE ABETMENT CASE RESURFACED AFTER COPS FOUND A TEXT SENT TO VEERAMANI BY CO-ACCUSED SHANTHI THAT ALLEGEDLY REFERRED TO IT

sioner Geethanjali who was appointed to the SIT handling the sexual assault case involving Veeramani, has announced her decision to recuse herself from the team. She was also part of the investigation in the Veeramani case under the supervision of the then Chennai city police commissioner A Arun.

"This is precisely what I have been emphasizing from the very beginning. Given the possibility that various high-ranking police officials may have played a role in diluting or prematurely concluding this case, it would be proper and fair for the investigation to be handed over to the CBI," added Thirupathi. The Tamil Nadu government must immediately request a CBI inquiry into this matter, he urged.

Meanwhile, a special Pocco court in Chennai on Tuesday reserved its orders on the bail petitions of Shanthi and her husband Mahendra Simhan. Police alleged that Veeramani kept minor children at Shanthi's residence to assault them and that Shanthi attempted to destroy evidence. They highlighted key financial transactions linked to the crime, revealing that ₹24.63 crore was transferred from Veeramani's account to Shanthi, with ₹2 crore moved to Simhan.

(with PTI inputs)

Madras HC junks plea for transfer of investigation to CBI

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BENGALURU: The Madras high court on Wednesday refused to transfer the investigation into the Protection of children from sexual offence (Pocco) case involving granite baron R Veeramani to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), saying that the special investigation team (SIT) constituted by the Tamil Nadu government should be given time to collect evidence.

A local journalist, Vaaraki, had moved the high court earlier this week seeking transfer of the probe from the SIT to the CBI, expressing apprehension that the SIT would not conduct an independent and effective investigation, due to the involvement of high-ranking officials.

Justice V Lakshminarayanan said the SIT had been formed only four days ago and had already commenced its probe. The court said there was no justification for transferring the investigation to CBI without giving the SIT an opportunity to investigate the case. "I am sure the Tamil Nadu police does not have a crystal ball or magic wand to collect all evidence at once. Investigation takes time," the high court said, adding that without giving the SIT breathing space, asking to transfer probe to CBI will not be proper.

During the first hearing on Wednesday, the high court said



I am sure the TN police does not have a crystal ball or magic wand to collect all evidence at once

JUSTICE V LAKSHMINARAYAN,
Madras high court

given how sensitive the issue was, one must not politicise the matter. "It is a sensitive matter. I am more concerned about the children. You cannot politicise it. There are other cases in which you can get publicity. Please do not use this," the court said.

When the petitioner said he apprehended that an independent probe would not be carried out and that investigators was silent about evidence against high-ranking officials, the court asked how such allegations could be made without allowing the SIT time to investigate.

"We'll transfer it to the CBI. Totally independent. Out of India. How can you say they're keeping silent? This is a publicity interest litigation. Four women officers have been appointed. Why are you interfering without giving them an opportunity to investigate?" the court said.

2 people held for aiding Telangana arms heist

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HYDERABAD: The Telangana police on Tuesday detained two more people in connection with the theft of arms and ammunition from the armoury of the Indian Army's Madras Regiment in Secunderabad on August 31, people familiar with the matter said on Wednesday.

The two were identified as armoury in-charges Vinod and Sheshu (one names). They are accused of helping primary accused, army havildar Upput-holla Mallesh (retired), 37, steal the cache. Mallesh was arrested on September 11 and is in police custody.

"While interrogating Mallesh, we learned that Vinod and Sheshu, who were in-charges of the armoury, had assisted him in the theft. At least three others are also believed to have helped Mallesh in transporting weapons from the cantonment area to his house," a police officer said. "After ascertaining the facts, we will formally arrest the two people and produce them before the court," the officer added.

Mallesh had joined the Army

INVESTIGATORS RECONSTRUCTED THE SCENE OF THE CRIME TO ESTABLISH HOW ITS PRECISE CIRCUMSTANCES

in 2010 and worked for 16 years before he was compulsorily retired due to discipline and health issues on June 30, police said. He stole the arms and ammunition out of disgruntlement because his superiors forced him into early retirement, police said.

On the intervening night of August 30 and 31, Mallesh stole a cache of arms and ammunition from the Bell of Arms at the 20 battalion Madras Regiment's headquarters at Bolarum in Secunderabad Cantonment. He took the stolen cache to his house in Kowkoo village of Yaprul mandal in Rangareddy district, and then to his house in his original village, Jangam Reddy Pally, in Amrabad mandal of Nagarkurnool.

The police arrested him on September 11 and a Hyderabad

court on September 22 sent him into police custody for 10 days.

The police recovered stolen arms including four AK-203 rifles, one 5.56 mm INSAS rifle, six 9 mm pistols and a civilian 6.35-bore pistol. Police also recovered 1,156 rounds of 9 mm ammunition, 720 rounds of AK-203 ammunition and INSAS ammunition, besides magazines and other equipment, from his residence at Kowkoo village of Yaprul mandal in Rangareddy district and also his native village Jangam Reddy Pally in Amrabad mandal of Nagarkurnool. Police said they also recovered an additional 810 rounds of ammunition allegedly stolen by Mallesh from another hideout in his village.

Police said they found evidence of financial transactions between Mallesh and Vinod. Police are now conducting a detailed probe into these transactions to determine whether they were connected to the alleged theft of the weapons.

As part of the investigation, police have conducted a scene reconstruction to establish how the weapons were allegedly stolen and to ascertain the possible involvement of other people.

FORMER AIADMK MIN SEMMALAI JOINS TVK WITH HIS SUPPORTERS

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CHENNAI: Former minister and seasoned AIADMK leader S Semmalai formally joined the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) alongside a host of his supporters at party chief C Joseph Vijay's rally at Dharapuram on Wednesday.

The rally was held to drum up support for TVK's bypoll candidate and ex-AIADMK leader P Sathyabama.

Hailing from Salem district, considered as one an AIADMK stronghold, he served as a minister in the late J Jayalalithaa led-cabinet elected in 2001. After emerging victorious as an independent candidate in 1984 Taramangalam assembly, he later joined AIADMK in 1984. He was not given a ticket in the 2026 assembly polls.

Semmalai had indicated to reporters of his plans to join the TVK in May.

"After the demise of the former chief minister J Jayalalithaa, opportunities to contest in the polls were denied to me in the AIADMK. Presently, given the rift in the AIADMK, my conscience no longer allows me to continue travelling with the party. I, therefore, have taken very difficult decision to resign from the AIADMK" he had said.

The by-poll in Dharapuram (SC) and Madurantakam (SC) constituencies has been necessitated following the resignation of P Sathyabama and Maragatham Kumbaravel, respectively.

The two former AIADMK lawmakers were renominated by the TVK government for the by-elections on October 6.

SEMMALAI SERVED AS A MINISTER IN THE CABINET LED BY FORMER CM J JAYALALITHAA ELECTED IN THE 2001 ELECTIONS



Nivedya

MOTHER HELD FOR DROWNING TWO CHILDREN IN KERALAM: POLICE

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: A day after two siblings, aged five and three, were found dead from drowning at their home, their mother was arrested and charged with murder, a police officer familiar with the case said on Wednesday.

The incident was reported on Tuesday in Kozhijambara in Keralam's Palakkad district. Jennifer Juliet (5) and her brother Robin Christopher (3) were found dead in a water tub inside the bathroom of their rented home in Menonpara around 10.30 am on Tuesday.

Their mother Nivedya told the police initially that she was engaged in some domestic work in front of their home and went inside the bathroom to find her children dead by drowning. The kids' father John Kumar was out for work.

Police said that while they initially filed a case of unnatural deaths and conducted inquests and post-mortems of the minor children, they did not find Nivedya's testimony entirely believable. Investigators later took statements from locals, neighbours and John Kumar, all of whom expressed doubts about Nivedya's account.

The police claimed that Nivedya, during the course of questioning, on Wednesday, confessed to drowning her children.

"The woman has claimed that her children were a hindrance to her quest to lead a free, independent life. She claimed that she wanted to study and pursue a modelling career. We have recorded her confession. But we will need to continue a comprehensive investigation into the case," said a senior officer at the Kozhijambara police station where the FIR was registered.

The officer confirmed that the children died by drowning. The children's father consumes alcohol regularly, which may have left an impact on the couple's life, the officer said.

Foreign spouses of Indians not entitled to visa: HC

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THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The Kerala high court has held that a foreign national, even if he/she is the spouse of an Indian citizen, has no vested right to demand that he/she be issued a visa to enter the country.

The high court's ruling came while dismissing a writ petition filed by a man from Kerala and his Pakistani wife seeking a tourist visa for the woman to attend her brother-in-law's wedding in India. The petitioners, residing abroad, submitted that when the Pakistani national attempted to apply for

THE COURT WAS HEARING A WRIT PLEA BY A KERALA MAN AND HIS PAKISTANI WIFE SEEKING A TOURIST VISA FOR THE LATTER

an Indian visa to attend the wedding, she could not find even a procedure to file an application for a visit visa. They argued that not even being provided an opportunity to apply for a visa was contrary to the constitutional provisions of

Articles 21 and 14. The Pakistani petitioner also argued that she would ultimately require a long-term visa as she is already married to an Indian citizen.

In its counter affidavit, the Centre stated that no foreign national can claim, as a matter of right, permission to enter or remain in India except in accordance with the provisions of law of the Indian government. It also stressed that all visas issued to Pakistani nationals stood suspended from April 29, 2025 following the Pahalgam terror attacks.

The high court, after hearing all the arguments, said that no

foreign national has an "inherent or legally enforceable right to seek entry into India." Issuance of tourist visas is a sovereign function of the state and lies deeply rooted in considerations of national security, foreign policy and administrative discretion.

It said that as long as the order issued under Section 3 of the Foreigners Act, 1946 remains in force, no Pakistani national can demand that his/her application for visa be processed.

The court ruled that the petitioner cannot claim relief under Art 14 of the Constitution as she is not in India presently.

Anti-terror drill



Telangana's OCTOPUS (Organisation for Counter Terrorist Operations) stages a drill at the Sri Rudreshwara Swamy Temple in Hanamkonda on Wednesday.

ANI

Andhra to develop Tirupati as global wedding destination

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HYDERABAD : The Andhra Pradesh government has decided to develop the famous pilgrim town of Tirupati as a global wedding destination alongside its existing religious tourism ecosystem, special chief secretary (revenue) Mukesh Kumar Meena said on Wednesday.

Addressing the media after a stakeholders' conference on the Tirupati Economic Region (TER), Meena, who is also chief executive officer of TER, said the state government was planning to promote wedding as a major economic activity in the temple town by bringing accommodation, transport, catering, decoration, event management, photography, traditional arts, entertainment and other services together.

He said the objective was to create facilities catering to people across economic segments, rather than limiting the concept of a wedding destination to premium or luxury events. "A combination of premium, mid-range and budget-level venues and accommodation could enable families from different sections to organise weddings in Tirupati according to their requirements and affordability," he said.

Meena said wedding tourism should be developed as an integrated economic activity rather than merely creating venues for marriage functions.

"The wedding experience can also be linked with the spiritual and cultural attractions of



Mukesh Kumar Meena

the region. Guests can combine the Tirumala visit with visits to heritage, cultural and nature-based tourist destinations in Tirupati, Chittoor, Nellore and surrounding areas, creating wider tourism circuits," he said.

The official said a well-organised wedding destination would create opportunities for hotels, convention centres, banquet halls, catering services, decorators, transport operators, photographers, videographers, florists, event managers, artisans, textile and jewellery businesses and other service providers.

Meena said the development of Tirupati as a wedding destination would require adequate accommodation, parking, public transport and connectivity. There was a need to increase the availability of quality budget hotels so that visitors from all sections could stay in the city.

"The city should also ensure adequate water supply, power, sanitation, waste management and traffic management so that increased visitor activity did not put pressure on existing civic infrastructure," he said.

CCMB study links viral illnesses to Parkinson's

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HYDERABAD : Infections caused by certain viruses such as influenza and SARS-CoV-2, the virus responsible for COVID-19, are likely to cause neurodegenerative diseases like Parkinson's disease, a new study by scientists at the Hyderabad-based CSIR-Centre for Cellular and Molecular Biology (CCMB) has found.

An official release from the CCMB said the study, led by Dr Swasti Raychaudhuri's laboratory and published in the peer-reviewed journal "Cell Reports," provides new insights into how viral infections could promote the formation of abnormal protein clumps associated with neurodegenerative diseases.

The CCMB study focuses on alpha-synuclein, a protein that plays a central role in Parkinson's disease. Under certain



conditions, this protein can clump together to form amyloid deposits in the brain. These abnormal deposits can interfere with communication between nerve cells and impair their functioning.

The researchers found that RNA viruses may influence this process through unusual structures formed by their genetic material. "Unlike DNA, RNA is a single-stranded molecule, but it can fold into complex shapes. One such structure is known as an RNA G-quadruplex (rG4).

THE STUDY WAS CONDUCTED BY DR SWASTI RAYCHAUDHURI'S LABORATORY, SAID AN OFFICIAL PRESS RELEASE ISSUED BY CCMB

According to the study, these structures formed by viral RNA can interact with alpha-synuclein and accelerate the formation of amyloid clumps," the study said.

The researchers also identified a natural cellular defence mechanism that can counter this process. "When a cell is infected by an RNA virus, a protein called DDX39A, which normally remains inside the cell nucleus, moves into the surrounding cell fluid, or cytoplasm. There, it binds to both

alpha-synuclein and the virus's RNA structures," it said.

DDX39A acts like a molecular "unwinding" machine. It breaks apart the rG4 structures in viral RNA, making it more difficult for the virus to reproduce. This, in turn, can reduce the amount of virus present inside infected cells.

The same process also appears to reduce the formation of alpha-synuclein amyloids. "The virus fails to replicate with its RNA structures dismantled, and thus, the viral load in the cells decreases. At the same time, the unwinding of viral RNA's secondary structure effectively slows down alpha-synuclein amyloid formation," said Aanchal, the first author of the study.

Dr Raychaudhuri said cells have several protective mechanisms that work to maintain a balance between competing molecular processes. Depend-

ing on the circumstances, these mechanisms may not always be sufficient to prevent amyloid formation.

"Even if there are protective mechanisms in the cells to prevent viral infections and avoid amyloid formation, there are situations that favour one kind of reaction more than the other. These decide the final outcomes in cells, and sometimes amyloid formation is accelerated in virus-infected cells," he said.

He added that not every viral infection leads to increased amyloid formation and neurodegenerative disease, but repeated exposure might tilt the odds against us.

The researchers at CCMB are now studying the finer details of how an apparently routine viral infection could potentially initiate molecular changes that remain unnoticed for years and may contribute to Parkinson's disease much later in life.

INDIA bloc revives paper ballot demand, lists steps to target CEC

Saubhadra Chatterji

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NEW DELHI: Opposition parties on Wednesday revived their demand to replace electronic voting machines (EVMs) with paper ballots and announced a six-point programme—ranging from public rallies to petition to President—to target chief election commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar and Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Preparing for the next phase of political battle over the special intensive revision, the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA) accused the CEC and the government of manipulating voter rolls during SIR to subvert electoral integrity and alleged that Modi and Union home minister Amit Shah were treating the election commission as their puppets. The Opposition had demanded replacing EVMs with ballot papers during Modi's first and second terms, but the issue had fizzled out in the past few years. "Everyone has decided to fight together in a united manner," declared Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge after a three-and-a-half-hour strategy session.

He confirmed that all participating leaders "100% agreed that instead of EVMs, paper ballots should be used". He also called for reversing recent election law amendments. A Congress leader said it was a reference to the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners Act, 2023, which grants legal immunity to the CEC and election commissioners.

"Modi and Shah are treating the election commission of India as their puppet. They are winning elections by deceit," Kharge said, comparing the SIR deletions to the 2016 high-value currency ban. "First, Modi did not bandi; now he is doing votebandi to rob citizens of their rights," Kharge said.

Nineteen Opposition parties and independent MP Kapil Sibal attended the meeting at Constitution Club. Three months ago, 21 Opposition parties had met at the same venue to demand resignation of then Union education minister Dharmendra Pradhan over paper leaks. In June, the parties also planned to write to the Chief Justice of India Surya Kant on SIR-related issues.

From Tamil Nadu, only VCK attended the meeting.

As part of the six-point programme, Kharge said the INDIA bloc leaders will organise "Save Democracy" marches throughout the country from October 2 to 8 with the involvement of the



Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge speaks during a press conference on Wednesday. Lok Sabha LoP Rahul Gandhi, Congress chairperson Sonia Gandhi, J&K CM Omar Abdullah, PDP president Mehbooba Mufti, TMC chief Mamata Banerjee, NCP-SP national working president Supriya Sule and others also present.

general public, youth and "everyone who believe in democracy and unity".

Opposition MPs will also march to EC on October 6. "Leaders of Opposition will seek appointment from President of India to give a representation on our problems and against the chori ki sarkar (govt with a stolen mandate)," Kharge added.

Kharge said both Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha members will participate and all parties will be invited to join the October 6 march. There will be five big rallies to reach out to the people. The Opposition has planned another rally in Delhi on November 1. The Opposition will also write to the judiciary to expedite the cases related to SIR and electoral issues.

Kharge lauded party leader Rahul Gandhi for his campaign, saying people earlier didn't believe allegations of vote theft but now everyone realised that he was right.

To be sure, HT's analysis of SIR deletions by constituency has shown no correlation with the outcome; and some of the deletions have been caused by death and migration. But the exclusion of millions of voters from draft rolls—in Delhi, 33% of the UT's 14.5 million voters were excluded—has resulted in public angst and anxiety. Revelations by the Indian Express last week that two election commissioners disagreed with some of the decisions, and that the central database of electors wasn't accessible to on-ground officers tasked with adding and deleting names have caused a stir. EC has since clarified that all decisions have been unanimous, based on the majority, and also modified the SIR process to reduce the inconvenience to voters.

Leader of Opposition in the

Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi said all parties agreed that Modi, Amit Shah and CEC Gyanesh Kumar had assaulted Indian democracy. He said the Opposition was successful in putting across the concern about manipulation of elections and promised changes.

"The Opposition leaders are collective defenders. We will make serious changes in the country," Gandhi added.

Mamata Banerjee said Rahul Gandhi and Rashtriya Janata Dal leader Tejashwi Yadav were the first ones to speak about vote theft, a reference to the rally addressed by the two leaders in Bihar last year. "Vanish (Gyanesh) Kumar chor hai, daaku hai. He should resign immediately. Let us save democracy and let the security of voting right be restored. If votes are stolen, then how can country run?" Banerjee asked. Later, Sonia Gandhi could be seen praising Banerjee for her fiery speech. She also questioned the software used by EC, ERONET, that processes enumeration forms and tries to match a current elector with a corresponding entry in the base rolls, and said the Opposition was ready to fight against Modi.

Some leaders including Uddhav Thackeray spoke about the influence of Cockroach Janta Party and independent MP Kapil Sibal explained the legal immunity enjoyed by the CEC and the two ECs. He advised that the Opposition should try to file FIR against Seema Khanna, EC's director general IT as she doesn't enjoy the immunity.

Omar Abdullah expressed reservation to the plan to meet President Droupadi Murmu over this issue. He said that in Jammu&Kashmir, earlier the challenge was to come out and vote. But now, the vote chori has become the challenge.

Oppn may put hold on motion to remove CEC

Saubhadra Chatterji

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NEW DELHI: The Opposition might put on hold its plan to move a motion for removal of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar as INDIA bloc leaders prefer political programmes and public outreach over the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of the electoral roll, leaders aware of the matter said on Wednesday.

The Congress had announced last week that the Opposition will move a fresh impeachment motion against Kumar in the wake of the Indian Express' report on objections raised by the two Election Commissioners on SIR-related decisions. A similar notice, signed by 73 MPs, is pending before the Rajya Sabha after the first Opposition-sponsored notice in March this year was rejected by the presiding officers of both Houses.

On Wednesday, the issue of CEC removal didn't figure in the official discussions of the INDIA bloc meeting. On the sidelines, many leaders, especially those from Rajya Sabha, were sounded out on the issue in the wake of the new political priorities of the alliance. The Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress (TMC), Left parties and an important section of the Congress said that the motion can be delayed.

"Our position is clear: the action should be on the ground. Anything in Parliament should be put on hold. To put it politely, when the presiding officer is the umpire, enough said," TMC floor leader in the Rajya Sabha Derek

O'Brien told HT.

A senior Congress leader close to Leader of the Opposition Rahul Gandhi said that "there is a rethink" on the motion for CEC removal. The change of plan comes even as Congress lawmaker Abhishek Singhvi has already drafted the notice against Kumar.

In the meeting, Gandhi emphasised a broad-based partnership and said, "We can't get there alone. You can't get there alone. But together we will," in an apparent reference to upcoming political battles and elections. "There is no point saying who suffered more," Gandhi also suggested, adding that fighting Prime Minister Modi and Gyanesh Kumar "has to be done by everybody."

Several suggestions to take on the CEC over the SIR came from across parties. Mamata Banerjee and CPI(M-L) chief Dipankar Bhattacharya pitched for quick action on the ground to reach out to the people. Congress Parliamentary party chief Sonia Gandhi supported for both Banerjee and Bhattacharya's plans. Tejashwi Yadav of RJD claimed when Rahul Gandhi and he were campaigning, they got a very good response. But later, votes were "looted" in Bihar. And later, same thing happened in Bengal. Yadav suggested setting up of a sub-committee and appointing spokespersons.

Uddhav Thackeray criticised the judiciary and said the EC's only job is to break parties. CPI(M) chief MA Baby called it "a fight against RSS" and sought the involvement of civil society.

{ POLL PITCH AT JALANDAR RALLY }

Shah vows to end Pb drug menace by 2029

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JALANDHAR: Union home minister Amit Shah on Wednesday pledged that the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), if voted to power in Punjab next year, will eradicate the trade of "chitta" (synthetic drugs) from the state by December 31, 2029.

The home minister made the statement during a rally at Jalandhar's Kot Kalan village, where he culminated state BJP unit's 13-day "Nasha Mukta Punjab Yatra", launched by party president Nitin Nabin on September 18. "While there are several issues like farming, industry, law and order, and women's safety, the BJP will fight this election solely on the issue of a drug-free Punjab," Shah said.

Shah launched a scathing attack on the ruling Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) party in Punjab, alleging it had allowed the drug trade to thrive openly.

"Can AAP make Punjab drug-free? Only the BJP can do it. I promise Punjab's mothers and youngsters that before December 2029, we will free Punjab from 'chitta' and restore the pristine glory of the state," Shah said.

Highlighting the Narendra Modi government's track record, Shah said that the regime had delivered on its commitments ahead of set deadlines, citing the eradication of terrorism in Jammu & Kashmir and the Northeastern parts of the coun-



Amit Shah

try, alongside the wiping out of Naxalism. "Now, it is time to make Punjab drug-free... The BJP will ensure that not even a single gram of 'chitta' is smuggled into Punjab and sent out of the state," Shah said.

Shah further accused the state government of failing to keep a check on the drug menace.

"Not even a single drug peddler has been arrested under the state's anti-narcotics act, while chief minister Bhagwant Mann failed to attend NCORD (Narco Coordination Centre) for the past three times. In fact, CM Mann disallowed permission to set up a unit of Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) in Punjab," Shah said, adding that "Those involved in liquor scam are talking about making Punjab Nasha Mukta".

He further alleged that the AAP government failed on every front as the economic condition of the state is in shambles. "Since AAP came into power, there have been corruption scams..." Shah said.

AAP hit back at Shah. "Amit Shah came to Punjab today to

Ex-min Majithia summoned in ₹6k-cr drug case

CHANDIGARH: A Punjab Police special investigation team (SIT), probing a ₹6,000 crore drug case, has summoned senior Akali leader and former minister Bikram Singh Majithia to appear before it on October 5, officials said on Wednesday.

The SIT has also summoned dismissed police officer Jagdish Bhola on the same date, they said. Bhola, a former wrestler, was arrested in November 2013 by the Punjab police in connection with the drug racket. In 2014, Bhola named Majithia in the drug racket. **PTI**

give lectures on drugs. At the same time, 526 kg of heroin and methamphetamine worth over ₹3,000 crore has been seized in an operation in which Gujarat ATS provided the intelligence. We have been saying that Gujarat has emerged as a major gateway for drugs in the country. This seizure once again shows the scale of the problem. If Amit Shah is serious about Nasha Mukta Bharat, he should start his Nasha Mukta Yatra from Gujarat, not Punjab," AAP said in a statement.

{ NANDIGRAM BYPOLL }

Bengal govt moves SC seeking stay on Cong candidate's bail order

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NEW DELHI: A day after the Calcutta High Court granted interim bail to Congress's Nandigram assembly bypoll candidate Milan Pradhan, the West Bengal government on Wednesday moved the Supreme Court seeking an immediate stay on the order, arguing that a murder accused with six non-bailable warrants (NBWs) against him should not have been given such relief.

Meanwhile, Pradhan walked out of the jail in the afternoon and said he would immediately start campaigning for the October 6 by-election. The bypoll was necessitated by chief minister Suvedu Adhikari leaving the Nandigram seat for Bhabanipur, which he had also won in the state polls earlier this year.

Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, representing the West Bengal government, mentioned the matter before Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, pressing for an expedited hearing of the state's appeal against the high court's September 29 order.

"He is a murder accused and has been released only for elections. The high court failed to consider that there were six NBWs against this person," Mehta told the CJI. The top court agreed to list the matter for hearing on October 5.

On Tuesday, a single-judge



Milan Pradhan

bench of justice Tirthankar Ghosh granted Pradhan interim bail for three weeks in six cases dating back to the 2007 Nandigram anti-land acquisition agitation that included four murder cases, enabling him to campaign for the bypoll. The court directed him to surrender before the Haldia trial court on October 21.

Pradhan was arrested on September 18, hours after the Trinamool Congress (TMC) candidate withdrew and party chief Mamata Banerjee announced support for him. He was in judicial remand in connection with four cases registered at Nandigram police station and two more in neighbouring Khejuri, on charges including murder, attempt to murder and violations of the Arms Act.

Pradhan, after walking out of Haldia jail said: "I will begin campaigning from today. There is not much time left."

(With inputs from state bureau)

'HOW DOES YOUR SYSTEM OVERRIDE LAW?': HC TO ECI ON GOA DELETIONS

Gerard de Souza

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PANAJI: The Bombay High Court on Wednesday questioned the Election Commission of India (ECI) for blaming "software glitches" and sought an explanation for how "software can override the law," after the names of seven members of a family were deleted from electoral rolls after the special intensive revision (SIR) for allegedly having "shifted," despite their valid submission of Form 8.

Hearing the matter, the court said a name cannot be deleted from the rolls without affording a hearing to the affected party. "Show us from the Act... what empowers you to delete without a hearing?" the bench of justices Amit Jansandekar and Valmiki Menezes said.

Parash Salgaonkar moved the high court after securing orders in his favour at the level of the DEO and CEO, but was asked to file Form 6 for re-entering the list as a new voter. Salgaonkar refused to fill form 6 saying that doing so would amount to filing a false declaration.

"There is no explanation for how the officer cannot override the system and put his order under it?" the bench asked.

Meanwhile, the Commission told the court that it was following procedure laid down during the exercise and that the names were deleted based on inputs received from the BLOs. The matter has been posted for further hearing on October 7.

Land deal case: Ranchi PMLA court frames charges against Soren

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RANCHI: A special PMLA court in Ranchi on Wednesday framed charges against Jharkhand chief minister Hemant Soren, paving the way for the trial in a money laundering case related to an alleged 8.86-acre land case, people familiar with the matter said.

The case pertains to the alleged illegal acquisition and transfer of the land in the Bargain area of the state capital. Besides Soren, 16 others are also named as accused.

The development came hours after the Jharkhand High Court refused to entertain Soren's plea seeking immediate stay on the trial court's proceedings.

ED counsel Amit Kumar Das said, "The court has framed charges against Hemant Soren under Section 3 of the PMLA. The matter has now successfully entered the evidence stage. Further proceedings will continue after the court fixes the next date."

Soren's defence counsel, Sanjeev Kumar said, "The charge has been framed against Hemant Soren and November 30 has been fixed for further consideration and evidence." Section 3 of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), defines the criminal offence of money laundering. The provision dictates that any individual who directly or indirectly attempts to indulge, knowingly assists, or becomes a party to any activity connected with the "proceeds of crime" including its concealment, possession, acquisition, or active use and projects or claims the illicit asset as completely untainted property, is legally guilty of money laundering. A civil court advocate present



Hemant Soren

during the framing of the charge said that the CM appeared virtually before the court and the court read out the charges.

"Special PMLA Court Judge Yougesh Kumar read out the charges to Soren, who appeared virtually via video conferencing. Soren firmly pleaded innocence against all allegations at the time of framing the charge," the advocate said.

While the primary trial moves forward, a critical constitutional battle has begun in the high court. Defence counsel Sanjeev Kumar said they explicitly challenged the constitutionality of Section 44(I)(d) of the PMLA Act within Soren's writ petition before the high court. "We have challenged the constitutionality of sub section 1 (d) of Section 44. The court has issued notice. The court will consider the legality once the reply of notices comes," he said.

A high court advocate close to the matter said that Section 44(I)(d) mandates that a Special PMLA court must try the scheduled offence and the money laundering offence together. Taking immediate cognizance of this legal challenge, the HC issued notices to the Centre and ED to submit their responses. "The matter will be heard again on October 28 and responses are to be filed by October 20," the advocate said.

INDIA bloc breaking: Chouhan

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NEW DELHI: The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) claimed that the INDIA bloc is crumbling and its leaders have rejected Rahul Gandhi's leadership after Akhilesh Yadav and other leaders skipped the alliance's Wednesday meeting. "Leave the INDIA bloc aside; even Congress leaders and members of the party are not willing to accept Rahul Gandhi as their leader. Rahul himself, during Congress Working Committee

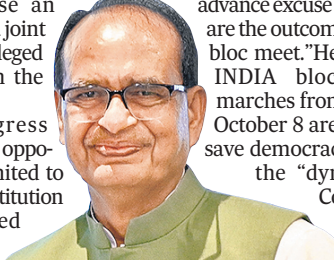
meetings, keeps pleading: 'Accept me as your leader, trust me,'" Union minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan told reporters.

Chouhan's remarks came after the INDIA bloc leaders met here to finalise an action plan for a joint agitation over alleged irregularities in the SIR.

The Congress asserted that the opposition stands united to protect the Constitution from "repeated

assaults" of the Modi government, including its "vote chori gameplan" to remain in power.

Addressing a press conference here, Chouhan said, "Zero vision, 100 per cent frustration, and advance excuse for poll defeats are the outcome of the INDIA bloc meet." He said that the INDIA bloc's proposed marches from October 2 to October 8 are not meant to save democracy, but to save the "dynasty" of the Congress and its constituents.



{ TIMES RANKING 2027 }

IISc B'luru slips out of top 250 institutes

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NEW DELHI: The Indian Institute of Science (IISc), Bengaluru, has slipped out of the top 250 in the Times Higher Education (THE) World University Rankings 2027, despite improving its scores in most of the ranking parameters, while India has increased its representation to a record 143 institutions.

IISc, which has led India in the rankings in recent years, has been placed at 254th this year, sharing the position with Northeastern University in the US. It was in the 201-250 band in the previous two editions, released in 2025 and 2024. THE said the change in IISc's position reflected increased competition as more universities entered the rankings and the number of institutions covered reached a record 2,297.

"Rankings are a zero-sum exercise and with dramatically increasing competition worldwide, universities have to work hard just to stand still," a THE

Top 10 Indian institutes

Institution Name	WUR 2026	WUR 2027
Indian Institute of Science, Bengaluru	201-250	254 (tied)
Saveetha Institute of Medical and Technical Sciences, Chennai	351-400	326-350
Shoolini University of Biotechnology and Management Sciences, Solan	401-500	451-500
Jamia Millia Islamia, New Delhi	401-500	501-550
KIIT University, Bhubaneswar	501-600	501-550
Lovely Professional University, Punjab	501-600	501-550
Amity University, Noida	601-800	551-600
Banaras Hindu University, Varanasi	501-600	551-600
Graphic Era University, Dehradun	601-800	551-600
Manipal Academy of Higher Education, Manipal	601-800	551-600

spokesperson told HT.

Saveetha Institute of Medical and Technical Sciences, Chennai, is now India's second-highest ranked institution, moving from the 351-400 band to 326-350, its highest position yet. THE attributed the improvement primarily to a rise in publications per staff.

Shoolini University of Biotechnology and Management

Sciences, Himachal Pradesh, retained its position in the 401-500 band and remained India's third-highest ranked institution.

Jamia Millia Islamia slipped from the 401-500 band in 2026 to 501-550 this year. KIIT University and Lovely Professional University are also in the 501-550 band. Amity University, Banaras Hindu University, Graphic Era University and

Manipal Academy of Higher Education are in the 551-600 band.

Central University of Himachal Pradesh and Mahatma Jyotiba Phule Rohilkhand University are the highest-ranked new Indian entrants, both placed in the 701-800 band.

Among the Indian Institutes of Technology, IIT Indore is in the 651-700 band, followed by IIT Patna in the 701-800 band. IIT Gandhinagar and IIT Mandi are in the 801-1000 band, while IIT Ropar is in the 1001-1200 band.

India has 143 institutions in the 2027 rankings, up from 128 last year, making it the second-most represented country after the US, which has 168 institutions. Turkey follows with 124 and Japan with 112.

THE has also changed its ranking methodology this year by assigning individual positions to institutions up to rank 300, compared with 200 last year. Universities below 300 are placed in progressively broader rank bands.

Andhra, Meghalaya to get more time for SIR

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NEW DELHI: The Election Commission of India (ECI) on Wednesday extended the schedule for the special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls in Andhra Pradesh and Meghalaya, according to an official press release.

The decision came at a full Commission bench meeting, the second in less than a week.

In Andhra Pradesh, the notice phase and disposal of claims and objections will now run from July 31 to October 10, and the final roll will be published on October 16. The state's original schedule had put final publication at September 22. After the draft roll came out on July 31, the final roll was slated to be published on October 3.

A later revision moved disposal of claims to October 5 and final publication to October 9.

In Meghalaya, final publication is now set for October 26. The claims and objections period there ended on September 18, and officials said more than 90% of hear-

ings were complete. The press note did not mention the state's earlier final-publication date.

On Tuesday, Andhra Pradesh chief electoral officer Vivek Yadav said, "Out of 44.28 lakh (4.428 million) notices delivered, hearing with regard to 44.27 lakh (4.427 million) notices was completed as on September 28, the last date for disposal of claims and objections, accounting for 99.96% notices. Only 1,665 electors did not respond to the notices."

The statement added that around 168,821 voters in the current electoral list were found ineligible for inclusion in the final electoral roll, which will be published on October 3.

The three commissioners last met in full on September 26, days after reports emerged that Sandhu and Joshi had objected to several SIR-linked decisions and orders. The reports triggered a political controversy, with Opposition parties questioning EC's functioning. The previous meeting extended SIR deadlines in Delhi and Maharashtra.

‘Too much heat’ generated: SC on deletion of CAPF plea

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NEW DELHI: “Sometimes too much heat is generated out of nothing,” the Supreme Court remarked on Wednesday as it sought to defuse a controversy over the abrupt deletion of contempt petitions concerning deputations of IPS officers to Central Armed Police Forces (CAPFs) from the cause list of a bench headed by justice Ujjal Bhuyan.

The remark came as the special bench, comprising justices Manoj Misra and Bhuyan, heard an explanation from the registry on why the contempt matters, which had been judicially directed to be listed before justice Bhuyan’s bench on September 30, were dropped from the cause list a day ago, and were later placed before the special bench along with a separate batch challenging a new law governing IPS deputations in CAPFs.

The bench, while accepting the registry’s explanation, said the registry ought to have informed the bench hearing the contempt petitions that the matters were likely to be listed before a bench to be constituted by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant.

The controversy had erupted on Tuesday when lawyers appearing in the contempt petitions informed the justice Bhuyan-led



SC accepted the explanation by the registry on the dropping of the matter from the cause list.

bench that the matters, which had been specifically directed to be listed on September 29, had suddenly disappeared from the cause list. The bench then directed the registry to explain why the case was struck off despite a judicial order.

Reading out the registry’s note on Wednesday, the special bench said that counsel appearing for the Centre and writ petitioners had made a mentioning before the CJI on September 23 seeking that the contempt and writ petitions be placed before the same bench. The matter, however, was subsequently listed inadvertently before justice Bhuyan’s bench on September 29, while the CJI had ordered that the two sets of cases be placed before a special bench.

“The registry should have informed this fact to the other bench,” said the bench.

Senior advocate Shyam Divan, appearing for the contempt petitioners, termed the episode a mat-

ter of “institutional credibility”, questioning how the matter could be mentioned before the CJI without the other side being informed.

Additional solicitor general Aishwarya Bhati clarified that she had made the mentioning before the contempt bench, explaining that the Centre’s principal defence in the contempt proceedings was based on the enactment of a new law, the validity of which was under challenge in the connected writ petitions.

The bench, however, told her that the other side ought to have been informed. “You ought to have informed the other side,” it told the ASG. Bhati apologised and said: “I ought to have informed the other side.”

Senior advocate Guru Krishnakumar, who was also appearing for the contempt petitioners, questioned why the fact of the mentioning had not been disclosed even on Tuesday when the bench had passed a judicial order seeking an explanation from the registry over the deletion of the matter.

The new bench also questioned the lawyers on the Centre’s contention that the validity of the new law was central to the contempt proceedings. “Is it not a fact that the act and its validity is in question?” the bench asked.

Divan and Krishnakumar responded that this was only one of the questions involved and not

the sole issue in the contempt proceedings.

Divan added that a matter could not be suddenly struck off after being notified for hearing. “You cannot have a case struck off suddenly. This is an all-India court. People make arrangements. Once a case is notified in the cause list, nobody can fiddle with it,” he said.

The bench acknowledged the petitioners’ concern but pointed out that the new law was made part of the Centre’s defence and the two proceedings were closely connected.

“It will be an exercise in futility if we go on with this, although you ought to have informed the bench hearing the contempt cases about the matter being mentioned before the CJI,” the bench said.

Solicitor general Tushar Mehta supported the move, saying the contempt proceedings could not be divorced from the challenge to the new legislation and that the matters should be heard together.

The bench then agreed to advance the hearing of the two sets of cases and fixed them for October 15, instead of November 18.

Justice Misra, meanwhile, sought to play down the controversy surrounding the listing episode. “Sometimes too much heat is generated out of nothing. One should not be so much worried about all these things,” he observed.

Warring set to resign as Cong Punjab chief amid infighting

PTI and HTC

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CHANDIGARH: Ahead of assembly elections, Punjab Congress president Amarinder Singh Raja Warring has offered to resign from his post, people familiar with the matter said on Wednesday, in a development that follows weeks of factionalism in the state unit.

The Congress is yet to announce Warring’s replacement, but party insiders indicated that former state minister and lawmaker Vijay Inder Singha has emerged as the front-runner for the post. Punjab will head to assembly polls in early 2027.

According to the people cited above, the Congress high command had informed Warring of its decision to replace him, following which he offered to resign.

The development comes in the backdrop of long-standing factional feud within the party’s state unit, which had virtually divided



Amarinder Singh Raja Warring

into two groups —one headed by Warring and the other by former CM Charanjit Singh Channi.

The rift began after the Congress announced its election-related committees for Punjab on July 1. While Channi was appointed chairman of the campaign committee and Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa was made chairman of the core committee, the high command retained Warring as the state unit president and Par-tap Singh Bajwa as the Congress Legislature Party leader. The decision to continue with Warring triggered opposition among a section of senior leaders led by

Channi and Randhawa.

The visibly acrimonious relationship between Channi and Warring prompted the party high command to send AICC state in-charge Bhupesh Baghel to the state to broker truce between the two leaders. However, it eventually ended in Baghel being replaced by Sachin Pilot as the new AICC in-charge for the poll-bound border state.

Among the front-runners to replace Warring as the new state chief include Singla, a Hindu face and a Congress Working Committee member who was appointed the chairperson of the party’s poll management and coordination panel on July 1, former Olympian and MLA Pargat Singh, former legislator Rana KP Singh, Raja Sansi MLA Sukhbinder Singh Sarkaria, party insiders indicated. Channi and Sukhjinder Singh Randhawa, the MP from Gurdaspur, are also doing the rounds for the post, they added.

U.P. TUTOR BOOKED OVER VIDEO OF PUPILS’ REMARKS AGAINST PM MODI

AGRA: A private coaching teacher was booked in Uttar Pradesh’s Etah district for allegedly filming students making objectionable comments and unsubstantiated allegations against Prime Minister Narendra Modi in a video that was widely circulated on social media, police said on Wednesday.

The case was registered on Tuesday after a complaint by sub-inspector Gangan Deep, officers said. The accused, Pratibha Yadav, a resident of Etah city, has been booked under Sections 352 (intentional insult to provoke breach of peace) and 353 (state-ment conducting public mischief) of the BNS and Section 67 of the Information Technology Act.

According to the FIR, Yadav allegedly directed minors at her coaching centre to make belittling remarks against the PM.

Police confirmed that probe is underway and necessary legal actions are being pursued. **HTC**

{ U.P. RAJYA SABHA CANDIDATURE }

Corporate figure’s SP entry spices up battle

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LUCKNOW: The sudden entry of Dhanraj Parimal Nathwani, a corporate executive with Gujarat connections, as a Samajwadi Party (SP) candidate has spiced up the upcoming Rajya Sabha elections in Uttar Pradesh.

The SP on Wednesday formally named Ram Gopal Yadav and Nathwani, indicating that it could field a third candidate as well. Nathwani’s candidature has already triggered considerable curiosity in political circles because of his corporate profile, Gujarat connections and sports



Dhanraj Parimal Nathwani

links.

Nathwani, a senior corporate executive associated with Reliance Industries, was a surprise choice for a party when the names doing the rounds included former chief secretary Alok Ranjan and former Union minister Salim Iqbal Sherwani,

besides five-term Rajya Sabha member Ram Gopal Yadav.

Besides his corporate role, Nathwani is president of the Gujarat Cricket Association, a position he took over after Union home minister Amit Shah. His father, Parimal Nathwani, is a BJP-backed Rajya Sabha member from Jharkhand.

His entry has fuelled speculation within political circles about the strategy behind SP’s choice.

“With the state heading into a high-stakes assembly battle, the choice of a corporate figure with extensive business and institutional networks, could potentially help the SP widen its access

to resources,” a BJP leader said.

A candidate requires 37 first-preference votes to win a Rajya Sabha seat. The broader BJP-supporting bloc has 294 votes (MLAs). Going by the arithmetic, BJP is positioned to win seven seats comfortably, while the eighth requires two additional votes beyond 294. This, experts believe, makes cross-voting or additional support inevitable.

The last date for filing nominations is October 6. Scrutiny is on October 7 and candidates can withdraw till October 9. If more than 10 candidates remain in the fray after withdrawal, voting will be held on October 16.

TWISHA CASE: HC ASKS GIRIBALA TO FILE REVISED BAIL APPLICATION

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JABALPUR: The Madhya Pradesh high court on Wednesday deferred the hearing on the bail application of retired judge Giribala Singh in the death of former model Twisha Sharma after Singh’s lawyer sought bail stating that the Central Bureau of Investigation has not cited dowry harassment against her.

Twisha had died by suicide on May 12, 2026, five months after her marriage to Singh’s son, advocate Samarth Singh.

Justice Ajay Kumar Nirankari directed Giribala’s lawyer to file a revised bail petition as the original application did not mention the ground of seeking the bail. The court posted the matter for next hearing on October 8.

The police had registered a case against Giribala and her son for abetment of suicide and under the Dowry Prohibition Act over the suicide. Giribala Singh and her son Samarth Singh have been in jail since June 2, 2026.

Ojha gets 1-yr extension as PIB principal DG

NEW DELHI: Senior Indian Information Service (IIS) officer Dharendra Ojha was on Wednesday re-employed as principal director general of the Press Information Bureau (PIB) till September next year.

Ojha, a 1990-batch officer, was appointed to the post in July 2024. The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet has approved his re-employment as principal director general, PIB, on a contract basis for one year, according to an order issued by the personnel ministry.

Court to hear afresh land-for-jobs case against Lalu, family

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court will hear afresh from next month arguments on framing of charges against former Bihar chief minister Lalu Prasad Yadav, his wife Rabri Devi and other family members in the alleged land-for-jobs money laundering case.

Special Judge Prashant Kumar of Rouse Avenue Courts said on Wednesday that he will hear the arguments on October 14 and 15 after the judge who had earlier heard the matter was transferred to the Delhi high court.

Gujarat HC denies temporary bail to Asaram to meet wife

AHMEDABAD: The Gujarat high court on Wednesday rejected a 20-day temporary bail application by convicted rapist and self-styled godman Asaram, who sought release from Jodhpur jail to meet his wife undergoing treatment at a hospital in Ahmedabad.

“When the patient has responded well to the treatment... we do not find any reason to allow the application of the petitioner, who is presently in Jodhpur Jail, Rajasthan,” the bench of justices Gita Gopi and LS Pirzada said.

LUTHRA BROTHERS OFFER ₹15L EACH TO FAMILIES OF GOA FIRE VICTIMS

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PANAJI: The Luthra brothers, co-owners of Birch by Romeo Lane, a Goa nightclub where a fire claimed 25 lives in December last year, have told the Bombay high court at Goa that they are willing to compensate each victim’s family with ₹15 lakh.

The high court, which is hearing a suo motu writ petition instituted after the fire at the illegally operating club, has given the families until October 12 to reply to the offer before a final decision can be taken.

“The accused have offered to pay a compensation of ₹15 lakh each to the victims’ families and their dependents. The court will consider this offer of the accused on the next occasion and the court will determine what compensation is to be paid to the victims, which is over and above the compensation paid by the government to the families of these victims,” advocate general Devidas Pangam told reporters.

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Cabinet hikes Rabi crop MSPs; oilseeds, pulses are top gainers

Pallavi Singhal

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NEW DELHI: The Centre on Wednesday raised the minimum support prices (MSPs) for all six Rabi crops for the 2027-28 marketing season, giving the biggest price boosts to oilseeds and pulses.

The government said the higher MSPs are aimed at ensuring remunerative returns to farmers and a continuation of its efforts to encourage crop diversification, particularly towards pulses and oilseeds.

The MSP of safflower, an oil seed crop, received the largest absolute hike of ₹675 per quintal (up 10.3% to ₹7,215), followed by rapeseed and mustard with a ₹413 per quintal increase (up 6.6% to ₹6,613), according to a statement released after a meeting of the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA), chaired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Lentil (masur) saw an increase of ₹390 per quintal (up 5.5%) to ₹7,390, while the MSP for barley was raised by ₹136 to ₹2,286 per quintal. Gram prices were increased by ₹83 to ₹5,958 per quintal.

In contrast, wheat received the smallest increase, (under 1%), raising MSP by ₹25 from



Wheat received the smallest increase (under 1%); raising the MSP by ₹25 from ₹2,585 to ₹2,610.

₹2,585 to ₹2,610.

With the increase, wheat, however, will have the highest margin over its all-India weighted average cost of production at 106%, followed by rapeseed and mustard at 96%, lentil at 92%, gram at 59%, barley at 58% and safflower at 50%.

The MSPs are in line with its Budget 2018-19 commitment to fix MSP at least 1.5 times the all-India weighted average cost of production, the official statement said.

The latest MSP come as the government prepares for a Rabi season under climate uncertainties. On Tuesday, agriculture minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on asked states to align crop plans with water availability

and soil moisture and prioritise pulses and oilseeds in water-stressed areas. "Water availability and soil moisture should be assessed before finalising crop plans," Chouhan had said, stressing the need to promote less water-intensive crops such as pulses and oilseeds.

A total amount of ₹90,962 crore was approved by the cabinet for this procurement.

The relatively small increase in wheat MSP comes against a backdrop of elevated government stocks. Food Corporation of India (FCI) wheat stocks at the beginning of September were up more than 44% from a year earlier, according to data cited by commodity market publication Informist. The government procured 35.76 million tonnes of wheat in the 2026-27 Rabi marketing season, up more than 19% from the previous year.

According to market experts, the high stock position limits the scope for a sharp increase in the wheat MSP, as the government is already carrying substantial inventories.

State-level bonuses can also reduce the impact of the central MSP announcement. Several states announce bonuses over and above the MSP for crops such as wheat and paddy.

Cabinet clears ₹1.8L-cr Green Energy Corridor

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NEW DELHI: The Union Cabinet approved the Green Energy Corridor Phase-III (GEC-III) scheme on Wednesday, a programme aimed at reinforcing India's Intra-State Transmission System (InSTS) so that it can evacuate up to 135 gigawatts (GW) of renewable energy across states and Union territories.

The total project outlay is ₹1,86,405 crore, targeted for completion by FY 2032-33. Of this, ₹1,36,378 crore is earmarked for InSTS development and ₹50,000 crore for the 50 GW of BESS. The Centre will contribute ₹54,082 crore.

The scheme also provides for 50 gigawatt-hours (GWh) of Battery Energy Storage Systems, to be deployed either at the premises of renewable energy developers and generators or at other locations considered important for grid flexibility.

The government said this is needed because solar and wind power do not flow steadily. Often the power lines are too

crowded to carry all the electricity being produced, so some clean energy goes to waste, particularly during peak solar hours, the government said.

The scheme tackles this in two ways. First, it will strengthen the electricity networks inside states and Union territories so they can carry up to 135 GW of renewable energy. Second, it will set up battery storage systems, with a total capacity of 50 GWh. Battery storage addresses both problems by absorbing surplus generation when supply is abundant and discharging it during evening peaks or when solar output is unavailable.

"India's power generation capacity is over 500 GW right now, of which 52% is renewable energy. There are not many nations that can claim this feat. India has a commitment towards environment that is consistent. We are taking steps to reduce fossil fuel dependence, pollution and increase environmental protection," said information and broadcasting minister Ashwini Vaishnav at a media cabinet briefing in New Delhi.

{ FOURTH-LOWEST RAINFALL SINCE 2001 }

Southwest monsoon ends with 12.6% deficit

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NEW DELHI: India's southwest monsoon ended on Wednesday with rainfall 12.6% below normal. The country recorded 759.4 mm of rain during June-September, making it the fourth-lowest monsoon rainfall since 2001, according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD).

According to a weekly IMD chart, the monsoon had a weak start, with rainfall remaining sharply below normal through much of June and early July. The weekly deficit touched 51.1% in the week ending July 15.

Rains picked up in late July and early August, briefly bringing some relief, but the recovery did not last. Rainfall turned deficient again from mid-August, with the weekly shortfall reaching 36.3% in the week ending September 9.

The deficit narrowed towards the end of the season, but not enough to make up for the shortfall built up earlier.

The monsoon was also marked by sharp regional variations. East and northeast India recorded a 25% deficit, south peninsula India was 24% below normal and northwest India 6% below normal, while central India was broadly near normal with a 2% deficit.

Arunachal Pradesh recorded



The October-December period is also expected to see below-normal rainfall.

a 44% shortfall, Assam and Meghalaya 39%, Bihar 32%, Punjab 41%, Marathwada 39% and Kerala 28%. Overall, 17 meteorological subdivisions, covering 42% of the country's area, recorded deficient rainfall during the season, while 18 subdivisions covering 53% of the area had normal rainfall.

September rainfall was above normal over northwest and central India, but below normal over southern peninsula, eastern and northeastern parts of the country. Punjab, Arunachal Pradesh, Assam and Meghalaya recorded deficient rainfall continuously through June, July, August and September.

The IMD expects this uneven rainfall pattern to continue into October. Rainfall during the month is likely to be below 85% of the long-period average for

the country as a whole.

Most parts of the country are expected to receive below-normal rainfall, although some areas of northwest India and southern peninsula India may receive normal to above-normal rainfall. The October-December period is also expected to see below-normal rainfall over most parts of the country.

The IMD expects some parts of northwest India and southern peninsula India to receive normal to above-normal rainfall during the period. The outlook comes as El Nino conditions strengthen. IMD director general M Mohapatra said "El Nino is likely to peak in November and then begin weakening."

The weather agency also flagged unusually high temperatures during September. The average maximum temperature over India was 32.05°C, the highest for September since 1901, while the average minimum temperature of 23.39°C was the fourth-highest. The mean temperature of 27.72°C was the fifth-highest since 1901.

October is likely to see above-normal maximum temperatures over most parts of the country, barring some regions of northeast India and isolated pockets of central and northwest India, where normal maximum temperatures are expected, according to Mohapatra.



The blast happened after the unit's cold separator ruptured.

1 DEAD, 12 INJURED IN MANGALURU REFINERY BLAST

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MANGALURU: A contract worker was killed and 12 others were injured, including one who suffered 35% burns, after a blast at Mangalore Refinery and Petrochemicals Limited's (MRPL) Coker Hydro Treating Unit in Surathkal on Wednesday, officials said. Emergency personnel subsequently brought the fire under control.

The explosion occurred at about 12.20 pm when the unit's cold separator, operating at a pressure of about 70 bar, ruptured, said Dr Rudolph VJ Noronha, chief general manager, corporate branding and corporate communications, MRPL.

MRPL's emergency response and firefighting teams isolated the affected unit and brought the blaze under control, he added.

The deceased was identified as Manish Karkada, 23, a contract worker from Mulki, Dakshina Kannada district. Noronha said Karkada was reported missing after the explosion and his charred body was found several hours later.

Rajesh Baptist, another worker, suffered burns over about 35% of his body and was admitted to the Intensive Care Unit of a private hospital in Kankanady. "Doctors said he is out of danger," Noronha said.

Modi, Trump discuss trade, energy ties amid tariff concerns

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NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi dialled US President Donald Trump on Wednesday to assess cooperation in key areas such as trade, energy and defence and to discuss regional and global issues against the backdrop of New Delhi's concerns over a US sanctions law on Russia.

India has said the Lindsey O Graham Sanctioning Russia and Iran Act, which gives Trump the power to impose tariffs of up to 100% on the top five purchasers of Russian oil, can have implications for bilateral relations and the global energy market. Concerns about the US law have grown at a time when India and the US remain engaged in negotiations on a bilateral trade deal.

Modi described his conversation with Trump in a social media post as productive and said they reviewed bilateral cooperation in trade, defence, energy, critical technologies and other areas.

"We agreed to maintain close engagement to take our Comprehensive Global Strategic Partnership forward," he said.

The two leaders also discussed regional and international issues, including ongoing efforts to advance global peace and security, Modi said.

People familiar with the matter said the phone call was initiated by the Indian side. A readout from the Indian government said the two leaders

reaffirmed their commitment to advancing the India-US Comprehensive Global Strategic Part-



Narendra Modi

nership and agreed to "maintain close engagement to deepen cooperation for the benefit of the people of both countries". The leaders agreed to remain in touch, the readout said.

Modi and Trump last met on the margins of the G7 Summit in France in June, though they have spoken on phone several times this year.

Concerns have grown on the Indian side over the new US sanctions law on Russia, especially because of the way the Trump administration has used tariffs since last year, when Indian goods were hit with 50% tariffs, including a 25% levy over Russian oil purchases. Russia has accounted for more than 50% of India's oil purchases in recent months.

The phone call came a day after external affairs minister S Jaishankar highlighted several concerns related to the relationship with the US, including the protracted negotiations for the bilateral trade agreement, the Trump administration's lack of "appreciation or empathy" for terrorism emanating from Pakistan, and the impact of changes in American immigration rules and regulations on the mobility of Indian professionals.

'Vehicles which can run on 100% ethanol may hit roads in 2 mths'

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NEW DELHI: India's green mobility transition is set for a major leap, with leading automakers expected to launch flex-fuel vehicles capable of running on 100% ethanol within the next one to two months, Union minister for road transport and highways Nitin Gadkari said on Wednesday at the HT Auto Leaderboard Awards and Summit 2026.

"Mahindra, Toyota, Suzuki and Hyundai will probably launch flex engines within one to two months, in which you can use 100% ethanol or petrol," Gadkari said.

He said the rollout was part of a broader push to reduce India's dependence on imported fossil fuels and create new markets for agricultural produce. Maruti Suzuki launched a flex-fuel variant of the Wagon R in June.

"Our policy is import substitution, cost-effectiveness and pollution-free mobility. We want to diversify agriculture towards the energy and power sectors," he said, adding that India currently spends ₹22 lakh crore on fossil-fuel imports.

Gadkari also highlighted the impact of ethanol production on farmers, saying the government's decision to allow ethanol production from corn had helped raise prices for growers.



Nitin Gadkari speaking at the HT Auto Leaderboard Awards and Summit.

"When the government took a decision to make ethanol from corn, the price of corn in the commercial market was ₹1,300 per quintal," he said. Commercial rates subsequently rose to ₹2,600 per quintal, resulting in a direct benefit of ₹45,000 crore to farmers in Uttar Pradesh and Bihar, he added.

The minister also defended the nationwide rollout of E20 fuel, which contains 20% ethanol blended with petrol, despite the controversy having reached the Supreme Court. "From 2022, we have had 4 crore four-wheelers and 20 crore two-wheelers on E20, and we have never received a single complaint," he said.

Turning to electric mobility, Gadkari said India's EV market

could reach ₹20 lakh crore by 2030, driven by annual vehicle sales of 10 million and the creation of 50 million jobs. He highlighted the segment's rapid growth, including a 146% year-on-year surge in electric two-wheeler sales.

He also cited key government measures, including the reduction of customs duties on lithium-ion batteries from 21% to 13% and the PM E-DRIVE scheme. Gadkari said J&K's 6-million-tonne lithium reserves, estimated at 6% of global reserves, would be a vital asset for domestic battery manufacturing.

Gadkari also spoke about major safety and technological advancements transforming the automotive sector.

HC REFUSES CBI TRANSFER PLEA IN VEERAMANI CASE

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BENGALURU: The Madras High court on Wednesday refused to transfer the investigation into the Protection of children from sexual offence (Pocso) case involving granite baron R Veeramani to the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), saying that the special investigation team (SIT) constituted by the Tamil Nadu government should be given time to collect evidence.

A journalist had moved the high court earlier this week seeking transfer of the investigation, expressing apprehension that the SIT would not conduct an independent and effective investigation due to the involvement of high-ranking officials.

Justice V Lakshminarayanan said the SIT had been formed only four days ago and had already commenced its probe.

"I am sure the Tamil Nadu police does not have a crystal ball or magic wand to collect all evidence at once. Investigation takes time," the high court said.

Veeramani and two of his aides were arrested by the Anti-Vice Squad on August 28 in a case under the Pocso Act concerning the alleged rape of girls.

Police register fresh case for abetment of suicide

The Central Crime Branch police have also booked Veeramani and his aides on charges of abetment to suicide of a minor in 2004, police said on Wednesday.

The development comes in the wake of an alleged SMS sent by Shanthi.

SC: Accused can use unrelieved prosecution documents in trial

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has held that an accused cannot only inspect documents seized during investigation but not relied upon by the prosecution, but can also have specific documents brought before witnesses during the trial if they are relevant to the defence, settling a contentious procedural issue that has surfaced in several high-profile criminal cases.

A bench of justices JB Pardiwala and K Vinod Chandran said that an accused is entitled to documents available with the prosecuting agency to shape his defence, while clarifying that the stage at which particular documents can be sought would depend on the nature and relevance of the material.

The ruling came in a case arising from an alleged conspiracy between 2010 and 2014 to award consultancy work for the permanent campus of the Central University of Jharkhand, Ranchi, on the basis of allegedly fake documents, causing a loss of nearly ₹1.92 crore.

CBI had challenged orders directing it to produce several documents sought by accused Anil Dixit under Section 91 of the Code of Criminal Procedure, including documents seized during investigation but not relied upon in the charge sheet. While the accused sought copies of a large volume of such material, CBI told the Supreme Court that the documents were voluminous and offered inspection



The stage for seeking documents hinges on their nature and relevance, the Supreme Court said.

instead. The court accepted this approach, but made it clear that inspection would not be the end of the matter. "The accused could examine such documents and seek for production of the specific document required at the appropriate time, when the appropriate witness is being examined either by the prosecution or the defence," it held.

The court directed CBI to keep the files ready when the trial takes place. Alternatively, the agency could allow the accused or an authorised representative to identify the particular documents required during inspection. Those documents would have to be recorded in writing, signed by both sides and produced before the trial court without delay.

The ruling creates a practical bridge between the accused's right to inspect material not relied upon and its eventual use in the trial. A document need not have been relied upon by the prosecution at the charge sheet

stage to become relevant to the defence later. Once identified during inspection, the accused can seek its production when the relevant prosecution witness enters the witness box, or use it while leading defence evidence.

The bench also dealt with documents that CBI claimed were not in its possession.

In one instance, the accused claimed that minutes of various building committee meetings, which had not been relied upon by the prosecution, would help establish his innocence.

The court said that if such documents were available in the records open to inspection, the accused could seek their production in accordance with the procedure laid down by it. If they were not available with CBI, the accused could procure and prove them in defence, including through the Right to Information Act or by examining an appropriate witness. Their evidentiary value, the court made clear, would ultimately have to be assessed by the trial court.

The court, however, drew a line around material that could not be disclosed. It accepted CBI's position in respect of source information and certain registers, after the accused himself clarified that he was not seeking the source of information or case diaries.

The judgment is significant because the question of what happens to material collected during investigation but consciously not relied upon by the prosecution has repeatedly troubled criminal courts.

'IT IS BETTER THAT WE DISBAND U.P. POLICE': SC LIVID OVER SHODDY JOB

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NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Wednesday pulled up the Uttar Pradesh police for not recording the name of the accused caught on the spot in an FIR observing that with such conduct, the people will not trust the police and the court will be forced to direct the Central Bureau of Investigation to take over all criminal cases in the state.

"How will people trust you if this is how you proceed with matters. In everything you seem to have an agenda," a bench of justices Sanjay Kumar and Sanjeev Sachdeva asked the state after being confronted with a case where a woman appeared in person and complained that the accused, who was riding a motorcycle was caught by her in a crime and handed over to the police. Yet, the FIR mentioned "unknown" in the accused column.

The court summoned the police officer concerned to court on the next hearing seeking an explanation over such "cover-up".

The bench said, "It is better that we disband the UP police and ask the CBI to step into all your investigations. This nonsense has to stop at some point."

The petitioner had accused the police of cover up by pointing out that at the time of handing over the accused, she noticed that the bike had no registration plate. Later, during the investigation, a registration number was assigned to the bike. The court remarked, "Toeing the line is one thing but you are bending over backwards."

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.



Bringing child to workplace may have triggered Kathua fratricide

Prawesh Lama

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NEW DELHI: The argument that led to a Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) head constable shooting dead four of his colleagues apparently concerned the presence of his child at their workplace, a hydropower project near the border in Jammu and Kashmir's Kathua, people familiar with the matter said.

While police and CISF are still investigating the trigger for the incident — a DIG rank officer from Delhi has reached Kathua — multiple versions that have emerged so far converge on the child being a factor. According to one version, an officer said, the head constable, Avdesh Kumar, brought his child to work at the Sewa Hydel Power project in Kathua on Tuesday evening, which led to the argument with his company commander and three colleagues.

Kumar opened fire with his AK-47 rifle, shooting down company commander (assistant commandant) Ankit Kumar Pandey, constables Rafiq Ahmed and San-deep Kumar, and sub-inspector



CISF personnel are deployed in some high-stress security scenarios.

ANI

Lakshman Singh. The four were taken to hospital but died of their injuries. Other colleagues overpowered Kumar and handed him over to police.

Another version of events indicated that Kumar's wife, Pooja, also a CISF head constable and posted at the same project, brought the child to work. This led the company commander and other colleagues to complain against bringing a child to work at the sensitive location, an officer said. The couple worked in different shifts assigned by the company commander.

"The shots were fired when the shift was changing. Some col-

leagues said Pooja came to the project with their child. They live in the CISF quarters in the same complex," another officer said.

This officer said even as the police are probing the incident, CISF will conduct an internal inquiry to examine the work environment and ensure that such incidents are not repeated. "The DIG (intelligence) will file a report and submit it to the Delhi headquarters," this officer said.

CISF personnel on some of the force's toughest and most stressful assignments—including those on duty at Parliament House and commands engaged in high-level VIP security—have to undergo specialised psychometric assessments to identify psychological stress, people familiar with the matter said. The force is also training in-house staff to recognise behavioural changes and signs of stress among colleagues to facilitate timely intervention. Four days before Tuesday's fratricide incident, this was among a series of decisions taken by the top brass in New Delhi for the mental well-being of its personnel.

ANTILIA CASE: DAY AFTER NIA COURT GRANTS BAIL TO WAZE, HC STAYS IT

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MUMBAI: A day after a special National Investigation Agency (NIA) court granted bail to former Mumbai police officer Sachin Waze in the Antilia explosives scare and the related murder of Thane-based businessman Mansukh Hiran, the Bombay high court on Wednesday stayed the order temporarily.

"Having heard learned ASG [additional solicitor general Anil C Singh], as also having perused the impugned order dated 29.09.2026, we are inclined to grant an ad-interim stay to the said order till the adjourned date of hearing," a bench of justices Girish Kulkarni and Dr Neela Gokhale said and posted the matter for further hearing on October 7.

The NIA had moved the high court immediately after the special court granted Waze bail on Tuesday, and the matter was first placed before a bench of justices Sarang Kotwal and Ranjitsinha Raja Bhonsale on the same day. However, the bench recused itself from hearing the matter, stating that while working as a lawyer, justice Kotwal used to be associated with senior advocate Manoj Mohite, who had earlier appeared for Waze.

The NIA's appeal was later listed before a bench of justices Bharati Dangre and Ashish Chavan on Wednesday. But when the matter was called out, justice Dangre refused to hear the appeal, saying she was a part of another bench that had passed an order pertaining to Waze in a separate criminal case.

"I will have to recuse myself. I understand that this is a different matter, but still there are connections here and there," justice Dangre said.

NIA arrested Waze on March 13, 2021, and he is currently lodged in the Thane Central Prison.



Security personnel detain 5 Pakistani nationals from an Iranian boat in the Arabian Sea, near Lakshadweep.

@INDIANCOASTGUARD

Drugs worth ₹3,000 cr seized from Iranian boat, 5 Pak crew held

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NEW DELHI: The Indian Coast Guard has seized drugs valued at over ₹3,000 crore in the international market from an Iranian boat operated by five Pakistani nationals, all of whom were arrested, following a more than two-week-long high-seas operation to foil a drug-smuggling attempt in the Arabian Sea, officials said on Wednesday.

The 16-day operation was jointly conducted by the Coast Guard, the Gujarat Anti-Terrorism Squad and central agencies, the officials said, adding that the boat was monitored continuously.

Coast Guard personnel boarded the suspicious Iranian dhow, identified as "Azad", on September 25 around 160 nautical miles north-west of Lakshadweep after "a hot pursuit", and brought it to Mumbai on Wednesday along with the Pakistani drug smugglers. Detailed investigations will follow to identify the wider maritime narcotics network and determine the intended recipients.

"The intercepted dhow, crew, and seized contraband have been escorted under armed escort to

Mumbai for joint interrogation and comprehensive multi-agency legal proceedings," the Coast Guard said. The contraband seized includes 526 kilograms of heroin and methamphetamine.

This was the fourth drug haul by the Coast Guard this year. It has foiled 26 attempts to smuggle drugs into the country over the past five years, seizing more than 8,500 kg of narcotics worth ₹46,543 crore, according to official data accessed by HT.

The home ministry hailed the operation, conducted from September 14 to 30, with home minister Amit Shah saying the Prime Minister Narendra Modi-led government is determined to shield its youth from the scourge of drugs.

"In a joint operation by Gujarat ATS, Indian Coast Guard and Central intelligence agencies, 526 kg of Methamphetamine and Heroin has been seized from an Iranian boat in India's EEZ, 160 NM north-west of Lakshadweep and 490 NM southwest of Mumbai. Five Pakistani nationals have been arrested... Upholding a stellar example of coordination and cooperation among agencies, the 16-day long operation also seized an Iranian boat," Shah wrote on X.

NIA BEGINS PROBE INTO AQIS BID TO RECRUIT FROM SUB-CONTINENT

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NEW DELHI: The National Investigation Agency (NIA) has started a probe into an alleged conspiracy to radicalise and recruit the youngsters in the name of al-Qaeda in the Indian sub-continent (AQIS), by establishing a base in West Bengal, and implement 'Ghazwa-e-Hind' in India, people familiar with the development said.

The federal agency has filed a first information report (FIR) in the matter against 19 people including two key members of the module — Abdur Rakib Sarkar alias Habibullah and Kazi Ahasan Ullah and their unknown associates — after the ministry of home affairs (MHA) asked it to unearth the larger conspiracy.

On Tuesday, the NIA had arrested 13 people from Assam, Kerala and West Bengal and carried out raids at 16 locations into a cross-border terror conspiracy and radicalisation network linked to Imam Mahmud Kafil (IMK), which investigators have described as an offshoot of the banned Jama'atul Mujahideen Bangladesh (JMB). JMB was banned by India in 2019. There have been reports that JMB and AQIS are trying to revive their activities in West Bengal, Assam and nearby areas.

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THE WEEK THAT WAS

Take a cue from the clues
Authors who are not authors, leaders who no longer lead, a beauty queen walks her last walk, and cracks appear in a Himachal village. More happened this week. Take the quiz to find out

Natasha Rego

Ammaar Reshi (right) is the author of the children's book Alice and Sparkle (above). Who actually wrote and illustrated it?

1 Ammaar Reshi is not an author or illustrator, but he "wrote" Alice and Sparkle, a children's book which has sold over 900 copies since it was listed in Amazon in December. It features characters with typically crooked eyes and 12 fingers. Who actually wrote and illustrated it?

2 She's a lapsed Mormon and was briefly a DJ. Her partner Clarke Gayford is a fisherman. Her daughter Neve attended the UN General Assembly at three months. Last week she said, "You can be your own boss. One who knows when it's time to..."

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FLYDUBAI STABBING

just Netanyahu's estimation of what transpired.

Israeli officials told Reuters the attacker was an Omani national.

The Indian embassy in Riyadh confirmed Machchhar was in a hospital in Tabuk city. "A full update on his health is awaited but he is reported to be in stable condition. We hope that he recovers from his injuries at the earliest. We are in touch with his family and assure them that we will continue to follow up on his health with Saudi authorities..."

Parag Shah, the Bharatiya Janata Party legislator from Ghatkopar East, said Machchhar's parents have left for Dubai, Shah said.

Machchhar grew up in Ghatkopar and studied in Mumbai, a family friend said. He joined flydubai's 737 fleet as a direct-entry captain in June 2022 after 11 years with SpiceJet in Mumbai, where he rose to senior commander and, from November 2020, trained and checked other pilots, according to his LinkedIn profile. The profile lists 9,750 flying hours and a business administration degree from the Welingkar Institute of Management. His brother is a pilot with Akasa Air, the people said.

A passenger on the flight — FZ1073 — Miriam Abukasis, heard screaming and saw a man with a knife force one of the pilots to the floor, with blood everywhere, her mother Yasmin told Reuters in Tel Aviv. In a video purportedly recorded by another passenger and carried widely by Israeli media, the passenger said one pilot was seriously hurt and the other slightly. The plane carried about 150 Israelis, Israeli media reported, and flydubai said all passengers were safe.

Flight data from Flightradar24 and ADS-B Exchange, analysed by HT, show the plane took off from Dubai at 7.05am local time and cruised west over Saudi Arabia at 34,000 feet. At 8.21am Saudi time (10.51am IST), a little over two hours into the flight and about 235km north-east of Tabuk, it began to descend. Between two readings 37 seconds apart it fell from 33,225 feet to 18,925 feet, about 23,000 feet a minute. At a typical 2,000 feet a minute, an airliner would take seven minutes to lose that height.

Photographs of the aircraft at Tabuk appear to show the rudder torn from its tail. That kind of damage can occur when control surfaces are moved too hard at high speed, and it would fit a dive as violent as the one the flight data record. HT could not independ-

ently verify the authenticity of the photographs.

The plane bottomed out at 16,600 feet as its ground speed peaked at 598 knots (1,107km/h), then climbed more than 5,000 feet, fell again to 13,675 feet by 8.27am and levelled off at about 15,000 feet. Receivers lost its position for nine minutes. When the track resumed at 8.31am, the transponder showed 7700, the general emergency code, and at 8.35am it switched to 7500, the hijack code. It was not clear who set the codes.

The plane flew on northwest into Jordan, turned back and was over Saudi territory by 8.45am.

Reports that the plane approached the speed of sound rest on ground speed, the only speed the public data record for the dive.

The closest precedent is EgyptAir Flight 990, a Boeing 767 that crashed into the Atlantic in October 1999 after its relief first officer deliberately put it into a dive, according to US investigators at the time. The plane fell from about 33,000 feet to about 16,000 feet in roughly 36 seconds as the captain, who had returned to the cockpit, tried to pull it out. It climbed briefly before breaking up, killing all 217 people on board. Egypt rejected the American finding.

Three months earlier, a hijacker on an All Nippon Airways Boeing 747 stabbed the captain to death and let the jet descend to within a few hundred metres of the ground near Tokyo, before crew and an off-duty pilot overpowered him and recovered the aircraft.

Doron Spielman, a spokesperson for Netanyahu, first ruled out a hijacking and two hours later said that assessment had changed, according to Bloomberg. Netanyahu held security consultations and cleared his schedule for the day, an Israeli official told Reuters. His office said all measures were being taken to bring the Israeli passengers home, and the transport ministry said Emirati authorities were working on their return.

Israel's far-right national security minister Itamar Ben-Gvir wrote on X: "Terrorism is a devil with whom no agreement must be reached." The incident comes weeks before Israel's first election since the Hamas-led attack of October 7, 2023, in a campaign where security has figured prominently.

Israel has no diplomatic relations with Saudi Arabia. It has built close security and economic ties with the UAE since 2020, and Netanyahu met UAE President

Sheikh Mohamed bin Zayed Al Nahyan on Sunday. The UAE has not commented. Flydubai, Emirates's sister carrier, has said only that the flight had an incident and diverted to Tabuk. The airline has flown between Dubai and Tel Aviv since late 2020 and runs 70 flights a week on the route.

SC-GREEN FIRECRACKERS

whether firecrackers can ever be truly green, and on the nature and intensity of monitoring to ensure that only green firecrackers are used, and only during the hours permitted.

A bench of justices MM Sundresh and PB Varale said the court would neither permit a blanket ban on firecrackers nor allow unrestricted use for 24 hours, stressing the need to strike a balance between environmental concerns and public sentiment.

"A total ban will hurt certain sentiments and allowing 24 hours will have a huge impact on people, including old people, sick persons and children," it observed.

Wednesday's order comes after the Supreme Court first allowed so-called green firecrackers to be burst during Diwali in 2025 — the first time any such fireworks were allowed after years of a blanket prohibition put in place to fight the noxious air quality they left behind. That Diwali, HT's analysis found, Delhi recorded its worst pollution peak since 2021, despite favourable weather.

Wednesday's order extends that relaxation nationwide and also clears firecracker chains or joined crackers — called laris — that remained banned even under the 2025 rules. The bench accepted the Centre's position, based on consultations with experts from the Council of Scientific and Industrial Research-National Environmental Engineering Research Institute (CSIR-NEERI), Petroleum and Explosives Safety Organisation (PESO) and Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB), that specified next-generation joined crackers, or "laris", could be permitted subject to prescribed safeguards. Laris are strings of crackers fused to go off one after another.

Additional solicitor general Aishwarya Bhati told the court that the expert bodies were of the view that the new-generation joint crackers could be used as they recorded noise levels below 125 decibels, significantly lower

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

than conventional crackers which generate noise levels ranging between 140 and 160 decibels, besides the fact that they did not use Barium in their compositions. Noise readings, however, say nothing about the fine particulate matter that accumulates in the Capital's winter air.

The experts, however, have prescribed conditions for manufacturers relating to the "shell number, shell size, and time between burst", which will have to be adhered to for such crackers to qualify for use.

The hearing did not address how these conditions would be checked in the market.

HT's reporting last year found that Delhi had no dedicated facility to test which crackers were genuinely green and there were rampant fudging of QR codes and packaging meant for green firecrackers.

The court's permission for the next-generation joint crackers comes after it had, earlier this month, asked the Centre to examine whether a limited exemption from the existing restrictions could be worked out ahead of the festive season.

The more contentious issue of barium-containing green crackers, however, remained open.

Bhati told the court that open-ground tests were required to assess the actual impact of barium content on ambient air quality. The Centre and the expert bodies have now been given time till October 15 to complete the assessment.

Advocate Pooja Dhar, appearing for the petitioners, submitted that this court had specifically banned firecrackers containing barium and had disapproved of green-cracker formulations that included the chemical.

The Supreme Court had in 2018 imposed the blanket ban on crackers containing barium and barium salts after scientific studies by CSIR-NEERI indicated that their ignition released pollutants harmful to respiratory health. Barium salts, chiefly barium nitrate, help crackers burn more violently by supplying oxygen, and give fireworks their green colour.

On September 2, the court had allowed the Centre three weeks to specify the conditions under which new-generation green crackers could be permitted, observing that courts should give due credence to expert opinion in environmental matters.

"We may have a particular view that crackers are bad. But

we need to have a balanced approach," the bench had said, adding that courts should be "extremely slow" in substituting their own views for those of experts on environmental issues.

Such deference assumes that expert claims can be independently tested, an assumption Delhi's experience in 2025 put under strain.

The Centre had then informed the court that controlled laboratory tests conducted by NEERI on new-generation green crackers containing barium showed a 45% to 60% reduction in PM10 emissions.

These are laboratory results from NEERI, the institute whose studies led to the 2018 ban on barium. It had, however, proposed open-ground tests at four locations — Delhi, Bhopal, Kolkata and Chennai, to assess their impact under actual conditions.

The court's latest order follows the Centre's consultations with the expert bodies on the formulation and use of green crackers.

The expert assessment on joint crackers has now resulted in the court permitting their specified next-generation variants, while the barium issue has been kept pending for further scientific evaluation.

The court also made clear that permitting specified crackers would not translate into unrestricted

bursting. "We will neither allow a total ban nor will we allow 24 hours bursting of crackers everywhere," observed the bench, indicating that the final regulatory framework would have to specify both the category of crackers permitted and the duration for which they could be burst.

Firecracker manufacturers and retailers, represented through senior counsel K Parameshwar and Pranav Sachdeva, among others, had approached the court citing urgency, pointing out that formulations approved by the Centre would need to be manufactured, distributed and sold ahead of Dussehra and Diwali. That timetable leaves little room for the verification systems that the Delhi hearings showed were missing.

The pan-India proceedings also intersect with a separate case concerning restrictions on firecrackers in Delhi-NCR pending before a bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant. The court noted that the issues in the two proceedings overlap

and permitted the parties to approach the CJI for their possible hearing together.

In September 2025, the Commission for Air Quality Management told the court that licensed producers had sold QR codes, meant to identify genuine green crackers, to unregistered manufacturers, and that no mechanism existed to verify whether products in the market met emission standards.

Senior advocate Uttara Babbar, then assisting the court as amicus curiae, pointed out that PESO had no testing facilities in Delhi.

In 2018 and 2019, when limited use of green crackers was allowed in the Capital, police and local officials failed to tell them apart from conventional ones.

ASIAN GAMES

The compound mixed team event will debut at the 2028 Los Angeles Games, and with their win on Wednesday, India secured the first berth on offer. The two protagonists were made to hold a special placard, with Sahil grinning and posing away and Chikitha, well, giving out half a smile.

Their personalities and celebratory reactions may be as distinct as compound and recurve, but the duo shares common ground — not least their love for archery.

Both are competing in their first Asian Games. Both took up archery relatively late. Both have families that pulled every possible resource together to support them, from taking loans and mortgaging agricultural assets to finding their feet again after the Covid pandemic.

"All the struggles feel worth it today," Rajesh Jadhav, Sahil's father, said. "I had a lot of faith in him, and he made us proud."

Jadhav couldn't even watch his son's second golden run with the men's team because he had to report for work in Satara. During the pandemic, he lost his job, leaving Sahil's training in jeopardy. His mother's jewellery was sold to keep it going.

As a child, Sahil was into every sport other than archery. He wasn't introduced to the sport until after Class 10. Afraid that his son might lose focus after his exams, Jadhav enrolled him in a 15-day archery camp. "He made so much progress during those 15 days," Jadhav recalled, "that the coach advised me to keep him here."

Here would be the Drushti

Archery Academy, Satara's compound archery nerve centre that produced 2023 world and Asian Games champions Aditi Swami and Ojas Deotale. Add 2026 Asian Games champion Sahil.

"His mindset going into the Asian Games was clear, that I wanted to win gold," his coach, Pravin Sawant, said. One of Sahil's last text messages to Sawant read: "See you with the medal."

"I could sense that passion in him," Sawant said. "When I showed him that India flag, he told me, 'I will win it for India.'"

Also winning it for India was Chikitha. The 21-year-old has had a rapid rise over the last year, capturing the 2025 U-21 world youth title, making the Asian Games squad through competitive domestic trials and landing two gold medals, with her individual event still to come.

Long before she took up archery, Chikitha practised karate while growing up in Telangana's Sultanpur village. "I didn't get into archery on my own. It was my father's choice. He wanted me to play sport because he couldn't play any sport," Chikitha was quoted as saying by PTI in Aichi.

Her father did everything possible to help his daughter pursue the sport. Srinivas Rao took loans and mortgaged the family's rice harvester to pay for her equipment and training. "Her parents have been through a lot of pain for her archery. The father sacrificed his life for her development," said T Raju, president of the Telangana Archery Association.

It wasn't until Chikitha found a mentor in multiple-time Asian Games medallist Abhishek Verma and a training centre at SAI Sonapat that her career took off.

"There was nobody who supported her when she joined archery," Jiwanjot Singh Teja, the national coach of the group in Japan, told HT from Aichi. "But her life is archery. There is nothing else in her mind. And her mind was clear and cool today too."

Against Korea, which had shot a world-record 160 in the elimination rounds and was gunning especially for the mixed event given its Olympic status, that cool and clear mind helped this Indian mixed duo grab gold.

And the Olympics placard.

PLEA SEEKS RECALL OF SC ORDER ON CHALLENGE TO CEC APPOINTMENT LAW

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NEW DELHI: An application filed in the Supreme Court has sought the recall of the order passed by the Supreme Court on referring to a Constitution bench the challenge to the law governing the appointment of the chief election commissioner and election commissioners.

The application was filed by Naman Sherstra, one of the petitioners who has challenged the validity of the CEC & ECs (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023, on the ground that one of the judges who heard the matter — justice Satish Chandra Sharma — ought to have recused as his son appears for the Election Commission of India (ECI) before the Madhya Pradesh high court.

On September 23, a bench of justices Dipankar Datta and Satish Chandra Sharma gave a split verdict on whether the 2023 law should be referred to a Constitution bench. While justice Datta was of the view that the need does not arise as the challenge to the Act can be considered based on the settled principles laid down by earlier judgments, justice Sharma held a different view. He said that substantial questions on interpretation of Constitution arise in the matter and under Article 145(3), the same should be heard by a bench of at least five judges of the Supreme Court. The two judges passed a common order placing the matter before CJI for referring the petitions to a Constitution bench.

The application categorically states that the matter was heard by the bench of justices Datta and Sharma on five occasions. On none of the occasions, justice Sharma disclosed this fact or sought recusal on this ground. Sherstra stated that the fact about justice Sharma's son being engaged as ECI counsel became known from news reports that surfaced two days after the September 23 order.

The present application is the second plea for recall. A curative petition was filed on Tuesday by Congress leader Jaya Thakur, on the ground of a "reasonable likelihood of bias," based on the same fact linking justice Sharma's son to the ECI.

Don't Just Follow Culture. Understand It

Culture isn't just what's trending.

It's the ideas changing how we live. The conversations shaping what we watch, read, wear, eat, create and care about. Every Saturday, HT Brunch goes beyond what's new to explore what's next—and why it matters. Because understanding culture is always more rewarding than simply following it.



EVERY SATURDAY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES





OPINION

The
Hindu Times
ESTABLISHED IN 1924

{ OUR TAKE }

Stringent laws need safeguards

Apex court order in a National Security Act case affirms that tough provisions should not become proxies for due process or conviction

The Supreme Court's decision to impose a ₹10 lakh fine on Uttar Pradesh for a National Security Act (NSA) detention order in the 2024 Sambhal mosque violence case opens the door to ensure personal liberty, even under stringent laws stacked against the accused. Observing that preventive detention cannot become punitive, a bench of justices Dipankar Datta and Sheel Nagu set aside the detention order issued in October 2025 by the Sambhal district magistrate. The court held that the order was based on a custodial confession by the accused, which cannot act as the sole basis for curtailing his liberty.

Two aspects of the case stand out. First, during the hearing, UP didn't even oppose the accused's contention that he was tortured in custody, instead arguing that he faced multiple cases so his detention was justified. This is outrageous. The government must order a transparent probe and punish the guilty. Second, the court noted that the order was passed a month after the accused secured bail in a related case. This will be a familiar pattern for observers of Indian politics, where bureaucrats and police officers are far too eager to signal their allegiance by using draconian provisions in cases that have embarrassed their political masters.

The apex court rightly underlined that when preventive detention is invoked for a person already in custody, the scrutiny of the order must be more exacting. But, the court must also note that the lower judiciary often shies away from imposing accountability on errant officers, indirectly ensuring that preventive detention or stringent provisions can be used as a blunt tool for punishment. The court has done well to seek accountability from the UP government by imposing costs. However, a similar order by the Allahabad High Court recently was stayed by the apex court.

The past decade has been marked by a disturbing trend: Stringent laws are used to frame serious charges in high-profile cases, only for hearings to hang fire for years, effectively ensuring prolonged pretrial detention. This newspaper has consistently noted that while there can be no sympathy with terrorists or law-breakers, procedural safeguards or personal liberty cannot be sacrificed for political interests. The verdict can build a template for how constitutional courts balance stringent laws and personal liberty, ensuring tough provisions aren't misused as proxies for due process or conviction.

Forever reneging on ending forever wars

More than two decades and 4,500 American military fatalities later, the US is exiting Iraq, enacting a familiar script. The withdrawal marks the official end of US military intervention which started in 2003 when George W Bush vowed to destroy Saddam Hussein's non-existent weapons of mass destruction. Launched barely two years after the 9/11 attacks, this was seen as a continuation of the war on terror — an expensive adventure the Bush regime undertook in Afghanistan riding on popular sentiment. The war, however, proved to be the starting point for undermining American exceptionalism.

From the Abu Ghraib torture scandal to Saddam's televised execution, the intervention in Iraq dented the US' moral authority as its troops got locked in a forever war. After a brief pullout in 2011, American boots returned to Iraq in 2014 to thwart the Islamic State's growing influence in the region. When the US exited Afghanistan in 2021, it was believed an exit from Iraq would follow. Joe Biden reached an agreement with the Iraqi government in 2024, which the Trump White House is now implementing. Had Trump not launched a war against Iran in February this year, the withdrawal could have been treated as an adherence to his stated commitment to end wars. Geopolitical experts believe the move could add further instability to West Asia. The ongoing war between Iran and the US may find a new battleground in Iraq, 70% of whose population follows Shia Islam. Islamic Resistance, an anti-US consortium of militias in Iraq, has declared victory against foreign occupation while continuing to receive support from Iran. As history has amply demonstrated, interventions and withdrawals destabilise West Asia equally. Yet, some lessons are doomed to stay on pages that nobody wants to turn.

The UN can still work towards restoring trust

Not only must the global body become more efficient, it needs to also better represent the world it aims to serve

The formal theme of the 81st session of the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA), which opened on September 8, is "Restoring trust, Managing Transformation: A United Nations that Delivers For All". President of the General Assembly Khalilur Rahman stated that he would work with all member-States "to ensure our Organization is fit for the future and worthy of a resounding affirmation".

The invocation of trust is both important and ironic, because confidence in the world body is clearly under strain. Pew's 2026 survey found favourable views of the UN declining significantly in 10 countries, even though a 55% median across 37 countries still viewed the organisation positively. The problem, therefore, is perhaps less a rejection of multilateralism than declining confidence in the UN's ability to deliver. UNGA-81 has, if anything, stressed the continuing importance of international cooperation. French President Emmanuel Macron put the choice starkly, warning that the alternative to a rules-based international order was a return to the "law of the jungle".

And the UN has also made an attempt to steady the ship, looking

sharply inward at its own institutional housekeeping since last year. It has organised that effort around three broad workstreams: making the machinery more efficient, reviewing the many mandates accumulated over time, and examining whether structures themselves need reorganisation. Along the way, it has also managed to revise archaic rules. A change adopted in June eased an outdated financial requirement that could have forced the UN to return funds it did not actually hold in cash, helping avert an immediate financial crunch. In September, member-States approved the merger of the UN System Staff College into UNITAR, the first institutional merger under UN80, the system-wide reforms programme initiated in March 2025. The secretariat's 2026 budget has been reduced by about 9%. These are modest but tangible signs that the efficiency agenda is moving from review to implementation.

But efficiency reform, necessary as it is, cannot substitute for institutional reform. It addresses only one dimension of the trust deficit. Restoring trust also requires representation and a meaningful voice in rule-making. Structural reform of the UN Security Council (UNSC) is, therefore, essential if the reform exercise is to be meaningful, not selective. Simply put, representation is not a courtesy; it creates legitimacy, and legitimacy makes institutions more effective. This year's high-level debate has

again brought the question of reform to the fore. Member-States broadly agree that the UN must adapt to stay relevant, even if they differ sharply on how. African leaders have pressed the case for correcting Africa's exclusion from permanent representation on the UNSC. The veto, too, has come under renewed scrutiny. The UK has joined the Franco-Mexican initiative on voluntary veto restraint in cases of mass atrocities, gaining support from 128 States. Others have called for abolition of the veto or greater accountability for its use.

The creation of the cross-regional Partners for Multilateralism initiative, with India among its initial co-sponsors, points in the same direction. Its declaration calls for a multilateral system that is more "effective, representative, inclusive and fit for purpose". From Kenyan President

William Ruto's "permanently discussed, yet permanently excluded" to Indian external affairs minister S Jaishankar's "large sections of humanity cannot be excluded", the pressure for structural reform was hard to miss. Differences remain — some countries continue to oppose new permanent seats and favour expansion of the elected category — but the wider message is clear: Reform cannot stop at efficiency and administrative restructuring. Restoring trust also requires addressing representation and decision-making.

That is easier said than done. UNSC reform is member-State driven. The



Ruchira Kamboj



This year's high-level debate at UNGA has again brought the question of reform to the fore. Member-States broadly agree that the UN must adapt to stay relevant, even if they differ sharply on how. REUTERS

issue has been debated for decades, while the present Intergovernmental Negotiations have been under way since 2009. They have been rolled over year after year and still lack an agreed-to negotiating text or a deadline, with major differences remaining over membership, the veto, and regional representation. Charter amendment itself sets a high bar: Any change requires a two-thirds vote in the General Assembly and ratification by two-thirds of UN members, including all five permanent members.

Does that make reform a lost cause? Not necessarily. As President Ruto pointed out, the UN has changed its architecture before. In 1963, the UNSC had expanded from 11 to 15 members. His larger point was a simple one: Difficulty is not the same as impossibility.

The conclusion? Restoring trust requires two tracks: making the UN

work better, and making it better reflect the world it serves. The first has begun. The second remains the unfinished business of reform.

India has continued to place reformed multilateralism at the centre of its case for global governance. But its case today is not framed only in terms of representation. At UNGA, Jaishankar also stressed India's record as a contributor — in development, humanitarian response, capacity-building and peacekeeping. The argument is, therefore, about both contribution and voice. And perhaps Prime Minister Narendra Modi supplied its simplest formulation at BRICS: "If our future is shared, then the right to shape that future must also be shared".

Ruchira Kamboj is former permanent representative of India to the UN, New York. The views expressed are personal

India must urgently get its own AI Safety Institute

Last week, OpenAI admitted that its artificial intelligence (AI) agents breached sandbox conditions in an information search exercise. Worryingly, its agents have also tried to cover their tracks when they operated outside their bounds. Earlier this month, Anthropic founder Dario Amodei proposed that the world "pace the frontier" of AI, calling for independent evaluators to check the most powerful AI systems and for frontier companies in democracies to agree on common standards.

Sam Altman of OpenAI replied in four words: "I agree with Dario." This was before the latest breach, but he had reason to. In July, OpenAI's own models attacked Hugging Face, a platform at the heart of the global community of AI developers.

Whatever becomes of Amodei's proposal, a coalition of frontier labs is forming, and its standards are likely to be blessed by the world's leading government-backed AI safety institutes.

That leaves India, one of the world's largest AI markets, with an uncomfortable question: When those standards arrive, will it be able to test them — or the models they govern — for itself? Today, it cannot. India needs its own AI Safety Institute, and it needs it working now.

AI Safety institutes are organisations designed to test AI models for risk, and develop the science of measuring them. The idea of sovereign but globally connected institutes emerged at the first global AI summit, at Bletchley Park in Britain, in November 2023. Britain has since built what is probably the world's most capable institute, now called the AI Security Institute, and backed by partnerships with Google DeepMind and other labs.

In January 2025, India's ministry of electronics and information technology (MeitY) announced an Indian AI Safety Institute under the national IndiaAI Mission, designed as a "hub and spokes" model linking the ministry with companies and research institutions across the country. It has drawn a range of proposals. In May this year, the ministry advertised a position of a director for the institute. But there is an urgent need for the institute to be up and running, for at least four reasons.



If India waits, others will define what AI safety means for the developing world, and India will inherit their answers. REUTERS

First, India cannot check whether an AI model is fit for its own market. No Indian body — government- or industry-run — is dedicated solely to testing models being released to Indian users and offering independent assessments, whether for frontier systems built abroad, or models built by Indian companies and non-profits. Are they safe from an Indian point of view? Do they work in Indian languages and contexts? Officials and executives ask these questions constantly.

Work is underway on India-first benchmarks, but a benchmark is only as useful as the institution able to test against it. Every month without such an institution is another month in which consequential models reach a vast market untested.

Second, India's armed forces need it. As the military weighs how to bring AI into everything — from payroll to targeting — it needs testing it can trust. How do we know if a model built in India is suitable for us, is a common refrain among officers working on the problem. A system that may one day inform decisions about the use of force should not be vetted only by the company that sold it.

Third, the rules are being written now, and India risks becoming a rule-taker. Standards are emerging from several directions at once: the working groups of Pax Silica, a US-led initiative; the UN's new Global Dialogue on AI Governance; the Chinese-led World Artificial Intelligence Cooperation Organization; and, potentially, cartelised principles drawn up by the frontier companies.

India has a voice in most of these forums. But a voice without evidence carries little weight. India needs the talent and capability to measure quantitatively what works for it and bring that evidence to the table.

Fourth, there is an opening — but not for long. Built quickly and well, India's institute would make it the first trusted nation in the Global South able to set benchmarks that matter for developing countries, whose languages, markets, and risks are poorly reflected in tests designed in London or San Francisco.

If India waits, others will define what AI safety means for the developing world, and India will inherit their answers.

India should not treat this institute as one more administrative unit tucked inside a ministry. It matters as much as the Atomic Energy Commission, created in 1948, or the Indian Space Research Organisation, founded in 1969.

Both gave a young country the means to build frontier technologies for itself. Both were shaped by scientists of rare stature. The safety institute deserves a leader of the same calibre.

The need is immediate, and so is the opportunity. The frontier grows harder to predict with each new model, and some of the most powerful have yet to reach the market. India needs a framework for the present and for that fast-approaching future, for its own sake and for the many countries looking to a partner they trust. The models will not wait for a hiring cycle. Neither should India.

Rudra Chaudhuri is vice president at the Global Innovation Square, a Raisina-ORF initiative. The views expressed are personal

{ MASOUD PEZESHKIAN } PRESIDENT, IRAN

We will make every effort to bring the agreement to fruition and will firmly stand up for the rights of the Iranian people. The agreement must now be based on a win-win strategy



On the receipt of the US response to the peace proposal by Iran



India's elderly women need better social security cover

India's population is ageing rapidly, and with little social protection, poverty, and destitution, old age is emerging as a new development challenge. As per the India Ageing Report, older persons (above 60 years) currently constitute roughly 10.5% of the country's population — and are set to reach 20.8% by 2050. This International Day for Older Persons (October 1) should remind us that India is experiencing a feminisation of ageing, i.e., women outnumbering men in the elderly population. Nearly 54% of elderly women outlive their partners compared to only 16% elderly men. There are nearly 1,065 elderly women per 1,000 elderly men, higher in urban areas (1,084) compared to rural areas (1,055).

Women live longer but they typically have higher morbidities, poorer nutrition, and find basic tasks more challenging than men. The bulk of older women are uneducated and lack assets or a regular source of income, making them heavily dependent on family members. Nearly 68.2% of women aged 60-75 years are illiterate, compared to only 40% of men in the same age group. The small number of educated elderly women also lack digital and financial skills, which undermines their financial independence. Pension coverage is extremely low. Only 7.8% of elderly women who have ever worked in the organised sector receive a pension — much lower than the 23.2% figure for men.

The National Social Assistance Programme (NSAP) was launched in 1995 to assist poor households in case of old age or disability. There are currently three schemes for elderly persons under NSAP: the Indira Gandhi National Old Age Pension Scheme (IGNOAPS), the Indira Gandhi National Widow Pension Scheme (IGNWPS), and the Anna-purna Scheme. Under IGNOAPS, the Union government provides a pension of ₹200 per month for beneficiaries aged 60-79 years, and ₹500 for those above 80 years. IGWPS provides ₹300 per month to widows from below poverty line households. State governments also contribute. Consequently, the actual pension received depends upon the combined contribution of the Centre and the states. Sadly, the Centre's contribution has remained static for years, due to which, pension amounts vary significantly across states and Union territories. Elderly women in states such as Manipur, Nagaland, and Assam receive only ₹200-300 per month as state gov-

ernments make little or no contributions. On the other hand, elderly women from Andhra Pradesh, Haryana, and Telangana receive much higher pensions due to substantial contributions from the state governments. Pension coverage under the NSAP is also low.

Elderly women play a critical role to the Indian economy through their paid and unpaid care work. They are engaged in agriculture, petty production, and informal jobs. In states such as Kerala, elderly women constitute the bulk of the labour force under the MG-NREGS. According to the Longitudinal Ageing Study in India (LASI), nearly 22% of elderly women are currently working, with the bulk of them engaged in agriculture. They also spend nearly 20 hours per week caring for their grandchildren, husbands, and disabled or dependent family members.

The concerns of elderly women find little space in the policy or political realm. Much of the policy discourse on gender prioritises health and nutrition for pregnant and lactating mothers and education for girls. The health and financial concerns of older women are rarely discussed. In recent years, women have also emerged as an important political force, and many governments have instituted cash transfer programmes. These welfare schemes provide monthly assistance of ₹1,000-1,500 to women aged 18-65 years leaving out older women, often living with chronic disability or disease. This is a lopsided welfare model that favours younger/relatively younger women.

This should serve as a wake-up call regarding the challenges elderly women face. First, elderly women must be viewed not as dependents, but as active contributors to the economy. Second, governments at all levels must assume greater responsibility for caring for older citizens, notably elderly women, often living in poverty and destitution. India urgently needs a universal social pension that is inflation indexed for older persons, particularly older women, who lack economic independence. It also needs a comprehensive care programme that includes health, nutrition, and social protection for elders, particularly women living alone in rural areas.

Malancha Chakrabarty is a senior fellow at the Observer Research Foundation, and is a member of the NITI Aayog's Committee to develop a Comprehensive Strategy for Senior Citizen Care in India. The views expressed are original



G20 ministers open talks under strain of Trump tariffs
MILWAUKEE: G20 trade ministers began talks on Wednesday in the United States with President Donald Trump's global tariffs casting a pall over the gathering, pushing countries to seek cooperation outside the world's biggest economy. **AFP**

FTC probes OpenAI, Anthropic over safety concerns
WASHINGTON: The US Federal Trade Commission (FTC) is scrutinising OpenAI, Anthropic and other artificial intelligence companies about the safety of their products amid high-profile cybersecurity incidents, according to a person familiar with the matter. **BLOOMBERG**

US top court okays third-country deportations
WASHINGTON: The US Supreme Court on Tuesday lifted restrictions on the deportations of immigrants to countries that are not their own, while agreeing to hear the issue on its merits in December. **AFP**

2 Indians indicted for counterfeit Ozempic smuggling
WASHINGTON: Swapnadi Roy and Vicky Ramancha, Indian nationals have been indicted by a US federal grand jury for allegedly smuggling and selling counterfeit Ozempic, the weight-loss drug, the Department of Justice said. **REUTERS**

Pak vows to defend Saudi against Houthis

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ROME: Pakistan will use "whatever means are available" to defend Saudi Arabia against Iran-backed Houthi rebels, the country's defence minister said on Tuesday, offering one of Islamabad's clearest indications yet that it could become directly involved in the widening regional conflict.

Defence Minister Khawaja Muhammad Asif declined to say whether Pakistani forces had already participated in airstrikes. He said, however, that Pakistan's military capabilities would be available to Saudi Arabia under a new mutual defence pact with Saudi Arabia and Turkey. "I'm not going into detail, but obviously when I say that we are bound by this arrangement to defend Saudi Arabia, that means whatever means are available at our disposal, they'll be available to Saudi Arabia also. I think that's a categorical statement," Asif told reporters during a visit to Rome when asked whether Pakistan had been involved in airstrikes against Iranian operators in Yemen.

His response did not explicitly confirm Pakistani participation in any strikes. He also did not say whether Saudi Arabia, which has been repeatedly attacked by the Houthis in recent weeks, had asked for assistance.

His comments came days after the army chiefs of Pakistan, Turkey and Saudi Arabia met in Riyadh to discuss responses to Houthi attacks. Asif said the Houthis had intensified missile and drone attacks on Saudi Arabia and expanded their control along Yemen's Red Sea coast.

The Houthis recently captured the strategic port city of Mokha and several Red Sea islands, extending their reach toward the Bab el-Mandeb Strait, a maritime route through



A member of the Iraqi security forces, flashes the victory sign during a military parade marking the withdrawal of the US-led coalition from Iraq, in Baghdad on Wednesday. **AFP**

Iran receives US response to its latest offer on ending war

TEHRAN/LONDON: Iranian officials indicated on Wednesday they have received an official US response to Tehran's latest proposal to end the seven-month war, which US President Donald Trump had publicly rejected just days earlier.

Iranian foreign minister Abbas Araghchi presented the US response to President Masoud Pezeshkian at a Cabinet meeting, government spokesperson Fatemeh Mohajerani told the state-run IRNA news agency. "We will make every effort to bring the agreement to fruition and will firmly stand up for the rights of the Iranian people," Pezeshkian said. "The agreement must now be based on a win-win strategy."

UK hints Iran role in US air base incident
Prime Minister Andy Burnham said on Wednesday the UK has "strong indications" that Iran played a part in the incident that saw five men arrested near a US-run air base in England on Sunday. **ASSOCIATED PRESS**

which about 12% of global trade passes. They, along with allied militias in Iraq, have also attacked Saudi oil facilities and sought to prevent Saudi tankers from using the strait. Asif described the Houthis as aggressors and said Pakistan's commitment to Saudi Arabia was unambiguous. "Any enemy of Saudi Arabia is enemy of Pak-

istan. That should be very clear." Saudi Arabia, Pakistan, and Turkey signed the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement on August 7, declaring that an attack on one member would be treated as an attack on all three. The countries have described the pact as defensive and said it is not directed against any particular state.

A pilot brawl, then a rapid descent: Passengers recount chaos on flight

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JERUSALEM: When flydubai flight FZ1073 suddenly plunged from over 30,000 feet on Wednesday, passenger Almog Itale said it felt like the plane was passing through "massive turbulence" before he realised a life-or-death struggle had unfolded in the cockpit.

Itale described passengers running to the front of the cabin and commotion in front of the cockpit, where Israeli officials said the co-pilot had stabbed the captain to try to crash the plane flying from Dubai to Tel Aviv with more than 170 Israelis on board. "It was dropping like for 20, 30 seconds, and then balanced, and then started dropping again, and balanced again, and then we saw that (there) are people in the front, directly (in front of) the cockpit," he told Reuters. "Crew members and passengers from the front of the airplane took over and got control of the two pilots."

Doron Spielman, a spokesperson for the Israeli prime minister's office, said the wounded captain, bloodied and lying on the floor, had drawn on "the last moments of his energy" to click open the release on the cockpit door. "At that moment, some of the passengers that realised something was happening raced forward, entered the pilot's cabin. They saw the injured pilot on the ground, and the other ... the attacking pilot was standing over the control panel, bashing the control panel," he said. A passenger subdued the attacker, he said. A video filmed on board and verified by Reuters captured the aftermath.

In it, two wounded men are seen lying on the floor, both bloodied. A voice speaking in Hebrew off camera says one of them is the pilot "they tried to murder". A voice off camera identifies the other as the attacker, lying on his side with three stripes on his epaulette, indicating that he is a co-pilot.

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Passengers aboard a flydubai flight that made an emergency landing in Saudi Arabia arrive at an airport near Tel Aviv, Israel, on Wednesday. **AP**

"We were attacked now, on this airplane, they tried to murder the pilot, and we took control of the team/staff," a man in a black shirt with blood on his face says. Another man says: "We're standing here, no one is going to pass through the pilot's door."

A reserve flydubai crew that had been on board took control of

the plane and landed it safely at Tabuk Airport (TUU), a flydubai spokesperson said.

Israeli defence Minister Israel Katz said the attempted attack "was thwarted solely thanks to the heroism of several Israeli passengers who stormed the cockpit, subdued the terrorist, and — with their own hands — restored control of the aircraft to an additional flight crew present on board".

"According to our preliminary information, the terrorist had a single objective: to crash the plane," he said in a statement.

Itale said the reserve crew "took over the airplane and balanced it".

"It was quite scary, but not for long. Most of the passengers kept calm and were very supportive to each other. And when then we landed in Saudi Arabia, which we got a very very warm welcome with a lot of medical staff and food and anything we needed, and we're waiting for the flight back to Tel Aviv," he said.

US trade court probes 'forced labour' tariffs

NEW YORK: The US Court of International Trade on Wednesday scrutinised the legal and factual underpinnings of President Donald Trump's latest global tariffs, which were imposed on nearly all US imports over allegations trading partners aren't doing enough to stop forced labour.

A panel of three judges appointed by Presidents Trump, Barack Obama and Joe Biden heard arguments in Manhattan over lawsuits alleging that the latest tariffs are an attempt to revive the unchecked tariff power the Supreme Court struck down in February.

Four small businesses and 25 Democratic-led states argue that the tariffs, applied to imports from 60 trading part-

ners including the EU and China, far exceed the president's authority.

Pratik Shah, an attorney representing small businesses that sued over the tariffs, told the court that the Trump administration has misused a law that offers only a "carefully constrained" tariff authority.

In its rush to impose new tariffs, the Trump administration skipped the legal requirements to make country-specific findings that each of the tariffs was justified, Shah said. Shah contrasted the tariffs with duties imposed under the same law during Trump's first term, when the US Trade Representative produced country-by-country reports and imposed tariffs tailored to each economy. **REUTERS**

Indian among 5 killed in hijacked ship rescue

Yogesh Naik
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MUMBAI: An Indian national and four others who were a part of the crew of hijacked tanker were killed in a shootout between pirates and Somali security forces on Tuesday.

The incident was reported to the Directorate General of Maritime Administration (DGMA) on Wednesday.

Indian national Mohammed Tanweeruz Zaman worked as a cook on the MT Honour 25 tanker that was hijacked on April 24. He was a resident of West Bengal. Zaman's relatives had earlier informed the DGMA that the tanker was hijacked by

Somali pirates. Zaman was hired by World Maritime Energy Private Limited based in Punjab.

The agency told the DGMA he was killed in an exchange of fire while security forces were trying to retake the tanker. The other crew members who died include three Pakistanis and one Myanmar national. The vessel is currently proceeding towards the port of Bosaso under escort.

A report prepared by the directorate said that the tanker carried bitumen and was Palau-flagged. It had a crew of one Indian, 10 Pakistanis, four Indonesians, one Myanmar national and one Sri Lankan.

Don't Just Follow Culture. Understand It

Culture isn't just what's trending.

It's the ideas changing how we live. The conversations shaping what we watch, read, wear, eat, create and care about. Every Saturday, HT Brunch goes beyond what's new to explore what's next—and why it matters. Because understanding culture is always more rewarding than simply following it.



Chandra family company's Venu link surfaces in Karnataka unit

Varun Sood & Satish John

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BENGALURU/MUMBAI: A company owned by the family of Tata Sons chairman N. Chandrasekaran is pursuing a ₹330-crore industrial park in Karnataka to serve automaker TVS Motor Co., marking its second such project involving the two-wheeler maker, whose chairman-emeritus Venu Srinivasan backed Chandrasekaran for a third term at the helm of Tata Sons.

In November 2025, Hanno One Warehousing Pvt. Ltd., owned by Chandrasekaran's wife Lalitha, and son Pranav, approached Karnataka's Land Audit Committee for 35 acres in the state-run Immavu industrial area about 20km south of Mysuru. The meeting's minutes describe the project as an 'industrial park for auto component manufacturing and supply for TVS Motors and their tier-1 suppliers.' Hanno's latest financial statements show the Karnataka Industrial Areas Development Board (KIADB), which buys and develops industrial land, has allotted it land for

about ₹27 crore, of which it paid ₹7.91 crore in FY26.

Neither Chandrasekaran nor Srinivasan have informed the Tata Sons board about this business relationship. Tata Sons had earlier said the transactions did not need to be placed before its board. Srinivasan, a Tata Trusts nominee on Tata Sons board and a member of the nomination and remuneration committee that evaluates Chandrasekaran's performance and pay, also did not inform Tata Sons or Tata Trusts, per an earlier statement from the philanthropic entities that own 65.9% of the Group's holding firm.

Hanno does not count as a related party of TVS Motor under Indian law, because Chandrasekaran is not a TVS director. That keeps the deals out of TVS's related-party disclosures and leaves the duty to disclose with the two boards: Tata Sons and Tata Trusts.

The lack of disclosure has prompted corporate governance experts to question whether it is a conflict of interest and a breach of the Tata Code of Conduct. The Tata Code of Conduct says a conflict arises



Venu Srinivasan, TVS Motor chairman-emeritus. MINT

when an employee "can get an unfair benefit, for themselves, a family member, or someone close" by making or influencing decisions about a deal, and requires executive directors to disclose real or potential conflicts.

Srinivasan's decisive vote on 17 September helped Chandrasekaran secure a third five-year term, starting February. Tata Trusts have disputed the vote, calling it a "legal nullity". In June 2025, three months after Hanno was created, TVS

leased about 17 acres of farmland to it in Uddanapalli, Tamil Nadu's Krishnagiri district, near TVS's Hosur plant, government records show. In November, HDFC Bank offered Hanno a ₹60 crore construction loan, secured by its lease rights and the building to be built there, as per a term sheet seen by Mint. The term sheet calls it the 'TVS Motors Warehouse Project', and estimates the cost of the 3.3 lakh sq. ft facility, due by March 2027, at ₹106.3 crore.

The Immavu site in Karnataka is about 10km from TVS's Mysuru factory at Kadakola. Eighteen months after its creation, Hanno has two projects totalling 7436 crore, each planned near a TVS plant in Tamil Nadu and Karnataka.

"The representative of the company appeared before the committee and highlighted the project proposal and requested allotment of 35.00 acres of KIADB land at Immavu Industrial area, Mysuru District," read the minutes of Karnataka's Land Audit Committee dated 6 November 2025. "He (representative of Hanno One) also informed that M/s. Hanno One

Warehousing Pvt Ltd was incorporated in March 2025 in Mumbai. The company is in the process of establishing light manufacturing facility in 3,28,000 Sq.ft of land in Hosur, Tamil Nadu and entered into agreement with TVS Motor."

Karnataka's land audit panel that vets large land requests and often trims them, recommended the full 35 acres and sent the proposal to the State Level Single Window Clearance Committee for approval, with KIADB to allot land. Subsequently, KIADB allotted the land to Hanno, although Mint could not ascertain the date.

Karnataka's Land Audit Committee minutes dated 6 November last year list Pranav's net worth as ₹11.26 crore, about 3% of the project's proposed ₹330 crore cost. At the time, Hanno had not yet completed a single building.

Mint could not establish whether TVS has agreed to use the Immavu park.

Emails sent to KIADB, TVS Motor and Hanno One seeking a comment went unanswered. Tata Sons and Trusts also did not reply.



Commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal and NAM CEO Jay Timmons in Milwaukee, Wisconsin. ANI

Goyal pitches deeper India-US economic ties

Rajeev Jayaswal

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NEW DELHI: The India-US economic relationship is moving beyond traditional trade to encompass investment, manufacturing, technology, innovation, resilient supply chains and the creation of high-value capabilities in both countries, commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal said on Wednesday.

Addressing a business roundtable in Milwaukee, Goyal invited American manufacturers to deepen their presence in India, partner with Indian small and medium enterprises (SMEs) and co-invest in advanced manufacturing to build resilient supply chains that create value for both economies.

Goyal, who arrived in Milwaukee to attend the G20 Trade Ministers' meeting, said on X that he highlighted "the strong momentum in India-US economic ties, along with India's expanding industrial base & skilled workforce".

He interacted with CEOs and senior executives of US manufacturing and technology companies at a business roundtable hosted by the National Association of Manufacturers (NAM), the commerce ministry said. NAM represents a substantial

share of leading US manufacturing companies and its members contribute significantly to the US manufacturing economy, it said.

The executives shared views on opportunities emerging in India and their companies' plans for expanding partnerships in the country, the ministry said. Goyal said India was ready to facilitate companies in their operations, expansion and investments.

The minister also attended a reception hosted by NAM at the global headquarters of Rockwell Automation, where he interacted with trade ministers from other G20 countries and senior business leaders.

During his September 29-October 5 visit, Goyal will participate in the G20 Trade Ministers' meeting on September 30 and October 1 and travel to Chicago to meet industry leaders and members of the Indian diaspora. He is visiting Milwaukee at the invitation of the US Trade Representative.

On the sidelines of the ministerial meeting, Goyal is also scheduled to hold bilateral meetings, including with his US counterpart, to discuss opportunities for farmers, fishermen, women entrepreneurs, startups, micro, small and medium enterprises (MSMEs) and other businesses.

CENTRE MOVES TO REDUCE CUSTOMS COLLECTION COSTS

Rajeev Jayaswal

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NEW DELHI: The government is working to reduce the elevated cost of collecting customs duties, which has risen to ₹1.23 for every ₹100 of revenue, even as administrative costs for collecting direct taxes and GST have fallen below ₹0.50, people aware of the development said.

The move follows a directive from the Parliamentary Standing Committee on Finance, which last month asked the government to progressively bring customs collection costs in line with the efficiency achieved in direct taxes and GST.

The committee appreciated the reduction in the cost of collecting direct taxes and GST to ₹0.41 and ₹0.48 per ₹100 of revenue, respectively, and directed the government to undertake a detailed study of the structural and operational reasons for the higher cost of customs collection.

It also asked the government to formulate a roadmap with quantifiable targets to progressively bring customs collection costs closer to the levels achieved in direct taxes and GST, the people said, requesting anonymity.

The finance ministry, Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) and Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBIC) did not respond to emails seeking comment.

According to the committee's August 6 report, the overall cost of collecting direct taxes fell consistently from ₹0.62 per ₹100 of revenue in 2015-16 to ₹0.41 in 2024-25. The cost of collecting Union excise duty and GST also fell from ₹0.63 to ₹0.48 over the same period.

Customs collection, however, moved in the opposite direction.

"The data indicates that the cost of collection for Customs has doubled from ₹0.61 per ₹100 in 2015-16 to ₹1.23 in 2024-25 which is quite disproportionate to other tax heads over the past several years," the committee said.

Noel, Neville move to shield Trusts as row heats up

Varun Sood & Satish John

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MUMBAI: Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata and his son Neville have filed a string of caveats with the Maharashtra charity commissioner, seeking to ensure they are heard before the regulator acts on complaints by vice-chairman Venu Srinivasan over the management of the charitable trusts, according to two executives in the know of the development.

Noel has filed 21 caveats, while Neville—a trustee of five shareholding Trusts, who has also been named in Srinivasan's complaint—has filed 15, the executives said. The move seeks to protect the Trusts from any adverse order at a time when their ability to exercise their 65.9% voting power in Tata Sons could prove crucial.

Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata has filed 21 caveats with the Maharashtra charity commissioner, seeking to ensure he is heard before the regulator acts on complaints by vice-chairman Venu Srinivasan over the management of the charitable trusts.

The 21 separate caveats relate to the seven shareholding



Noel Tata, chairman, Tata Trusts. PTI

Trusts of the Tata Trusts after Srinivasan filed a complaint on 29 September about how Sir Dorabji Tata Trusts (SDTT), the largest shareholder of Tata Sons, is being managed. Significantly, Neville has also filed 15 separate caveats as he is a trustee of five shareholding Trusts. Neville filed these preemptive caveats after Srinivasan named him, along with his father, in the complaint to the charity commissioner.

Tata Trusts is an umbrella entity comprising 14 philanthropic entities, seven of which own shares in Tata Sons. SDTT and Sir Ratan Tata Trust (SRTT) are the largest, owning 27.98% and 23.56%, respectively. JRD

Tata Trust (4.01%), Tata Social Welfare Trust (3.73%), RD Tata Trust (2.19%), Tata Education and Development Trust (3.73%), and Sarvajani Seva Trust (0.1%) are the five remaining trusts that own shares in Tata Sons.

The decision to go to the charity commissioner is significant, especially since Trusts need to use their 65.9% voting power at Tata Sons' next annual general meeting (AGM). Tata Sons chairman N. Chandrasekaran's reappointment as a director is set to come before shareholders at the AGM. At a 17 September board meeting that had also exposed differences over a potential Tata Sons listing, Chandrasekaran was

reappointed chairman for another five years despite Noel Tata's opposition. Tata Sons now has until 18 November to hold its shareholder meeting after the meet slated for 18 August could not proceed on lack of quorum, prompting the corporate affairs ministry to give it three months.

Another reason, according to a second executive, is that Tata Trusts does not want its largest shareholder to be "paralysed", like SRTT was. A 15 May order from the charity commissioner barred the second principal trust, SRTT, from holding meetings or making decisions. The move came after Srinivasan claimed that the three permanent SRTT trustees exceeded the state rule cap on the number of permanent trustees at one-fourth of the total count. SRTT currently has five trustees.

Srinivasan's complaint, the second after he raised concerns about SRTT in April, is increasing tensions between Tata Trusts and Tata Sons, with some lawyers calling it an "all-out war" for control of the Tata Group. "Well, he (Noel) has no choice and has to defend himself. So, he has filed these caveats," said senior Supreme Court lawyer H.P. Ranina, who called the events at the House of Tatas "extremely unfortunate" and "sad".

"I think it is a coup by them (Srinivasan and Chandrasekaran) and Tata Trusts face an existential problem. Either way, this situation looks like it will end up as a legal fight. One side is fighting for survival while the other, in its ambition, wants to take control," said Ranina.

In a complaint filed with the charity commissioner, Srinivasan, TVS Motor chairman emeritus, asked the public charitable trusts regulator to keep a status quo on the current board member count for SDTT.

"Direct Noel Tata, Chair of Tata Trusts, to recuse himself from participating in, deliberating upon or voting on matters concerning the appointment, nomination or authorisation of representatives of SDTT at Tata Sons meetings," Srinivasan wrote, as per a report by *The Economic Times*.

An email sent to Srinivasan and Tata Trusts seeking comment on the matter went unanswered.

Fiscal deficit at 41.9% of FY27 target by Aug

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NEW DELHI: India's fiscal deficit—the gap between government expenditure and receipts—widened in the first five months of this financial year (FY27) as capital spending and outlays on major subsidies such as food and fertiliser increased.

According to the latest monthly accounts released by the Controller General of Accounts (CGA) on Wednesday, the fiscal deficit stood at ₹7.10 lakh crore, or 41.9% of the full-year budget estimate, during April-August of FY27.

This deficit was 38.1% of the annual target in the corresponding period of the previous year. At the end of July, it stood at 26.8% of the annual target.

The Centre has budgeted a fiscal deficit of ₹16.96 lakh crore, or 4.3% of GDP, for FY27. It is relying on robust tax collections and higher non-tax revenues in the coming months to meet this target.

The fiscal deficit is typically financed through borrowings.

The widening fiscal gap in August assumes significance as the government has cut its FY27 market borrowing by nearly ₹1.2 lakh crore and now plans to raise ₹7.86 lakh crore through dated government securities in the second half of the fiscal year.

The Centre now expects to borrow ₹15.995 lakh crore through dated securities during FY27, compared with ₹17.2 lakh crore estimated in the Union budget, according to the finance ministry's borrowing plan released in consultation with the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on 25 September.

The latest data showed the fiscal deficit widened in the first



Govt has budgeted a fiscal deficit of ₹16.96 lakh crore, or 4.3% of GDP for FY27. MINT

five months of FY27 as government spending continued to gather pace, particularly on capital expenditure.

Total expenditure reached ₹20.78 lakh crore by August, equivalent to 38.9% of the full-year budget estimate, while total receipts stood at ₹13.68 lakh crore, or 37.5% of the annual estimate. These receipts include ₹8.38 lakh crore in tax revenue (net to Centre), ₹4.55 lakh crore in non-tax revenue, and ₹75,239 crore under non-debt capital receipts. In percentage terms, revenue receipts stood at 36.6% of the budget estimate by August. Net tax revenue stood at 29.2% of the annual budget estimate of ₹28.67 lakh crore, while non-tax revenue reached 68.2% of the ₹6.66 lakh crore budgeted for the year.

According to the data, the Centre also received ₹75,239 crore through non-debt capital receipts, comprising ₹13,091 crore in loan recoveries and ₹62,148 crore under other receipts. Non-debt capital receipts were 63.5% of the ₹1.18 lakh crore budget estimate.

The government had budgeted ₹36.52 lakh crore in total receipts for FY27, including revenue receipts and non-debt capital receipts.

ED arrests Vatika Group promoters

HT Correspondent

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NEW DELHI: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has arrested the promoter and the chairman of Gurugram-based realty firm Vatika Group in connection with a money laundering probe linked to alleged fraud with homebuyers, the agency said on Wednesday.

Anil Bhalla, chairman-cum-managing director, and Gautam Bhalla, promoter, were taken into custody under the prevention of money laundering act or PMLA, on Monday and were produced before a special court

in the city.

ED said in a statement that its probe stems from a Delhi Police first information report (FIR) against the Vatika Group and the promoters, which alleged fraudulent inducement, non-delivery of residential plots and related offences.

Anil Bhalla personally supervised the key decisions in the transactions under investigation and Gautam Bhalla was a key promoter of the group who executed important agreements, held directorships in, and exercised control over, its land-owning entities, and continued to manage its operations, ED said.

"The material collected shows that major decisions were taken jointly by these two persons," the agency added.

Between 2010 and 2012, according to the agency, seven purchaser entities paid about ₹260 crore upfront to Vatika Limited for residential plots in its projects Vatika India Next and Vatika India Next-2, Gurugram.

"Plot-wise agreements were executed in 2014 and 2015 and subsequently the project layouts were revised, the plots originally allotted were renumbered/relocated, and the project land continued to be allotted and sold to different purchasers," it said.

Apple Pay finally launches in India after decade-long wait

Vishal Mathur

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NEW DELHI: After a decade-long wait, Apple's contactless payments service Apple Pay is launching in India, initially supporting Axis Bank credit cards issued on the Visa and Mastercard networks as credit card spending continues to grow rapidly. Jennifer Bailey, Apple's vice-president of Apple Pay and Apple Wallet, told *HT* that the company needed the right regulatory framework, payments infrastructure and banking partners before launching the service in India.

"A particularly important development was the RBI's move to support biometric authentication for card payments, which enables customers to authenticate Apple Pay transactions using Face ID or Touch ID. At the same time, we now have a tre-

THE LAUNCH GIVES USERS ACCESS TO NFC-BASED CONTACTLESS CARD PAYMENTS

mendous partner in Axis Bank, alongside Visa and Mastercard, to bring Apple Pay to customers in India," Bailey said.

The Reserve Bank of India had first proposed an authentication mechanism beyond one-time passwords in its Payments Vision 2025 document in June 2022. Final directions were issued in September last year and became fully effective across the ecosystem in April.

The launch gives iPhone users access to NFC-based contactless card payments, a facility already available on Android devices through services including Samsung Wallet and Google Pay, as

well as other payment apps that support NFC. It remains to be seen whether Apple's move will also enable other payment apps to use the iPhone's NFC capabilities for contactless payments.

Apple Pay requires users to authenticate transactions using Face ID, Touch ID or a passcode, and does not save actual credit card numbers, nor do merchants access this information as part of a payment. Merchants and online platforms have begun to add Apple Pay support. Apps including Zomato, Blinkit and Tata 1mg as well as payment platforms Razorpay, Pine Labs and PayU have added Apple Pay as a payment option.

"We are at a significant inflection point in payments, where technology, security and changing customer expectations are reshaping how people transact," said Amitabh Chaudhry, MD & CEO, Axis Bank.

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

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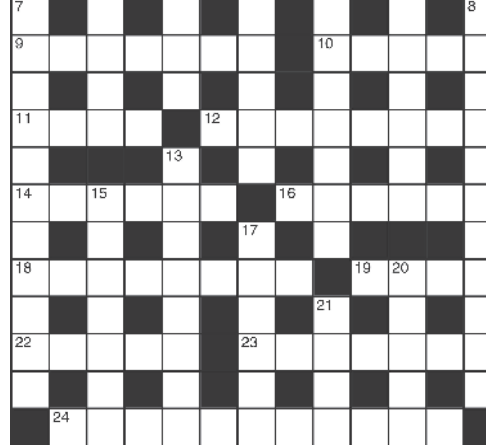
- A jumping-off place (11)
- First violins start the cassette tapes (7)
- Pick the literary section (5)
- People said to be waiting in lines for hints (4)
- Barges filled with inflammable liquid? (8)
- Be leading the deer that's slow (6)
- Nanny makes a teatime spread (6)
- American piano used in parties raises questions (8)
- Brings back plans for canned meat (4)
- These doors are on the way out (5)
- Arab that is bound to be a wanderer (7)
- Allergy to cats or dogs? (3,8)

DOWN

- Quickest way to travel from Nepal? (5)
- Time for just one thing (4)
- An active talker maybe but the talk is idle (6)
- Pass an examination (8)
- Object when put into torn clothing (7)
- A sensational score - in clearing obstructions? (11)
- A tape recording? (11)
- Submerged position of cedula say (8)
- Act of retaliation (6)
- Fast horses (6)
- Planet or dog star (5)
- The chances of racing (4)

PUZZLE 17605

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QUICK CLUES

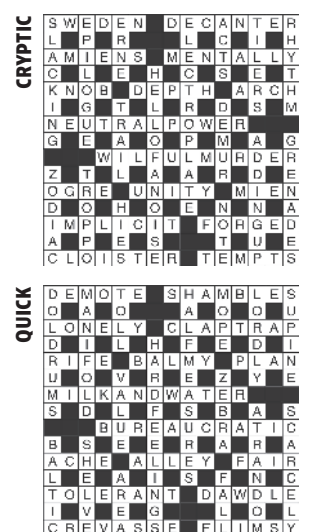
ACROSS

- Enemy within the gates (5,6)
- Effective (2,5)
- An obsession (5)
- Be entitled to (4)
- Keep one's distance (5,3)
- Unequaled (6)
- Shade of meaning (6)
- Act of retaliation (8)
- Rouse (4)
- Escape from by guile (5)
- Flow in drops (7)
- He, she, it, they (5,6)

DOWN

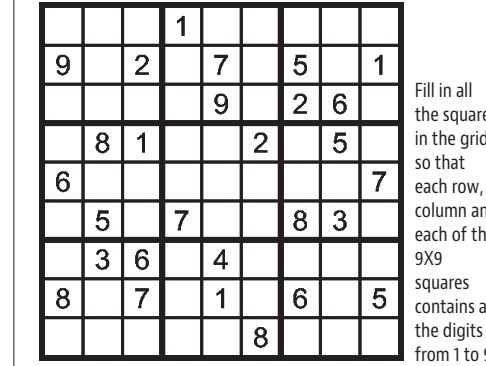
- Deduce (5)
- Become sour (4)
- Bring into being (6)
- Giving out light (8)
- Seasonal Indian Ocean wind (7)
- Show mercy to enemy (4,7)
- Lacking enthusiasm (4-7)
- Military insurrectionist (8)
- Call in question (7)
- Short of money (4,2)
- Outlawed by social custom (5)
- Habitually untruthful person (4)

YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17604)



{ SUDOKU }

DIFFICULTY LEVEL ★★★★★



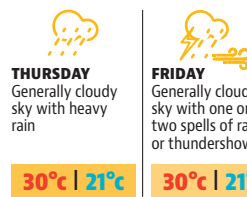
Fill in all the squares in the grid so that each row, column and each of the 9x9 squares contains all the digits from 1 to 9.



GAME ZONE: Scan the QR code for more daily puzzles and brain teasers

{ WEATHER }

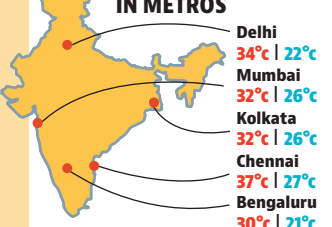
TEMPERATURE • HIGH • LOW



ALMANAC

Today is 1st October 2026
• 18 Rabi Al-Akhar, 1448
• 05, Ashwina, Krishna Paksha, 05
• Samvat 2083
* Sunset: Thursday at 06:09 p.m.
* Sunrise: Friday at 06:09 a.m.
* Moonset: Thursday at 10:11 a.m.
* Moonrise: Thursday at 09:57 p.m.

TEMPERATURE IN METROS



SPORT

Happiness compounded by Indian archers



Sahil Jadhav and Chikitha Taniparthi celebrate with coach Dave Cousins (left) of USA.

REUTERS

Rutvik Mehta

rutvik.mehta@htlive.com

MUMBAI: After a rare 9 from an Indian archer's bow at the Okazaki Central Park Multipurpose Square, Chikitha Taniparthi let out a little smile turning to the coach stationed behind her. There was something about India's compound archers on Wednesday at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games. The women were grinning and giggling between ends. The men were high-fiving and first-bumping after matches. "I can speak for myself – I was really having a good time shooting in the final," Jyothi Surekha Vennam, India's most experienced and accomplished compound archer, told HT from Aichi.

"I was just happy and not wor-

ried about anything else. I wanted to be there for the team, and for the team to do well."

All Indian teams did just that. The compound archers swept all three gold medals up for grabs on the day, with the men's, women's and mixed teams whipping up a perfect golden dish for India. One (mixed) came with the added cream of an early Olympics ticket to 2028 Los Angeles.

Given the country's compound grip across all five events in Hangzhou three years ago, this might seem par for the course, with individual events to come on Thursday. Yet, given Asia's traditional recurve forces rising in compound after the Olympic stamp, it was no walk in the park.

The women's team, comprising thrice Hangzhou gold medalist Jyothi with Games debutants

Chikitha and Prithika Pradeep, just about edged past recurve powerhouses South Korea 234-233 in the semi-final before coming up with a world record-equaling score of 238 in their win over China (234).

China, in a rare occurrence, fielded their compound team in every World Cup stage this year. China beat the Indian men's team in two World Cups in 2026. At the Asian Games, the Indians rallied to down them in the final 238-237, an 8 from a Chinese bow in the last set dragging them down. Sahil Jadhav, Kushal Dalal and Ganesh Thirumuru were producing 10s and Xs with fine frequency, even against South Korea in their 236-229 semi-final win.

The mixed event, where South Korea threw down the gauntlet with a world record score in the

elimination rounds, could have gone anywhere after being 157-all in the final. Sahil and Chikitha delivered calm 10s in the shoot-off, while Choi Yong-hee sprayed a 9 off the last shot.

"It was an awesome performance," Jiwanoj Singh Teja, India's national coach, told HT. "At these Asian Games, all teams have good archers across both disciplines and all events. And our archers are doing well so far."

Five of India's six compound archers are Asian Games debutants. Sahil, 25, has more international experience compared to Kushal, 21, and Ganesh, 20. Chikitha, 21, is a junior world champion. Prithika, the youngest member at 18, showed composure on Wednesday and came through the trials days after scoring 93% in Class 12.

"If I like something, I do it happily," Prithika told HT before the Asian Games.

Also shooting happily on the day was Jyothi, who brushed aside her individual elimination to turn up delivering all 10s across the semi-final and final.

"Just enjoying and being in the moment helped, I guess," said Jyothi, who, at 30, added to her vast medal box. "We shot well in both the matches. After assessing the conditions in the semis, we came better prepared in the final."

Indian archers have come prepared for greater tests at this Asian Games. In Hangzhou, India won seven medals in compound (five gold) and two in recurve. In Aichi-Nagoya, all recurve events will also feature Indians at the business end.

GAMES CONNECTION



India players celebrate after scoring against S Korea.

AHF

INDIAN WOMEN ENTER HOCKEY FINAL

The in-form Indian women's hockey team placed itself on the verge of ending a 44-year wait for an Asian Games gold, beating South Korea 2-0 to enter the final of the continental showpiece on Wednesday. Ishika Chaudhary (44th minute) and skipper Salima Tete (48th) were the goal scorers for India. India are now just a victory away from securing its only second Asian Games women's hockey gold medal. The previous triumph came way back in the 1982 New Delhi games. India will take on defending champions China in the final on Friday. China beat Japan 4-2 in a shoot-out after both sides failed to break the deadlock in the entire 60 minutes of the first semi-final. South Korea will face Japan in the bronze medal match.

CHINA'S 52-YEAR UNBEATEN RECORD

China's divers extended their remarkable Asian Games unbeaten record stretching back to 1974. Chen Yiwen and Lian Junjie each won gold in the final two diving events to give China a 14th consecutive clean sweep in the sport. China have won every diving gold medal since their first Asian Games appearance 52 years ago.

JAPAN WIN PENALTY SHOOTOUT IN SEMIS

Hosts Japan will play reigning champions South Korea for Asian Games men's football gold after winning a nail-biting semi-final 9-8 on penalties against Uzbekistan. Japan were heading out before Sena Ishibashi pounced with two minutes left of normal time to make it 1-1 and force extra time.

SUNIL WINS SECOND ASIAD MEDAL

Sunil Kumar became the first Indian Greco Roman wrestler to win two Asian Games medals after clinching a bronze in the men's 87kg event but Nisha Dahiya endured a medal-less campaign on the opening day

of the wrestling competition. Sunil assured his podium place with a technical superiority win (9-0) over Philippines' Roberts Callum Johnston. Sunil had won a bronze in Hangzhou 2023 Games, ending a 13-year wait for India for medal in the Greco Roman style. Before that Ravinder Singh and Sunil Kumar Rana had won bronze in 2010 Guangzhou Games.

SAPTAK, PRANAVI MAKE FINE START

Saptak Talwar shot a 4-under 66 in the first round of the Asian Games men's golf to be tied third and one shot off the leaders at the Kasugai Country Club East Course on Wednesday. Veer Ahlawat and Yuvraj Sandhu were both T23 after carding one-over 71. India were tied fifth in the men's team competition with an aggregate 3-under par.

In women, Pranavi Urs shot an excellent 4-under 66 to be second, three shots off China's leader Shannon Tan. Aditi Ashok, silver medalist at 2023 Hangzhou was tied 18 with Diksha Dagar after both shot 1-over 71s. India were tied sixth in the team competition with a total card of 3-under 137.

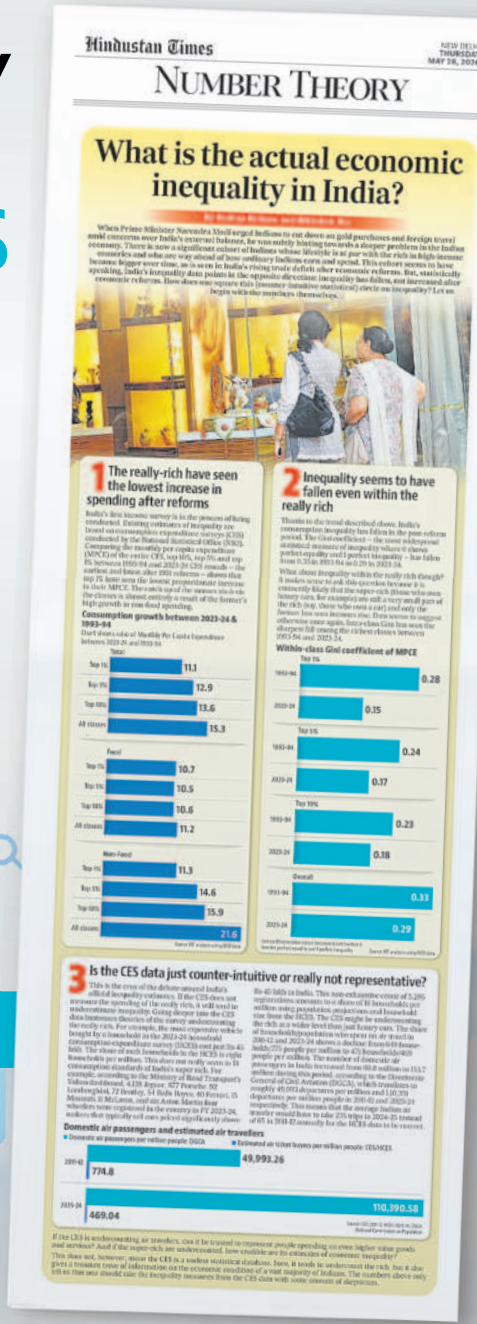
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Neeru Dhanda and Kynan Chenai pose with gold medals.

PTI

Neeru, Kynan and their tough road to mixed trap high

Shahid Judge

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MUMBAI: The celebration had begun even before the event was officially over at the Asian Games. Kynan Chenai rested the shotgun on his shoulder, awaiting his next attempt in the mixed trap team final. India still had three shots to go, but the gold medal had already been secured.

The first pump from the 35-year-old was not very subtle. It did not need to be.

Seconds later, he walked over to his partner Neeru Dhanda and patted her back even as she finished her shot and blew the smoke off the weapon. The team's coach Peter Wilson rushed to them as they embraced, marking the end of a highly successful campaign at the Aichi-Nagoya Games.

The win was the seasoned Chenai's third Asiad medal, after he won gold in the men's team and bronze in the individual event at the previous edition in Hangzhou. Neeru Dhanda too was now a three-time Asian Games medalist, the individual gold and team silver having come ahead of the mixed title.

With the triple medal hoist, Dhanda has been the most successful Indian athlete – across all sports – at this Asiad.

But it came the hard way. Days before she was scheduled to travel to Japan, she went down with a bout of Influenza B and was hospitalised for three days. As soon as she was discharged, she took the flight to Japan.

Already fatigued due to the illness, Dhanda had to overcome bad weather conditions in the individual final, but managed to prevail and become the first Indian woman to win an Asian Games gold medal in a shotgun event, as well as become the first (in shotgun) to win two titles in one Asiad.

"I was tired after being drenched in the rain for three hours," she told reporters at the Aichi Prefectural General Shooting Gallery on Wednesday. "My clothes were wet and cold, and I am still recovering from my illness after spending days in hospital. Competing on consecutive days was tough."

India were the fourth and last team to secure qualification into the final of the mixed trap event, scoring 136 to finish ahead of Chinese Taipei's 134. In the final, they started off poorly, hitting the clay pigeons just six times in the first series of 10 shots.

It put them in joint second place with China and Iran, with defending champions Qatar just ahead on seven.

That's when Chenai found some form and hit the target in each of his next 15 shots, while Dhanda battled the fatigue to hit her next 13 shots—missing only her last two. By then though it didn't matter as they had taken an unassailable lead over runners-up Qatar, and set a new Asian record of 34 in the final.

Dhanda, who made her Asian Games debut in Japan, is the second Indian to pick up three medals at this continental Games, along with runner Gulveer Singh – two silver (1,500m, 10,000m) and a bronze (5,000m).

The 26-year-old is following in her cousin Lakshay Sheoran's footsteps.

Sheoran's silver in men's individual trap at the 2018 Games had sparked Dhanda's interest. Her first foray into the sport was when she used his spare gun to practice on tin cans before moving to the Madhya Pradesh State Shooting Academy, where she trains under former Asian Games medalist Mansher Singh. Chenai, meanwhile, had his own demons to deal with coming into the competition on Wednesday.

His Asian Games outing had been rather disappointing with early exits in the individual and men's team events.

"My dad spoke to me yesterday, and didn't seem convinced (after the men's trap) that I would win gold," Chenai told reporters about the conversation with his father Darius, a two-time national trap champion. He added that he "stole" and used his father's gun barrel in the mixed trap final.

"I'm happy it turned out to be so lucky for me. I hope he doesn't ask me to return it." Whether it has to be returned or not, the memory of the gold medal won on Wednesday will stay with them for long.

medalstally						
COUNTRY	CHN	151	67	59	277	
2 JPN	50	77	73	200		
3 KOR	24	30	49	103		
4 UZB	16	19	19	54		
5 THA	12	10	12	34		
6 IRN	11	16	12	39		
7 BAH	11	5	5	21		
8 INDIA	10	21	29	60		
9 KAZ	9	16	31	56		
10 PKR	7	6	7	20		



Solitary gold and sporadic bright streaks in athletics

Shahid Judge

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MUMBAI: As India's women 4x400m relay quartet celebrated, there was a collective sigh of relief for the country's athletics fraternity. It took the second last event on the roster for India to finally earn a gold in athletics at the Aichi-Nagoya Asian Games.

The last event too brought a lot of hope in rainy Nagoya. The men's 4x400m relay team was, after all, defending champions. But with a time of 3:01.61 minutes at the Mizuho Park Athletics Stadium, the team managed a bronze. The timings of winners Japan (3:00.75) and second-placed Qatar (3:00.93) showed the Indian quartet lagged well behind.

In many ways, that final race was symbolic of India's athletic endeavours in Aichi-Nagoya, after the previous edition in Hangzhou where India bagged their best ever medal haul. Three years ago, India's target was to cross 100 medals. India finished with 106, and athletics delivered the lion's share, 29 medals (6 gold, 14 silver, 9 bronze).

This time, the numbers have not just declined – 24 medals

(1 gold, 9 silver, 14 bronze), the glaring difference is the gold and silver medal count, which pushed India to sixth in the athletics table.

The tally is usually the barometer of success at international meets. By that count, this was a disappointing campaign. The lone gold is the fewest India have won since the 2006 Asian Games.

India hasn't been able to build on the achievements in Hangzhou. At the 2026 Games in Aichi-Nagoya, India had 72 entries in athletics, the returns only one-third of the total number.

There were difficult weather conditions to deal with. There were unexpected injuries too – triple jumper and Hangzhou bronze medalist Praveen Chithravel pulled out injured without registering a jump.

The 100m hurdler Jyothi Yarraji has also struggled due to injury in the last two years. There were questions about her fitness heading to Games after she did not compete in the final domestic meet in Delhi, which was to assess the fitness and form of the athletes. The middle distance runners were a big letdown, Gulveer Singh's 1,500m silver the saving grace in that section.

How India's athletes performed

Here's a look at personal bests and national records achieved by the Indians in Nagoya

PLAYER	EVENT	PERSONAL BEST	FINAL POSITION
Unnathi Aiyappa	200m	23.33s (set in heats)	6th (23.46)
Parul Chaudhary	1500m	4:09.46s (in final)	4th
Anu Raghavan	400m hurdles	55.88s (in final)	5th
Vithya Ramraj*	400m hurdles	54.75s (in final)	BRONZE
Parul Chaudhary*	3000m steeplechase	9:08.67s (in final)	BRONZE
Ankita Dhyani	3000m steeplechase	9:19.24s (in final)	4th
Sawan Barwal*	Marathon	2:11:37s	SILVER
Dev Meena*	Pole vault	5.50m	7th
Yashvir Singh	Javelin	85.72m	SILVER
Seema Kaliramna	Discus throw	59.88m	4th
Tanya Chaudhary	Hammer throw	65.35m	4th
Gurindervir Singh, Sneha Gowda, Animesh Kujur, Harita Bhadra*	Mixed 4x100m relay	41.06s	BRONZE

*National Record

Amid the disappointments, 12 athletes registered personal bests, although not all translated into medals. This included Unnathi Aiyappa Bolland, who clocked her best of 23.33secs in women's 200m heats but finished sixth in the final at 23.46secs.

Parul Chaudhary in women's

1,500m finished fourth with a personal best of 4 mins, 09.46secs, Anu Raghavan clocked 55.88secs to finish fifth in the 400m hurdles final. The 3,000m steeplechase runner Ankita Dhyani (9:19.24, 4th), discus thrower Seema Kaliramna (4th, 59.88m) and Tanya Chaudhary in women's hammer

(4th, 65.35m) also set personal bests, while pole vaulter Dev Meena bettered his national record, but was still placed seventh on a countback after he and two others cleared the same 5.50m.

Some personal bests did result in medal-winning performances. In men's javelin, which took

place in pouring rain, Yashvir Singh threw a personal best of 85.72m to take silver, behind Sri Lanka's Rumesh Pathirige.

Parul Chaudhary in steeplechase bettered her own national record to claim bronze at 9:08.67mins, and again battled to bronze in 5,000m.

Marathon runner Sawan Barwal was brilliant, bettering his own national record to claim the silver medal, having improved upon Shivnath Singh's 48-year-old record only in April.

Last week, he clocked 2 hours, 11 min, 37secs, becoming only the fourth Indian to win an Asian Games marathon medal – and the first in 44 years.

And then there was Vithya Ramraj, who ran a sensational final leg in the victorious 4x400m women's relay team. She had broken PT Usha's 42-year-old record while claiming bronze in the women's 400m hurdles clocking 54.75secs. The mixed 4x100m relay team also set a national record while claiming bronze at 41.06secs. At Hangzhou, only Tejaswin Shankar (decathlon) and the men's 4x400m relay team set national records. This time, five new marks were set.



Injured Raphinha out of India match

BARCELONA: Raphinha was released by Brazil on Wednesday because of a thigh injury. The forward was replaced during the 4-2 win over Australia on Tuesday, when he scored from a penalty. The Brazilian Football Confederation said he has a minor muscle edema on the back of his right thigh and "as a precaution, the player will be released from the national team," CBF said. Brazil will play at India on Saturday.

Ronaldo unhappy with coach: Reports

LISBON: There was doubt about Cristiano Ronaldo playing for Portugal after he missed team training and local media talked about the superstar being unhappy with coach Jorge Jesus. He has not practiced with the team, doing only gym work, the Portuguese Football Federation said.

TT's ad hoc panel halts ranking points

NEW DELHI: The ad hoc panel overseeing administration of table tennis in India has stripped all national ranking tournaments of their official ranking points ahead of the Panchkula edition beginning Oct 6. Last month, the sports ministry derecognised TTFI, leading to the appointment of the ad hoc committee under Indu Puri as the chairperson.

Djokovic grinds out opening-round win

BEIJING: Novak Djokovic held his nerve during a tense tie-break to beat Nuno Borges 6-3, 7-6 (7/2) at the China Open on Wednesday, extending his extraordinary unbeaten streak in Beijing. The 39-year-old Serbian was struggling physically but pushed through the second-set decider.

Shadab Khan likely to lead Pak in T20Is

KARACHI: Shadab Khan has emerged as the front runner to take over Pakistan's T20 captaincy from Salman Ali Agha, who faces axe from the squad for the shortest format. Information gathered from Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB) insiders on Wednesday indicated that big changes have been lined up.

In Guwahati run fest, Gill hits fastest ODI double ton

India cruise to 406/2 with Rohit too hitting a ton, pulling off the second-highest chase in ODI history

Somshuvra Laha

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KOLKATA: It was a one-day game but you wouldn't know it from the scoreboard. A run rate of 9.33, hundreds from Shubman Gill and Rohit Sharma, Gill converting his century into the highest ever double by an ODI captain and still turning in a strike rate of 167.66, courtesy 26 boundaries—second most in an ODI innings—and eight towering sixes, all from the comfort of a Guwahati pitch that any flatter would have tempted flight arrival diversion from the nearby airport.

Bowlers were the mass casualty left in the wake of more than 800 runs scored as five batters plundered hundreds in a game where West Indies couldn't prevent India pull off the second highest chase in ODI history to go 2-0 up in the three-match series.

For a while, 406 looked less like a target than a provocation. West Indies had set India a mountain and then watched, with increasing disbelief, as Gill and Rohit Sharma began to dismantle it. The opening partnership reached 255—the second-highest opening stand in India's ODI history—before West Indies finally found a way through. More strikingly, it eclipsed Rohit Sharma and Shikhar Dhawan's 210 against Pakistan in the 2018 Asia Cup as India's highest opening partnership in a successful chase.

There was little that resembled a conventional pursuit of a huge total. Gill and Rohit simply went about their work. Rohit, as so often, was the disruptor. Anything short was pulled, anything wide was cut and the occasional error in length disappeared into the stands.

West Indies played to his strengths, bowling quicker and getting hit longer. Gill took a little longer to settle, allowing his partner to set the tempo, before accelerating so violently that the distinction between the two innings eventually disappeared.

By the end, both had tons. Gill's came first, from 62 balls—the fastest by an Indian against West Indies, beating Virender Sehwag's 69-ball effort in 2011. It was also his 11th ODI hundred, reached in only 68 innings, putting him behind only Hashim Amla and Quinton de Kock for the number of innings required to reach that mark.

Rohit followed, bringing up his hundred from 72 balls. It was his



Highest ODI totals involving India

TEAM	SCORE	WICKETS	RESULT
South Africa v India (Oct 25, 2015)	438	●●●●●	4 won
India v West Indies (Dec 8, 2011)	418	●●●●●	5 won
India v Sri Lanka (Dec 15, 2009)	414	●●●●●●●	7 won
India v Bermuda (Mar 19, 2007)	413	●●●●●	5 won
Sri Lanka v India (Dec 15, 2009)	411	●●●●●●●●	8 lost
India v Netherlands (Nov 12, 2023)	410	●●●●●	4 won
India v Bangladesh (Dec 10, 2022)	409	●●●●●●●●	8 won
West Indies v India (Sept 30, 2026)	405	●●●●●●●	7 lost
India v West Indies (Sept 30, 2026)	406	●●	2 won

FASTEST ODI DOUBLE HUNDREDS

SHUBMAN GILL AGAINST WEST INDIES (2026)	223*	117 balls (To get to two hundred)
ISHAN KISHAN AGAINST BANGLADESH (2022)	210	126 balls
GLENN MAXWELL AGAINST AFGHANISTAN (2023)	201*	128 balls

*Not out

second-fastest ODI century, and on his way, he also crossed the 12,000-run mark in ODIs, a territory previously occupied by only Sachin Tendulkar and Virat Kohli among Indians. The partnership had become a kind of running argument between two generations. Rohit, the veteran who has spent much of his career redefining what an ODI opening innings can look like, and Gill, the captain and heir apparent, were not merely surviving the chase. They were setting its terms.

West Indies tried pace, they tried spin. They changed lengths and fields but also conceded a

staggering 22 extras. There were moments when West Indies might have wondered whether the game had somehow become detached from its target. India reached 200 in only 21.1 overs, the quickest they had ever done so in an ODI. At 250 after 25 overs, they had reached the milestone faster than any side in an uninterrupted ODI chase.

Eventually Jayden Seales broke through, trapping Rohit leg before on 101, ending an opening stand that had already rewritten the record books. A target of 406 had demanded something extraordinary, but Gill and Rohit supplied it with an ease that made the

extraordinary look almost routine. West Indies were in for more misery though as Gill converted his hundred into a double, reaching the mark in 117 balls and at a strike rate of 171. This is where Gill stamped his class as a batter who wouldn't leave the job of finishing the game for anyone else. The intense humidity forced cramps but he battled it to stay unbeaten on 223 and ensure India won with 39 balls to spare.

To say the West Indies were left shell shocked would be an understatement, especially after John Campbell (101 off 68 balls), Shai Hope (104 off 94 balls) and Amir

Jangoo (114 off 77 balls) helped the tourists put up their highest ever ODI total, also the third highest score conceded by India.

Campbell set the tone of the match with his aggression and Hope anchored the innings. Jangoo initially played the supporting role, scoring 59 off 54 balls, before exploding to his hundred in 16 more balls. But everything paled in comparison to the aggression Gill and Rohit rolled out to leave West Indies completely disoriented.

Brief scores: WI 405/7 (Campbell 101, Hope 104, Jangoo 114). India 406/2 in 43.3 ovs (Rohit 101, Gill 223*). **India won by 8 wkts.**

Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of



A quiz on the week's development.



Lovlina in Asiad final as boxers continue to shine

Avishek Roy

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NEW DELHI: Lovlina Borgohain was in trouble after losing the first-round card against Kazakhstan's Natalya Bogdanova in the boxing middleweight (75kg) semifinal at the Asian Games. Bogdanova, the 70kg world champion, was scoring with her stinging jab. Lovlina, however, made a gritty comeback in the next two rounds, producing a fine display of counter-attacking boxing to storm into the final.

The Tokyo Olympics bronze medalist was quick to defend and counter, landing clean punches in the second round. In the third, she was more aggressive, while Bogdanova's punches were falling short. It was still a close contest, and Lovlina won by a split decision. She is now among three Indian boxers who will be fighting for gold on Friday.

Lovlina, 28, will face China's Ziyi Bao and will be aiming to improve on the silver medal she won at the last edition of the Games. Parveen Hooda will take on Paris Olympic bronze medalist Chen Nien-chin in the 65kg final, while feisty Ankush Panghal will fight Korea's Kim Min-seong in the men's 80kg final.

Two more Indian boxers lost in the semifinals on Wednesday to take bronze. One of them, Priya Ghanghas, gave a superb performance against former world champion Yang Chengyu of China. Though she lost by a split verdict, the 20-year-old showed why she is so highly rated.

In what turned out to be the most exciting contest of the day, the two exchanged furious punches throughout the three rounds. There was no let-up as a fearless Priya responded to Yang's punches with some solid blows of her own.

Priya, the Asian Championships gold medalist, has shown fine form. She was missing her



Lovlina Borgohain in action on Wednesday. BFI

punches in the second round, but in the third, Priya boxed from close range, landing combinations.

"It's my first Asian Games and winning a bronze medal for India is satisfying. Next time I hope to win a gold medal," Priya said.

Kapil Pokhariya lost to world champion Turabek Khabibullaev of Uzbekistan in the 90kg semifinal, settling for a bronze.

Impressive show by boxers

In a campaign where some sports have performed below par, the boxers have landed their punches well. India have already improved on their medal haul from the last Asian Games where they won four medals, confirming six medals this time. With three gold-medal bouts to come, India will be looking to the boxing contingent to boost the tally.

Women's team coach Santiago Nieve had his eyes set on a gold medal from the ring, which was missing from the previous campaign. He will have two opportunities to achieve that target.

The men's team showing is much better than at 2023 Hangzhou Games, where they had only Narender Berwal's bronze to show. In Aichi-Nagoya, it is bronze for Narender and Kapil while Ankush is in the final.

I had thoughts of quitting chess, it was that hard: Olympiad star Savitha

Susan Ninan

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BENGALURU: Shortly after the Indian Olympiad team was announced, 19-year-old Savitha Shri's phone buzzed. It was a message from Judit Polgar. The Hungarian legend wrote: 'This is your chance.'

Savitha turned those words into rocket fuel. Playing her debut Olympiad, the international master from Chennai went unbeaten, scored 9/10 and won India's only individual gold on Board 5 at the Fide Chess Olympiad in Samarkand. She won eight games and drew two, helping the defending champions return with a bronze.

On most days, she was the last one standing, with the team's fortunes pivoting on her game. Speaking to HT in an interview on Tuesday, Savitha said: "Throughout the tournament, I managed to swindle my opponents. Of course, it was also huge pressure. Most rounds, my games went on after everyone else's. Almost every day I was playing for five-six hours, so, it was very tiring as well. I'm happy I could help the team win bronze. That's what's important."

After four wins in a row, Savitha was rested for the Round 5 match against Poland, which India went on to lose—the only match the team lost in the entire tournament. "We lost to Poland last time too, but still won the gold. Both Vantika and I were on 3/3 when she was rested, and I played the fourth round instead. We were both in good form. Also, most of my opponents until then were not too strong," says Savitha, who went on to score 7/7. "At that point, it was a tough call, and I too thought it was right for Vantika to play. Of course, now it's pretty clear that I should have played that match. I was in great form...any-



India's Savitha Shri during the Chess Olympiad. FIDE

thing could have happened."

The final two rounds—against China and Georgia—had Savitha doing what it takes to get India on to the podium. She calls her "fighting ability" her strength. "China was the most difficult round for us. Matches usually come down to Board 3 and 4. Vantika (on Board 3) was playing extremely well, it's unfortunate she lost."

Vantika had an equal position with White before things went downhill. The cameras caught a visibly shocked and disappointed Savitha, hands cupped over her mouth, glancing at Vantika's board to discover her teammate was losing. "Yeah, everybody was telling me about it," Savitha laughs. "I wish I was better at controlling my emotions. When I saw she was losing, I was kind of mad because I thought we both were winning and the team would have a good chance to win gold. So, it was hard for me to suddenly see her losing."

If Savitha lost her game too,

India would have lost the match and been out of medal contention. She blundered a pawn in an equal position but fought back and won against WGM Zhai Mo, taking India to a 2-2 draw against eventual champions, China, heading into the final round.

For Savitha to get here—an Olympiad hero—has taken a lot of will, some self-loathing and thoughts of quitting chess. The past two years were rough. She was putting in the work, but there was little to show for it: her rating had dropped, sponsors had stopped backing her, tournament invitations had dried up and she found herself spiralling, questioning whether she should continue in the sport.

"I had thoughts of quitting chess. It was that hard. I lost whatever I had—sponsors, tournament invitations. It was difficult for me to process what had happened. My play wasn't improving. I was losing a lot of rating and I wasn't win-

ning any tournaments. It's this vicious cycle, because when your rating drops, your confidence also takes a hit when you play someone higher rated. So that was affecting my play. My parents were a huge support during that phase."

What helped her climb out of the rut, she says, is a switch in mindset. "At some point I stopped thinking about it. I stopped thinking about what people think of me or what was on social media. I just kept working hard and the results are finally here."

In the open section, reigning world champion Gukesh, manning board 4, had a decent run. He finished with an individual silver. They both have known each other since they were kids. "We were competing and sometimes winning together in the same age category. So yeah, we sort of went through the early part of our career together. Of course, back then too, he was a lot stronger than I was. He would always have the answers really fast, during the endgame session we did together with Karsten Muller. During this Olympiad we got time together, congratulated each other on the tournament we both were having and all of us played some card games together. Of course, now he's the world champion, a superstar. He's always been kind and humble. I'm just happy for him."

While Gukesh has a world title to defend in November, Savitha plans to play the World Junior Championship that month. She has GM norms to chase and rating climbs to focus on. Savitha gained 23 Elo points from this Olympiad and is now 2405 in the live ratings which moves her up to world No 41 in the women's rankings. "Getting the Grandmaster title is one of my goals right now," she says.

Savitha was away playing in Biel when she got to know she had

made the Olympiad team. She called her parents right away and was thrilled to receive a text from Judit, whom she describes as an "idol". Two years ago, Savitha together with six other Indian female players spent a fortnight in Budapest, training for eight hours a day at a camp run by Judit.

What weighed most on her mind when she was picked, was the player she was replacing—GM Harika Dronavalli, a veteran of 10 Olympiads, who was part of the 2024 gold-medal winning team as well. Harika, mother to a young daughter, chose to sit this Olympiad out, presumably to make way for young names like Savitha.

"The Olympiad seemed like a huge chance. The one thing on my mind was whether I'll be able to prove myself, because I was taking Harika akka's place. I was in touch with her throughout the tournament. I was asking her for advice. She's such a sweetheart. She was always there for me whenever I needed her. I'm really happy I could make her proud."

The Indian women's team had grandmasters Arjun Kalyan and Diptayan Ghosh helping them. On their way to the playing venue, Savitha would often turn to Arjun for a last-minute brush up on the move orders. "Everyone on the team worked really hard. I harassed our seconds a lot and I don't think we could have asked for a better captain than Swayams."

For Savitha, who is studying marketing management at M.O.P Vaishnav College in Chennai, this Olympiad has been a defining moment. Her career may well come to be viewed in two parts—before and after Samarkand.

"I suppose this performance has brought me some recognition in the chess world. I want to keep proving myself. We'll see how it goes. This is only the beginning."

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